

Aquifer Open Study Notes (Profiles)

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Aaron

Aaron was Moses' older brother (see [Exodus 6:20; 7:7](#)). He played an important role in establishing Israel and its institutions, especially the priesthood. He first appears after Moses' calling at the burning bush ([Exodus 3:1-4:17](#)). Moses hesitated to accept his mission from God, saying he was not able to lead the Israelites out of Egypt because he struggled with speech ([Exodus 4:10](#)). Despite God's reassurances, Moses continued to resist until God appointed Aaron to speak for him. After that, Aaron often stood by Moses, speaking to the Israelite leaders and demanding that Pharaoh allow the Israelites to leave Egypt ([Exodus 5:1-5](#)).

During the Israelites' time in the wilderness, God chose Aaron and his sons to be priests ([Exodus 28:1-5; 29:1-46; Leviticus 8:1-36](#)). Aaron became Israel's first high priest. His role was important on the Day of Atonement. This was the only day when the high priest entered the Most Holy Place to cleanse it from Israel's sins ([Leviticus 16](#)). Before doing this, the high priest had to offer a sacrifice for his own sins.

Aaron was not a perfect leader. While Moses was on Mount Sinai getting the law from God, Aaron helped the people make an idol ([Exodus 32](#)). When Moses came back, Aaron made weak excuses and blamed the people. This event led to the death of three thousand Israelites and a plague.

Aaron and his sister, Miriam, once wrongly questioned Moses' authority. This led to Miriam temporarily having leprosy ([Numbers 12](#)). Later, when other Levites questioned Aaron's authority, God confirmed Aaron's role by making his staff bloom with almond blossoms ([Numbers 17](#)). However, because Moses and Aaron questioned God's authority ([Numbers 20:1-13](#)), they both died in the wilderness and did not enter the Promised Land ([Numbers 20:22-29](#)).

Jesus is now the Great High Priest, with more authority and power than Aaron (see [Hebrews 7-10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 4:14-17, 27-31; 6:20-27; 7:1-2; 28:1-5; 32:1-25; Numbers 12:1-12; 20:1-13, 22-29; Acts 7:39-41](#)

Abiathar

Abiathar served as high priest during the reigns of David and Solomon. He first met David before David became king. When David fled from Saul, he stopped in the city of Nob. Pretending to follow Saul's orders, David obtained food and supplies from the priests there. Saul found out and became so angry that he killed all the priests except one; only Abiathar survived.

Abiathar was one of the first from Saul's administration to support David. His support was strong. He represented Eli's priestly line and brought the holy ephod with the Urim and Thummim ([Exodus 28:29-30](#)). (The ephod was a sacred garment worn by the high priest, and the Urim and Thummim were used for seeking God's guidance.) This allowed him to seek God's guidance for David during crises ([1 Samuel 23:1-12; 30:7-8](#)).

After David became king, Abiathar served as a priest alongside Zadok, who was not from Eli's line ([1 Chronicles 6:8; 18:16; 24:3](#)). Both served David well. During Absalom's rebellion, they informed David about events in the capital ([2 Samuel 15:27-37; 17:15-16](#)).

In David's old age, Abiathar wrongly supported Adonijah's attempt to become king instead of his father. Zadok stayed loyal to David and supported Solomon ([1 Kings 1:5-8](#)). As a result, once Solomon became king, he removed Abiathar's priestly authority and sent him to his estate in Anathoth, a village about four miles northeast of Jerusalem ([1 Kings 2:26-27](#)). Zadok became the high priest, and his descendants inherited that role instead of Abiathar's. This fulfilled the prophecy the Lord gave at Shiloh about Eli's descendants ([1 Kings 2:27](#); see [1 Samuel 2:27-36](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 22:20-23; 23:6, 9; 30:7; 2 Samuel 15:27-37; 17:15; 1 Kings 1:1-2:35; 1 Chronicles 15:11](#)

Abishai

Abishai was a strong and successful warrior and a leader in David's army. He was David's nephew, the

son of David's sister Zeruiah, and the brother of Joab and Asahel ([1 Chronicles 2:13-16](#)).

Abishai was very loyal to David and often suggested violence against David's enemies. God allowed David and Abishai to enter Saul's war camp while the troops slept. Abishai wanted to kill Saul, but David stopped him. Later, during Absalom's revolt, David had to leave Jerusalem. Shimei, a member of Saul's family, cursed the king, and Abishai wanted to kill Shimei ([2 Samuel 16:5-9](#)). David refused this idea twice ([2 Samuel 16:10-13](#); [19:18-23](#)). Abishai and his brothers' desire for revenge also appeared earlier: After Saul's general, Abner, killed Abishai's brother Asahel in self-defense, Joab and Abishai killed Abner in revenge ([2 Samuel 3:22-30](#)).

Abishai was brave and skilled. He once killed three hundred soldiers in one battle. Because of this, he became the leader of the Thirty, a group of highly skilled warriors, ranking just below the Three ([1 Chronicles 11:20-21](#)). Abishai also achieved a major victory over the Edomites ([1 Chronicles 18:12-13](#)). In a battle with the Philistines, Abishai saved David's life by killing the giant Ishbi-benob ([2 Samuel 21:15-17](#)). Abishai also led the army, and when it split for strategic reasons, he led one group while his brother Joab led the other ([2 Samuel 10:1-19](#); [18:1-18](#)). Their military efforts were usually very successful.

Joab's actions eventually led to his death. However, we do not learn about Abishai meeting the same fate. Like Joab, Abishai was also a violently impulsive military leader.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 26:6-12](#); [2 Samuel 2:18](#); [3:30](#), [39](#); [10:10-14](#); [16:9-12](#); [18:1-8](#); [19:21-23](#); [20:6-10](#); [21:17](#); [23:18-19](#); [1 Chronicles 2:16](#); [11:20-21](#); [18:12-13](#); [19:11-15](#)

Abner

Abner, son of Ner, was King Saul's cousin and his general ([1 Samuel 14:49-52](#)). Under Abner's command, Saul's armies won key battles against the Philistines ([1 Samuel 17:1-58](#)). Abner also dined with David and Jonathan at the king's table ([1 Samuel 20:24-25](#)). However, Jonathan and David both surpassed Abner in Saul's army.

David embarrassed Abner once ([1 Samuel 26:1-25](#)). Saul was chasing David to kill him. Saul and his

troops camped in a circle, with Saul sleeping in the center and Abner beside him. Abishai and David sneaked into the camp and could have killed Saul. Instead, they took some items from beside Saul's head. After retreating, David shouted to wake Saul and Abner and criticized Abner for being careless.

After Saul and Jonathan died, Abner supported Saul's son Ishbosheth ([2 Samuel 2:8-12](#)) while the tribe of Judah made David king. During this period, Abner held the real power in the north. When Ishbosheth accused Abner of having relations with one of Saul's concubines, Abner handed control of the northern kingdom to David. Ishbosheth was later murdered ([2 Samuel 4:1-12](#)).

During the battle between Ishbosheth and David, Abner had to kill Joab's brother Asahel in self-defense. He did not want to kill Asahel and had warned him to turn back ([2 Samuel 2:18-32](#)). Joab later murdered Abner in a planned act of revenge ([2 Samuel 3:22-30](#)), which David could not stop (see [2 Samuel 3:38-39](#)). David honored Abner with a eulogy (a speech of praise commemorating his life and achievements), public mourning, and a state funeral ([2 Samuel 3:31-37](#)). Later, David remembered these events and ensured Joab was punished for the murder ([1 Kings 2:5-6](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 14:49-52](#); [17:55-58](#); [26:5-16](#); [2 Samuel 2:8-29](#); [3:6-39](#); [1 Kings 2:5](#), [32](#)

Abraham

"By faith Abraham, when called to go to a place he would later receive as his inheritance, obeyed and went, without knowing where he was going...By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac on the altar" ([Hebrews 11:8](#), [17](#)). These key events in Abraham's life show the faithful obedience for which he is best known.

God summoned Abram from the city of Ur to lead God's people. Abram's family ties are in [Genesis 11:26-32](#). Terah had three sons:

1. Abram
2. Nahor
3. Haran

Terah left Ur with Abram, Abram's wife Sarai, and Lot, whose father, Haran, had died. On his way to Canaan, Terah settled in the city of Haran ([Genesis 11:31](#)). God called Abram to a new land while he

was still in Ur ([Acts 7:2-4](#)). God told Abram, "Leave your country, your kindred, and your father's household, and go to the land I will show you" ([Genesis 12:1](#)). God blessed Abram by making a covenant (special agreement) with him that included promises of great blessing, many descendants, and a new land ([Genesis 12:1-3](#)). These promises later saved Israel from destruction when they often failed to keep their covenant with God (see [Leviticus 26:40-45](#)).

Abram left Haran when he was seventy-five years old. Upon entering Canaan, he first went to Shechem, a Canaanite city between Mount Gerizim and Mount Ebal. God appeared to Abram near the oak of Moreh, which was likely a Canaanite place of worship. Abram built altars there and near Bethel ([Genesis 12:6-8](#)). He proclaimed the one true God at these places of false worship. Abram later moved to Hebron by the oaks of Mamre and built another altar to worship God ([Genesis 13:18](#)).

When God promised blessings to Abram again in a vision ([Genesis 15:1](#)), Abram said he was still childless because Sarai could not have children ([Genesis 11:30](#)). Eliezer of Damascus was his heir ([Genesis 15:2](#)). The Nuzi documents, found in the ancient Mesopotamian city of Nuzi, explain this. According to Hurrian custom, a wealthy childless couple could adopt an heir, often a slave, who would handle their burial and mourning. However, if a natural son was born after adopting the slave-heir, the son would replace him. It seems Abram adopted Eliezer this way, but God promised Abram's own son would be his heir ([Genesis 15:4](#)).

Abram's life was marked by his belief in the Lord, who considered him righteous due to his faith ([Genesis 15:6](#); see [Romans 4:3](#); [Galatians 3:6](#); [James 2:23](#)). Abram was not declared righteous because he was without sin. He sometimes failed to do what was right—twice he lied about Sarai out of fear, and he tried to have a son with Hagar instead of waiting for God ([Genesis 16:1-5](#)). However, he consistently returned to faith as the main principle of his life before God.

Abram was eighty-six years old when Ishmael was born to Sarai's servant, Hagar. When Abram was ninety-nine, the Lord appeared to him and confirmed His promise of a son and blessings ([Genesis 17](#)). He added circumcision as a sign of this covenant ([Genesis 17:9-14](#)). God also changed Abram's name to Abraham and Sarai's name to Sarah ([Genesis 17:5, 15](#)). Abraham laughed at the promise of another son ([Genesis 17:17](#)). Soon after, the Lord appeared again to Abraham ([Genesis](#)

[18:1-15](#)) and repeated the promise of a son. This time, Sarah laughed in disbelief ([Genesis 18:10-15](#)). Abraham was one hundred years old, and Sarah was ninety when the Lord fulfilled His promise ([Genesis 21:1](#)). The long-promised son was born and was named Isaac, meaning "he laughs."

The ultimate test of Abraham's faith occurred when God told him to sacrifice Isaac ([Genesis 22:1-19](#)). Abraham obeyed, trusting that God would fulfill His plans (see [Hebrews 11:17-19](#)). As Abraham was about to use the knife, an angel stopped him and provided a ram to sacrifice instead of Isaac. Abraham's faith was proven ([Genesis 22:10-13](#)).

Christians see Isaac's sacrifice as a sign of God providing his only Son, Jesus Christ, as a sacrifice for the world's sins. God fulfilled his promise to Abraham through Jesus Christ, who offers salvation to all who have faith ([Romans 4:16-17](#)), making believers Abraham's spiritual descendants ([Galatians 3:29](#)). Abraham's life shows that God is faithful and deserves belief and obedience. The full meaning of God's promise was realized when the gospel (the good news about Jesus) was shared with all nations, and people from all families of the earth responded in faith (see [Galatians 3:6-9](#)).

Abraham was called God's friend ([2 Chronicles 20:7](#); [James 2:23](#)). Everyone who lives by faith should try to live like him, trusting God's guidance and support each day. Abraham is one of many great "witnesses" to a life of faith ([Hebrews 12:1](#); see [Hebrews 11](#)). He inspires believers to keep their faith because we know God is faithful.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 11:26-25:11](#); [26:2-5](#); [Exodus 3:15-16](#); [6:3](#); [32:13](#); [Joshua 24:2-3](#); [1 Chronicles 1:27-34](#); [2 Chronicles 20:7](#); [Isaiah 29:22](#); [41:8](#); [51:1-2](#); [Ezekiel 33:24](#); [Matthew 1:1-2](#); [3:9](#); [8:11](#); [22:31-33](#); [Luke 16:19-31](#); [John 8:31-58](#); [Acts 7:2-8](#); [Romans 4:1-23](#); [9:5-9](#); [11:16-17](#); [Galatians 3:6-29](#); [Hebrews 6:13-15](#); [11:8-12](#), [17-19](#); [James 2:21-23](#)

Absalom

Absalom was the son of King David. The Bible says Absalom was "handsome and highly praised" ([2 Samuel 14:25-26](#)). When his sister Tamar was raped and abandoned by their half-brother Amnon, Absalom provided care and protection for her ([2 Samuel 13:1-20](#)). He might have expected David to punish Amnon, but David did nothing ([2 Samuel](#)

[13:21](#)). For two years, Absalom's anger and hatred increased ([2 Samuel 13:22](#)). Then he murdered Amnon and fled to his grandfather, King Talmai of Geshur ([2 Samuel 13:23-39](#)).

After three years, Joab convinced David to bring Absalom back. However, David neither punished nor reconciled with him. Absalom lived in Jerusalem for two years with privilege but felt isolated. Then he insisted on seeing the king. They met and appeared to reconcile ([2 Samuel 14:28-33](#)).

For Absalom, this meeting might have been a step toward the throne. Afterward, he started a campaign to weaken the people's trust in David ([2 Samuel 15:1-6](#)). Eventually, Absalom's deceitful ways succeeded. He started a rebellion and gathered supporters in Hebron from all over Israel. By the time David heard about what Absalom was doing, he could only flee Jerusalem ([2 Samuel 15:13-37](#); see [Psalm 3](#)).

David's wisest adviser was Ahithophel. When Absalom arrived in Jerusalem, Ahithophel joined Absalom and advised a quick attack while David was weak. However, Hushai, David's secret agent, suggested gathering more troops and attacking with overwhelming force. This advice appealed to Absalom's ego, but it was a fatal mistake. Both advisers knew it was wrong to give experienced warriors like David and his men time to gather strength, scout, and plan.

By the time Absalom led his forces across the Jordan River to fight in the forest of Ephraim, David and his loyal forces were well-rested and led by the capable Joab, Abishai, and Ittai from Gath. David's men outmaneuvered Absalom's larger forces and defeated them. Absalom fled on a mule, but his long hair got caught in a tree. Joab and his men found Absalom hanging helplessly and killed him, despite David's order to show him mercy ([2 Samuel 18:1-18](#)).

Absalom's death shocked David, and his grief almost pushed away those who risked their lives to stop Absalom's rebellion against the kingdom ([2 Samuel 18:33-19:8](#)). Absalom had reasons to be unhappy with David's rule. However, instead of following his father's example of trusting in the Lord and respecting the anointed king, Absalom started a rebellion that led to his own death ([1 Samuel 24:5-11](#); [26:5-24](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 3:3](#); [2 Samuel 13:1-19:10](#); [1 Kings 2:7; 15:2, 10](#); [1 Chronicles 3:2](#); [Psalm 3:1](#)

Adam and Eve

Adam was the first man and the father of humanity. God created the first couple in his image to fill the earth and manage creation ([Genesis 1:26-31](#)). God made Adam from the earth and gave him life ([Genesis 2:7](#)). Adam's tasks included:

- Tending the garden where God placed him ([Genesis 2:15](#))
- Naming the animals ([Genesis 2:19-20](#))
- Following God's instructions ([Genesis 1:28](#); [2:16-17](#))

God created the first woman to be Adam's companion and helper ([Genesis 2:18-22](#)). Eve's creation from Adam's rib shows the unity God wanted for marriage ([Genesis 2:23-25](#)). She is honored as "the mother of all the living" ([Genesis 3:20](#)).

After the serpent tricked Eve into rejecting God's rule, Adam also rebelled ([Genesis 3:1-6](#)). Their deliberate disobedience damaged their relationship ([Genesis 3:7](#)). Their disobedience also separated them from God. God looked for Adam after his rebellion. He and Eve were hiding among the trees, already feeling the separation ([Genesis 3:8](#)).

When God questioned him, Adam blamed Eve and indirectly blamed God ([Genesis 3:12](#)). Their rebellion led to pain, strained relationships, difficulty in managing the earth, and both physical and spiritual death ([Genesis 3:16-19, 22-24](#)). Despite this, God provided animal skins to cover Adam and Eve ([Genesis 3:21](#)). God promised that Eve's descendants would defeat Satan ([Genesis 3:15](#); see [Romans 16:20](#); [Revelation 12:1-9](#); [20:1-10](#)).

Adam was a historical person ([Genesis 4:25](#); [5:1-5](#); [1 Chronicles 1:1](#); [Hosea 6:7](#); [Luke 3:38](#); [Romans 5:14](#); [1 Corinthians 15:22, 45](#); [1 Timothy 2:13-14](#); [Jude 1:14](#)). Adam also symbolizes all of humanity. God's commands in [Genesis 1:26-30](#) and curses in [3:16-19](#) affected not only Adam and Eve but everyone. Adam represents the separation from God that all people experience.

The apostle Paul compared people represented by Adam, the first man, with those who follow Jesus Christ, the "last Adam" ([Romans 5:12-21](#); [1 Corinthians 15:45-50](#); see also [Romans 8:5-11, 20-22](#)). People represented by Adam live like him. They share in his sin, separation from God and creation, and spiritual death. In contrast, those who follow Jesus live by faith in him. They are remade in Christ's image and become "new people" who share in a new creation (see [Romans 8:29](#); [1 Corinthians 15:49](#); [2 Corinthians 5:17](#); [Galatians 6:15](#)). Jesus removes the barriers that Adam and Eve created ([Romans 5:1](#); [2 Corinthians 5:19](#); [Galatians 3:27-28](#); [Ephesians 2:14-16](#)). Jesus restores what they lost.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 1:26-31](#); [2:4-3:24](#); [4:25-5:5](#); [Hosea 6:6-7](#); [Luke 3:38](#); [Romans 5:12-21](#); [1 Corinthians 15:22, 45-49](#); [1 Timothy 2:13-14](#)

Ahab

Ahab, the eighth king of Israel, took over the northern kingdom from his strong father, Omri ([1 Kings 16:27-28](#)). He ruled Israel from 874 to 853 BC. Ahab married Jezebel, the daughter of King Ethbaal of Sidon. Influenced by her, Ahab started worshiping Baal instead of the Lord ([1 Kings 16:29-33](#)).

Ahab won several battles. He defeated the Arameans ([1 Kings 20:1-34](#)). In 853 BC, he led a group of kings against the Assyrian king Shalmaneser III, winning the Battle of Qarqar. However, the Old Testament shares little good news about Ahab, who betrayed God. God sent the prophet Elijah to challenge Ahab, Jezebel, and their prophets and to reaffirm the true God's supremacy ([1 Kings 17:1](#); [18:1-46](#)).

Ahab not only betrayed the Lord, but he also treated his people badly, as shown in the story of Naboth and his vineyard ([1 Kings 21:1-29](#)). In Israel, people owned their land as a gift from God. When Ahab wanted to take Naboth's vineyard and Naboth refused, Ahab became frustrated. Jezebel, who knew a different kind of kingship where kings took what they wanted, helped Ahab by telling lies about Naboth to have him killed. Naboth was executed on false charges, and Ahab took the land. However, the Lord did not let Ahab escape punishment. He sent Elijah to announce a death sentence for Ahab and his family.

War began again with Aram, and Ahab asked Jehoshaphat, the southern king, to be his ally ([1 Kings 22:2-4](#); [2 Chronicles 18:1-3](#)). Jehoshaphat still believed in the Lord, so he convinced Ahab to consult God's prophet Micaiah. Micaiah predicted that this battle would end Ahab's life ([1 Kings 22:5-28](#); [2 Chronicles 18:4-27](#)). Ahab tried to avoid this by wearing ordinary armor and having Jehoshaphat wear royal battle clothes as a decoy, but he could not deceive God. An archer's arrow hit the joint of Ahab's armor, and he died, "according to the word that the LORD had spoken" ([1 Kings 22:38](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 16:29-22:53](#); [2 Chronicles 18:1-34](#); [Micah 6:16](#)

Ahaz

Ahaz ruled Judah during a difficult time, from 743 to 715 BC. His father, Jotham, and his son, Hezekiah, were praised for following the Lord (see [2 Kings 15:32-38](#); [2 Chronicles 27:1-9](#); and [2 Kings 18:1-8](#)). However, Ahaz was wicked and even sacrificed one of his sons to false gods.

There was a lot of conflict during Ahaz's reign. King Pekah of Israel and King Rezin of Aram (Syria) wanted him to join a group against Assyria, but he refused. So, Pekah and Rezin attacked Judah and won major victories, which greatly scared Ahaz. Isaiah the prophet encouraged Ahaz to trust in the Lord, but Ahaz refused ([Isaiah 7](#)).

Ahaz showed his lack of trust in the true God by asking Tiglath-pileser III for help ([2 Kings 16:7-9](#)). Ahaz made Judah dangerously dependent on Assyria, turning it into a vassal state. The Assyrian king then defeated the Arameans in a two-year campaign that lasted from 734 to 732 BC and killed Rezin. He subdued Israel and added large areas of Pekah's land to the Assyrian Empire ([2 Kings 15:29](#)).

Ahaz became a devoted follower of Assyria. He adopted many religious practices based on Assyrian examples. Ahaz visited Tiglath-pileser III in Damascus. There, he saw an Assyrian altar and sent a model of it to Jerusalem. A similar altar was built there, replacing the original bronze altar ([2 Kings 16:10-18](#)). Several other changes to the temple also show Ahaz's departure from faith in the Lord.

Ahaz shows why the people of Judah were eventually exiled. He did not act properly as a king ([Deuteronomy 17:14-20](#)). He also did not worship the Lord. When he died, his son Hezekiah became king ([2 Kings 16:20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Kings 15:38-16:20](#); [2 Chronicles 27:9-28:27](#); [Isaiah 7:1-25](#)

Annas and Caiaphas

Annas and Caiaphas were both high priests during Jesus' time. They played key roles in condemning Jesus to death.

Annas was the Jewish high priest around AD 6 to 15. Even after the Roman procurator of Judea removed him, he remained very powerful and influential in the Jewish high council. People still called him "high priest" fifteen to twenty years later ([Luke 3:2](#); [Acts 4:6](#)). This might be because Jews believed high priests held their position for life. Five of his sons and his son-in-law, Caiaphas, became high priests after him. According to the Gospel of John, when Jesus was arrested, he was first taken to Annas for questioning before being handed over to Caiaphas for the official trial ([John 18:13-24](#)).

Caiaphas was the Jewish high priest from around AD 18 to 36. He worked closely with his influential father-in-law, Annas. Caiaphas argued in the high council that sacrificing Jesus would be better than risking the nation's destruction ([John 11:49-50](#)). God gave him these prophetic words because he was the high priest ([John 11:51-52](#)). During Jesus' trial, Caiaphas tore his robes when Jesus claimed to be the Son of God. He urged the high council to condemn Jesus for blasphemy ([Matthew 26:57-66](#)).

Shortly after Jesus's execution, Jewish leaders grew worried about the rising number of Christ's followers. Annas and Caiaphas questioned Peter and John about healing a crippled beggar and preaching about the resurrection of the dead ([Acts 4:5-7](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 26:3-5, 57-67](#); [Mark 14:53-65](#); [Luke 3:2](#); [John 11:49-53](#); [John 18:13-28](#); [Acts 4:5-7](#)

Antiochus IV

Antiochus IV is the most important Seleucid ruler in biblical literature. The Seleucids were a powerful Greek family that controlled much of the Middle East after Alexander the Great died. Antiochus IV is known as one of history's cruelest tyrants. He strongly believed in Zeus (the main Greek god) and aimed to unify his territories by promoting Greek culture, law, and religion. This led to violent conflict with the Jews in Judea.

Antiochus IV was born in 215 BC with the name Mithradates. He was the son of Antiochus III but not the chosen heir of the Seleucid kingdom. After the Battle of Magnesia in 190 BC, Mithradates went to Rome as a hostage to ensure his father paid debts to Rome. His brother, Seleucus IV, began ruling in 187 BC. Mithradates used schemes to free himself. After his brother was murdered, Mithradates became the Seleucid king and was called Antiochus IV. He called himself Epiphanes, meaning "god manifest." However, his unpredictable behavior led critics to nickname him Epimanes, meaning "manifestly insane."

Antiochus wanted to spread Greek culture and needed money. This led him to sell the Jewish high priesthood to the highest bidder who supported Hellenization (the spread of Greek culture, law, and religion). He sold the position of high priest twice: first to Jason in 174 BC and then to Menelaus, who offered more money, in 171 BC.

Antiochus wanted to control Egypt, so he invaded in 169 BC. Meanwhile, Jason tried to regain the high priest's office in Jerusalem but failed. Antiochus suspected rebellion, so after his successful campaign in Egypt, he attacked Jerusalem. He killed and enslaved thousands and looted the Temple. The next year, Antiochus attacked Egypt again, but Roman forces helped Egypt. Antiochus was stopped outside Alexandria. There, the Roman legate Popilius humiliated him by drawing a circle around him and forcing him to decide to surrender before leaving the circle.

In 167 BC, Antiochus sent troops to massacre the men of Jerusalem and enslave the women and children. By his order, practicing Judaism became illegal and punishable by death. Jews had to take part in pagan sacrifices. Antiochus believed that destroying the Jewish nation would secure his borders and support his Hellenization program. However, it had the opposite effect.

Open rebellion began later that year in the village of Modein near Jerusalem. When the king's

representative came to enforce the ban on Judaism, a Jewish priest named Mattathias killed him. Mattathias then fled with his followers to the nearby hills. This act started the Maccabean rebellion. Mattathias's sons eventually took control of Jerusalem and purified the temple in 164 BC. They later achieved semi-independence for Judea.

Many already thought Antiochus was insane. The Maccabees' success and his failure to stop the Jewish revolt worsened his madness. He retreated to Persia, where he died in 164 BC.

Passages for Further Study

[Daniel 11:21-35](#)

Apollos

Apollos was a Greek-speaking Jew who knew the Scriptures well. He became a strong evangelist (someone who shared the good news about Jesus with many people) and a Christian apologist (someone who defended Christian beliefs). He was from Alexandria, Egypt, which had a large Jewish community. Apollos likely learned from John the Baptist's followers. He then preached boldly and enthusiastically about Jesus in Jewish synagogues, even though he did not know about Christian baptism.

When Priscilla and Aquila heard Apollos preach in Ephesus, they invited him to their home. They explained the way of Christ to him more fully. The believers in Ephesus encouraged him because they saw that God had gifted him for ministry. Then, Apollos traveled to the city of Corinth in Achaia. There, he greatly helped the believers. He was an effective defender of the good news about Jesus in public debates with the Jews. He boldly showed that Jesus is the Messiah (God's chosen one) as predicted in Scripture ([Acts 18:24-28](#)).

Apollos was a skilled speaker. He was popular with some Christians in Corinth because of his intellectual style. His strong ministry attracted some people more than Paul's did ([1 Corinthians 1:11-12](#)). Paul defended his own simple way of preaching the good news about Jesus, possibly due to comparisons with Apollos.

Importantly, Paul never criticized Apollos. He called Apollos a fellow servant and appreciated the work Apollos did. Apollos continued the work that Paul had started, and God blessed both their efforts ("I planted the seed and Apollos watered it," [1](#)

[Corinthians 3:5-9; 4:1](#)). Instead, Paul criticized the shallow views and divisions among those who followed Apollos for superficial reasons (see [1 Corinthians 1:10-12; 3:3-4; 4:6-7](#)).

Apollos may have hesitated to return to Corinth from Ephesus because of the divisions his ministry caused ([1 Corinthians 16:12](#)). However, Paul encouraged him to go back eventually. Several years later, while Apollos was working on the island of Crete, Paul urged Titus to ensure Apollos's needs were met as he departed for an unknown destination for more missionary work ([Titus 3:13](#)). Apollos, with his strong intellect and powerful speaking skills, had a different approach and style from Paul, yet both were effective and useful in serving Christ.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 18:24-19:1; 1 Corinthians 1:10-12; 3:3-9; 4:1, 6-7; 16:12; 2 Corinthians 10:10; Titus 3:13](#)

Arameans

The Arameans belonged to a family of peoples who descended from Noah's son Shem ([Genesis 10:22-23](#); compare [Genesis 22:20-21](#)). Bethuel and Laban were known as Arameans ([Genesis 25:20; 28:1-7](#)). Jacob lived with them in Aramean territory for about twenty years ([Genesis 28-31; Hosea 12:12](#)), and the people of Israel remembered that their ancestors were culturally Arameans ([Deuteronomy 26:5](#)).

The Arameans appeared in history around Abraham's time. They lived near the central Euphrates and spread east, west, and north. By about 1100 BC, Aramean tribes were throughout Syria and northern Transjordan (the land east of the Jordan River). They established strong city-states like Zobah and Damascus, which conflicted with the Israelites starting with David's time (see [2 Samuel 8:3-8; 10:6-19](#)).

After Solomon died, Israel split into northern and southern kingdoms. During this time, the Aramean city of Damascus became very powerful. The rulers of Damascus often took advantage of the fighting between the two kingdoms of Israel. During the war between Israel and Judah from 890 to 880 BC, King Asa of Israel asked Ben-hadad I of Damascus for help ([1 Kings 15:18-19](#)).

About thirty years later, in the early 850s BC, Ben-hadad invaded Israel, but Ahab defeated him at

Samaria ([1 Kings 20:1-21](#)) and again at Aphek the next year ([20:22-34](#)). After three years of peace, Israel and Damascus fought again in 853 BC, and Ahab was killed in battle ([1 Kings 22:29-37](#)). Aramean Damascus continued to cause losses for Israel over the next several decades (see [2 Kings 8:28-29](#); [12:17-18](#); [13:1-7](#)).

During this time, the Aramean city-states began to feel pressure from Assyria. Assyria first defeated Damascus around 838 BC and forced it to pay tribute in 803 BC. This weakened Damascus, allowing Jehoash, the king of Israel from 798 to 782 BC, to defeat the Arameans and drive them out of Israel's territory around 795 BC ([2 Kings 13:14-25](#)). Later, Jeroboam II, who ruled from 793 to 753 BC, made Damascus pay tribute to him (see [2 Kings 14:28](#)).

Around 738 BC, the Arameans of Damascus allied with Israel to conquer Judah. They captured much land, but their siege of Jerusalem failed ([2 Kings 16:5](#); see also [2 Chronicles 28:5](#)). During this apparent success for Damascus, the prophets Isaiah and Amos predicted the city's destruction ([Isaiah 8:4](#); [17:1](#); [Amos 1:3-5](#)). Instead of trusting God, King Ahaz of Judah sought protection from the Assyrians. The Assyrians responded to his gifts by attacking Damascus and exiling its people in 733 and 732 BC ([2 Kings 16:7-11](#)). Damascus ceased to be an independent city-state.

The Arameans' language, Aramaic, became the main language for diplomacy and administration across the Near East (see, for example, [2 Kings 18:26](#)). During the exile in Babylon, the Jews started using Aramaic; parts of Ezra and Daniel are in Aramaic. Aramaic was the common language from Egypt to India during the Persian period and was widely spoken in Palestine during Jesus' time (see [Mark 5:41](#); [1 Corinthians 16:22](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 10:22-23](#); [22:20-21](#); [25:20](#); [28:1-7](#); [Deuteronomy 26:5](#); [2 Samuel 8:3-4](#); [10:17-19](#); [1 Kings 15:18](#); [1 Kings 20:1-34](#); [22:29-37](#); [2 Kings 13:25](#); [16:9-13](#); [17:24-34](#); [Hosea 12:12](#); [Amos 1:5](#)

Asa

Asa became the third king of Judah after Solomon's empire split into separate kingdoms. Asa became king after his father, Abijah, who ruled briefly from 913 to 910 BC. Asa reigned for 41 years, from 910 to 869 BC.

At the start of his reign, Asa was a good king. He opposed the worship of false gods, destroyed the Asherah pole his grandmother Maacah had set up, and removed her political influence ([1 Kings 15:13](#); [2 Chronicles 15:16](#)).

In the early days of Asa's reign, God gave him military victories and peace. Asa expelled or defeated anyone trying to conquer, divide, or destroy Judah ([2 Chronicles 14:1-8](#)). Asa's most remarkable victory was over an Ethiopian leader named Zerah, who attacked Judah with over a million troops. Due to Asa's obedience and faithfulness, God granted him a great victory ([2 Chronicles 14:9-15](#)).

Sadly, Asa's attitude changed near the end of his life. He stopped trusting in God. Baasha, the king of the northern kingdom, attacked Judah with help from Ben-hadad, king of Aram, and strengthened the city of Ramah. Asa paid the king of Aram to switch sides and support him instead of Baasha. This showed Asa trusted a foreign king more than the Lord. Worse, Asa paid Ben-hadad with gold and silver he had previously given to the temple! Asa's strategy worked, and the northern kingdom of Israel had to leave Judah to deal with Ben-hadad's threat from the north. However, the prophet Hanani criticized Asa for his lack of faith in God. Angered, Asa imprisoned Hanani ([2 Chronicles 16:7-10](#)).

In the last years of his reign, Asa had a serious foot disease. Despite the severity of his illness, he did not seek the Lord's help. Instead, he relied only on his doctors ([2 Chronicles 16:12](#)). Even so, when Asa died, they buried him with honor in the royal tombs ([2 Chronicles 16:14](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 15:8-24](#); [2 Chronicles 14:1-16:14](#)

Assyria

Assyria was a symbol of fear and cruelty in the Near East for over three centuries. The Bible describes its power and harsh treatment of the people of Israel and Judah. However, Assyria's success depended on its leaders' strength. Eventually, stronger forces defeated it.

Ashurnasirpal II (885-860 BC)

Ashurnasirpal II had the same qualities and flaws as the kings who came after him but to a greater

degree. He was ambitious, energetic, brave, vain, and magnificent. He was determined to expand his kingdom.

Shalmaneser III (858–824 BC)

Shalmaneser III is famous for the Battle of Qarqar in 853 BC, one of the best-documented events from ancient times. A group of allied kingdoms, including King Ahab of Israel and several other states, stopped his invasion of Syria. It took years before Shalmaneser conquered Israel and Syria. The Black Obelisk of Shalmaneser III shows King Jehu of Israel bowing and giving tribute (payment to show submission).

Repentance during the Time of Jonah

During King Jeroboam II's reign in Israel from 793 to 753 BC, the prophet Jonah reluctantly traveled to Nineveh to announce judgment ([Jonah 3–4](#)). Assyria was declining at that time. As Jonah feared, the king and people of Nineveh listened and repented of their sins. As a result, God gave them a reprieve that lasted about 150 years.

Tiglath-pileser III (744–727 BC)

Tiglath-pileser III took over the Assyrian throne and worked to regain and strengthen control over all Assyrian territories. He also became the king of Babylon, making Assyria the leading military and economic power in the Near East. He showed political wisdom uncommon among the typically ruthless Assyrian kings. King Menahem of Israel, who ruled 752 from 742 BC, paid him tribute ([2 Kings 15:19–20](#)), as did Tyre, Byblos, and Damascus. When King Ahaz of Judah, who ruled from 735 to 715 BC, asked for help against Syria and Israel ([2 Kings 16:5–20](#)), Tiglath-pileser conquered Damascus in 732 BC. Shalmaneser V, who became king after Tiglath-pileser, would destroy Samaria in 722 BC. This would mark the end of the northern kingdom of Israel.

Sennacherib (705–681 BC)

Sennacherib spent his reign fighting many difficult wars. He is well-known in the Bible for attacking Judah and surrounding Jerusalem in 701 BC. This happened during King Hezekiah's rule and the prophet Isaiah's time ([2 Kings 18:13–19:37](#); [Isaiah 36–37](#)).

Ashurbanipal (668–627 BC)

Ashurbanipal captured No-amon (Thebes) in Egypt, achieving the greatest victory in Assyrian history (see [Nahum 3:3–10](#)). He also established a large library in Nineveh, which was excavated in 1860. Many tablets were found, containing a wide range of Akkadian material. This library is now one of the main treasures of the British Museum in London. Very little is known about Ashurbanipal's reign after 639 BC, as his records do not go beyond that year. However, hints in state correspondence, business documents, and prayers to the gods suggest that Assyria was becoming more unstable. When Ashurbanipal died in 627 BC, his empire declined quickly.

Final Decline and Destruction

In 626 BC, Nabopolassar became king of Babylon, ruled from 626 to 605 BC, and allied with the Medes. This alliance made Babylon's success against Assyria almost certain. In 612 BC, their combined forces launched a final attack on Nineveh. After a three-month siege, the mighty city fell (see [Nahum 1:8](#)). Nebuchadnezzar, then a general in his father's army, completely destroyed the last Assyrian forces at the Battle of Carchemish in 605 BC.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Kings 15:19–19:37](#)

Babylon

Babylon, one of the world's oldest cities, was the center of Babylonian civilization. It is often used as a symbol for defiant human pride.

Nimrod founded Babylon a few generations after the flood ([Genesis 10:8–10](#)). He was one of the first powerful rulers in history. The name Babylon comes from Babel, which means "gate of god" in the Babylonian language. Babylon was likely where the tower of Babel stood ([Genesis 11:1–9](#)). This tower was an early human attempt to create an identity separate from the Creator. Abraham and his family left this proud civilization when they traveled from Ur of the Chaldeans around 2000 BC. Although many kingdoms ruled Babylon over the centuries, the city remained a cultural and religious leader.

Sumerian Civilization (3200–2000 BC)

The first major civilization in Babylonia was Sumer, located south of Babylon. The Sumerians created cuneiform writing, used by Mesopotamian cultures for three thousand years.

The Akkadian Empire (2334–2154 BC)

North of Babylon, King Sargon I of Akkad, who ruled from 2339 to 2279 BC, established the capital city of Akkad. He achieved political and cultural dominance over Mesopotamia. The Akkadian Empire lasted almost two centuries.

First Babylonian Kingdom (1900–1600 BC)

During the Akkadian Empire, Semitic-speaking nomads from Syria, known as Amurru or Amorites, migrated into Babylonia. The urbane Babylonians considered them barbarians. Eventually, they established a new Babylonian kingdom under Amorite control. Hammurabi, the sixth king of that dynasty, ruled from 1792 to 1750 BC and expanded the kingdom significantly. However, Babylon's glory was short-lived. Under Hammurabi's son, the kingdom declined and lasted only another century.

Assyrian Domination (900–614 BC)

In 851 BC, Assyrian King Shalmaneser III, who ruled from 858 to 824 BC, entered Babylon. He treated the ancient city with respect and allowed its king to remain as a vassal. About 150 years later, around 705 BC, a Babylonian vassal king named Merodach-baladan led a rebellion. He sent ambassadors to King Hezekiah of Judah for support (see [2 Kings 20:12–19](#); [Isaiah 39](#)). Assyria quickly crushed Merodach-baladan's rebellion, and its domination continued for another century.

Neo-Babylonian Empire (612–539 BC)

The Chaldean prince Nabopolassar took the throne of Babylon from 625 to 605 BC, ending the Assyrian Empire. His son, Nebuchadnezzar II, ruled from 605 to 562 BC. Under Nebuchadnezzar, Babylon became the leading power in the Near East and a city of great splendor (see [Daniel 1–4](#)).

After Nebuchadnezzar died, Nabonidus became the next king of Babylon. Nabonidus was once a high-ranking government official who worked with other kingdoms. He ruled Babylon from about 555 BC to 539 BC. Nabonidus neglected Babylon and lost its support. When Cyrus II of Persia, who ruled from 559 to 530 BC, attacked the city in October

539 BC (see [Daniel 5:30–31](#) and study note on Daniel 5:31), the city surrendered without a battle. This surrender marked the end of independent Babylon.

The Symbolic Enemy of God's People

In 1 Peter and Revelation, Rome is represented by Babylon. Rome is "BABYLON THE GREAT, THE MOTHER OF PROSTITUTES AND OF THE ABOMINATIONS OF THE EARTH" ([Revelation 17:5](#)). It is portrayed as a very immoral center of wealth and trade, ruling over the earth's kings and persecuting God's people. The earth's kings and merchants will mourn its fall ([Revelation 18:9–19](#)). But God's people will celebrate because their oppression has ended and they can worship God freely.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 10:8–9](#); [11:1–9](#); [2 Kings 20:12–19](#); [24:1–25:30](#); [Isaiah 39](#); [Daniel 1–5](#); [1 Peter 5:13](#); [Revelation 14:8](#); [16:19](#); [17:5](#); [18:2–21](#); [19:2](#)

Balaam

Balaam was a diviner who read signs to predict the future and performed rituals to change it (see study note on Numbers 22:5–6; compare [Joshua 13:22](#)). He worked for money, so when Balak, the king of Moab, wanted to hire him to curse Israel, he was eager to start. Even when God told him not to go, he hoped God would change His mind because he was very interested in the money ([2 Peter 2:15](#)).

Finally, God allowed Balaam to go, but only if Balaam agreed to say what God instructed, aiming to frustrate Balak's plans ([Deuteronomy 23:4–5](#)). On the road, Balaam's donkey stopped and refused to move because the angel of the Lord blocked the way. The donkey could see the angel, but Balaam could not. Despite this, Balaam wisely chose not to curse the Israelites when God told him to bless them. To Balak's great frustration, blessing them was all Balaam could do.

Recently, an inscription was found mentioning Balaam son of Beor, a diviner who had visions at night (see [Numbers 22:9–12](#), [20](#)). The inscription was written on a plaster wall at Deir 'Alla, eight miles east of the Jordan River, near where the Hebrews camped during the Balaam incident. This nonbiblical text, dated 800–750 BC, identifies Balaam as a "seer of the gods." It reports that the gods, whose names in the inscription resemble

Shaddai ("Almighty"; see [Numbers 24:4, 16](#)), gave Balaam a message and announced judgment upon the world (see [Numbers 24:15-25](#)). The inscription provides rare evidence from outside the Bible about a character in the Bible.

Balaam's character and motives seem mixed in [Numbers 22-24](#). [Numbers 25](#) describes how the men of Israel sinned by being with Moabite women and worshipping their gods, which angered God. Although Balaam is not mentioned here, [Numbers 31:16](#) identifies him as the one who started this plot. After his visions ended, Balaam stayed in Moab and looked for ways to harm Israel and earn money. The Israelites killed him shortly after ([Numbers 31:8](#)). Balaam became known as:

- A magician with bad intentions (see [Deuteronomy 23:4-5](#); [Joshua 13:22](#))
- A false teacher interested only in money (see [Nehemiah 13:2](#); [2 Peter 2:15](#); [Jude 1:11](#))
- Someone who led Israel into idolatry and immorality ([Numbers 31:16](#); see [Revelation 2:14](#))

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 22:1-25:18](#); [31:8, 16](#); [Joshua 13:22](#); [2 Peter 2:15-16](#); [Jude 1:11](#); [Revelation 2:14](#)

Barnabas

Barnabas is shown in Acts as a good example of a Christian leader. He was from Cyprus and was active in the Jerusalem church. Barnabas showed great generosity by helping poorer members ([Acts 4:32-37](#)). His real name was Joseph, but he was nicknamed Barnabas. Barnabas means "Son of Encouragement" and shows his character ([Acts 4:36](#)).

Barnabas was well-suited to fairly assess the new work in Antioch ([Acts 11:19-22](#)). Barnabas saw God's blessing there and encouraged believers to remain faithful to the Lord ([Acts 11:23](#)). His good character was evident in his kindness, strong faith, and Spirit-filled life and work ([Acts 11:24](#)). The Holy Spirit chose Barnabas and Saul for a special mission (known as the first missionary journey). The church at Antioch sent them out on this journey ([Acts 13:1-3](#)).

Barnabas showed wisdom when he went to Tarsus to find Saul ([Acts 11:25](#)). Barnabas admired Saul's bold preaching as a new Christian in Damascus. He introduced Saul to the apostles, which was important because Saul had previously attacked believers. Thanks to Barnabas, Saul met the original apostles, gained their acceptance, and preached bravely in Jerusalem until he had to leave ([Acts 9:26-30](#)). Barnabas's trip was successful, and for a year, they worked together in the Antioch church, attracting large crowds ([Acts 11:26](#)).

Barnabas was an important person. In Lystra, people even thought he was Zeus (see [Acts 14:8-18](#)). He was John Mark's cousin and mentor. Barnabas helped John Mark get a second chance to succeed as a Christian leader after he left an earlier mission (see [Acts 15:36-40](#)).

Barnabas understood how others could influence people to do wrong things. One time, he gave in to this pressure and did something he knew was wrong ([Galatians 2:11-13](#)). Barnabas was not perfect, but he was a "Son of Encouragement" to many. He was generous and unselfish, helping others and the church grow.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 4:36-37](#); [9:26-28](#); [11:19-30](#); [13:1-15:40](#); [Galatians 2:1-14](#)

Baruch

Baruch, the son of Neriah, was a royal scribe in Jerusalem. He worked as a secretary for the prophet Jeremiah. His brother, Seraiah, was a staff officer in Zedekiah's administration ([Jeremiah 51:59-64](#)). Baruch's family likely held a high position in Judah's administration.

In the fourth year of King Jehoiakim of Judah (605 BC), God told Jeremiah to write down the messages he had given to Israel, Judah, and other nations ([Jeremiah 36:1-3](#)). Jeremiah asked Baruch to write the prophecies ([Jeremiah 36:4](#)) and read them to the people ([36:8-19](#)). When Jehoiakim heard the message, he destroyed the scroll and ordered the arrest of Baruch and Jeremiah ([Jeremiah 36:21-26](#)). However, they hid, and Jeremiah repeated the prophecies while Baruch wrote them down again ([Jeremiah 36:27-32](#)).

Around that time, God sent Baruch a personal message through Jeremiah ([Jeremiah 45](#)). Baruch might have worried about losing career

opportunities or personal comfort because of his connection with Jeremiah. God reassured Baruch with a promise of protection and advised him not to seek "great things" for himself, as Judah's destruction was certain.

When Jerusalem was destroyed in 586 BC, Baruch stayed with Jeremiah and others who remained. Baruch seemed influential because the rebel leaders wanted to go to Egypt. When Jeremiah warned them not to go ([Jeremiah 42](#)), they accused Baruch of influencing Jeremiah. The leaders ignored the warning and took Baruch and Jeremiah to Egypt ([Jeremiah 43:1-7](#)). We do not know how, when, or where Baruch died. One tradition says he was taken to Babylon when Nebuchadnezzar invaded Egypt. It is also possible that Baruch died in Egypt.

God warned Baruch not to seek greatness, and he appeared to die without honor. However, his legacy may be the book of Jeremiah. He likely helped create this book, which warns of judgment and clearly expresses hope for the new covenant ([Jeremiah 31:31-34](#)).

In 1975, a clay impression (called a *bullā*) from a scribe's seal was found. It had the words "[Belonging to] Berechiah, son of Neriah, the scribe." (*Berechiah* is the long form of the name *Baruch*.) Each scribe and government official had a unique seal with his name. They used it to seal documents, like a signature today. The seal was pressed into soft clay to make an impression (*bullā*), which was attached to the signed document. Baruch's *bullā* is from the time of Jeremiah and Baruch. Other *bullae* found include names of people in Jeremiah, like:

4. "Gemariah son of Shaphan" ([Jeremiah 36:10-12, 25](#))
5. Ishmael ([Jeremiah 40:7-41:10](#))

Most scholars agree that Baruch's *bullā* was made by Baruch's seal, Jeremiah's scribe. These *bullae*, small artifacts from an ancient civilization, provide independent historical proof of some details in Jeremiah's account.

Passages for Further Study

[Jeremiah 32:9-15; 36:1-21, 26-32; 43:1-7; 45:1-5](#)

Bathsheba

Bathsheba, the wife of Uriah, was Eliam's daughter ([2 Samuel 11:3](#); see also [1 Chronicles 3:5](#)). She was Ahithophel's granddaughter, the king's adviser ([2 Samuel 15:12; 23:34](#)). Her husband, Uriah, was a Hittite soldier. He was in King David's army and was one of David's mighty warriors ([2 Samuel 23:39](#)).

One spring, David stayed home in Jerusalem while the army went to battle ([2 Samuel 11:1](#)). Resting at midday, David walked on his roof overlooking the city and saw the beautiful Bathsheba bathing. He arranged for her to be brought to his private chambers. He then had sexual relations with her, and she became pregnant ([2 Samuel 11:2-4](#)).

David did not want people to find out what he had done wrong, so he tried to hide it. He told Joab, the general, to have Uriah bring back a report from the battle lines. David hoped Uriah would return home and have sexual relations with Bathsheba. This would make it look like she had become pregnant by Uriah. However, Uriah felt he was still on duty, so he slept at the palace gate instead ([2 Samuel 11:5-13](#)).

When David asked him about this, Uriah said he could not sleep with his wife while the ark of the covenant and Israel's armies were at war. This response made David look bad. Uriah was not even an Israelite, but he was ready to return to battle by avoiding being with his wife (see [Leviticus 15:16-18](#)). But David stayed home and tried to hide his adultery. Then David sent Uriah back and ordered Joab to ensure Uriah died in battle ([2 Samuel 11:14-25](#)). Uriah's death did not keep David's sin secret. The Lord sent the prophet Nathan to confront David, and David confessed his sin and repented ([2 Samuel 12:1-14](#); see [Psalm 51](#)).

Bathsheba's baby became sick and died, as Nathan had predicted. After Bathsheba's mourning period, David brought her to the palace as his wife. David and Bathsheba had other children, including:

- Shimea
- Shobab
- Nathan
- Solomon ([2 Samuel 12:15-25](#); [1 Chronicles 3:5](#))

For the rest of David's life, his wives and children fought against each other for power. The worst of this family fighting happened when David was old.

At that time, Bathsheba worked to make sure her son Solomon would become the next king ([1 Kings 1:1-53](#)).

When Matthew lists Jesus the Messiah's family history, he mentions both Solomon and Bathsheba ([Matthew 1:6](#)). She is described as "Uriah's wife." This reminds us of the sin that brought her into David's family and of God's gracious favor toward her descendants.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 11:1-12:25](#); [1 Kings 1:5-2:25](#); [Psalm 51:1-19](#)

Caleb

Caleb is an inspiring example of faith in God. He was the son of Jephunneh the Kenizzite ([Joshua 14:6](#); [Numbers 32:12](#)). The Kenizzites lived in the Negev, the southern desert region of Canaan (see [Genesis 15:18-21](#)). Jephunneh likely married into the tribe of Judah a generation before Israel left Egypt.

Caleb first appears as one of the twelve spies Moses sent to explore the land of Canaan. Upon returning, all twelve confirmed the land was impressive, but ten of the scouts focused on its fearsome residents ([Numbers 13:31-33](#)). Only Joshua and Caleb believed that God would help Israel conquer the Canaanites ([Numbers 14:6-9](#)), advising the Israelites to take the land immediately ([Numbers 13:30](#)).

The people wanted to stone Caleb and Joshua ([Numbers 14:10](#)). But God protected them and punished the people ([Numbers 14:11-38](#)). God ultimately rewarded Caleb and Joshua for their faithfulness: Among all the adults who left Egypt, they were the only ones to enter the promised land.

After many years in the wilderness and fighting many battles, Caleb received his inheritance in the land ([Joshua 14:6-15](#)). Caleb's faith remained strong over forty-five years. His story shows his character and firm faith in God. Although Caleb was eighty-five years old, he was still strong and able to fight. Caleb took Hebron as his land by driving out the giant Anakites who had scared the earlier scouts ([Joshua 15:13-14](#); see [Numbers 13:28, 33](#)).

Caleb lived in the city of Hebron, which was about twenty miles south of Jerusalem. This city was close to where the Kenizzite people lived. Later, Hebron became a special city where the Levites (priests)

lived and where people could go for safety ([Joshua 21:13](#); [1 Chronicles 6:54-57](#)).

Caleb focused on God's promise that Israel would live in Canaan, despite serious obstacles. With full energy, he was ready to take the land Joshua gave him. Caleb's strong belief in God's promises made him respected among the faithful. Even when he was outnumbered by enemies, Caleb trusted God, and God rewarded him greatly.

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 13:1-14:38](#); [26:65](#); [32:12](#); [34:19](#); [Deuteronomy 1:36](#); [Joshua 14:6-15](#); [15:13-19](#); [Judges 1:11-15, 20](#); [1 Chronicles 4:15](#)

Corinth

Corinth is one of Greece's oldest cities, with settlements dating back to at least 3000 BC. Its strategic location on key trade routes helped it become a major center for commerce. Corinth reached its peak power between 800 and 600 BC. In the mid-100s BC, as the Roman military expanded its empire, Corinth led the Hellenic League to resist Roman control in Greece. However, they could not defeat the Romans. In 146 BC, the Romans completely destroyed Corinth, executing the men and selling the women and children into slavery. Corinth remained in ruins for a century.

In 44 BC, Julius Caesar founded a Roman colony in Corinth. This colony attracted a diverse group of Italians, freedmen (freed former slaves) from Rome, and displaced Greeks. The new residents, with hard work and creativity, quickly rebuilt the city into a thriving hub for trade, commerce, and industry. By the time Paul arrived in Corinth, it was a lively, diverse city with nearly 700,000 people, including many wealthy individuals and others aspiring to wealth.

Corinth drew tradespeople from around the world, but it also became known for luxury, indulgence, and vice. The city had a reputation for promiscuity and prostitution, so much so that the verb "Corinthianize" meant engaging in immoral sexual behavior. The church in Corinth experienced challenges with sexual immorality ([1 Corinthians 5:1-13](#); [6:12-20](#)).

Corinth was also important because of the Isthmian Games, which began in 523 BC and took place every two years. The events focused on three types:

equestrian, gymnastic, and musical. By the New Testament period, the games included chariot racing and other Roman shows, along with traditional Greek competitions. Paul referred to these athletic contests, mentioning both running and boxing ([1 Corinthians 9:24-26](#)). The winners of the games became national heroes. They received a wreath made of myrtle, olive, or pine branches. They also got a stipend from the state, tax exemptions, and special benefits for their children.

In most Roman cities, marble temples dominated the landscape. Worshiping the gods and attending their feasts were important parts of life in Corinth. The Corinthian church struggled with these pagan feasts ([1 Corinthians 8:1-10:33](#)).

A large group of displaced Jews also settled in the city. Many may have arrived after Emperor Claudius expelled Jews from Rome (see [Acts 18:2](#)). When Paul traveled to Corinth on his second missionary journey, he met Aquila and Priscilla. They became his close friends and co-workers ([Acts 18:1-3](#)). Paul stayed in Corinth for over a year and a half, teaching the word of God ([Acts 18:11](#)).

The church of Corinth, emerging in a place full of paganism and promiscuity, experienced many challenges. Paul's letters to them offer valuable solutions to practical issues in Christian life and community.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 18:1-18](#); [1 Corinthians 1:1-2](#); [16:5-20](#); [2 Corinthians 1:1](#); [13:1](#); [2 Timothy 4:20](#)

Cyrus II

Cyrus II, king of Persia from 559 to 530 BC, founded the Persian Empire. His father was the king of Persia, a small nation under Media's control, and his mother was the daughter of the king of the Medes. In 549 BC, Cyrus conquered the Medes and united the two nations. He then conquered Lydia in Asia Minor in 547 BC. Turning east, he added Parthia and part of India to the Persian Empire. Finally, on October 29, 539 BC, Cyrus conquered Babylon and included Babylonia in his empire (see [Daniel 5:30-31](#)).

After conquering Babylon, Cyrus issued a decree allowing the Jewish people to return home and rebuild the Temple in Jerusalem. The part of this decree concerning the Jews is recorded in [2 Chronicles 36:22-23](#) and [Ezra 1:1-4](#). The Cyrus

Cylinder, a barrel found in Babylon between 1879 and 1882, confirms this practice. It describes Cyrus's policy on conquered peoples.

Isaiah identified Cyrus as the future liberator of Judah ([Isaiah 44:28-45:13](#)). Isaiah referred to Cyrus as the Lord's anointed ([Isaiah 45:1](#), Hebrew *mashiakh*, meaning "messiah"). Israel saw Cyrus as chosen and empowered by God to free them. Cyrus was not *the* Messiah, but his actions foreshadowed what the Messiah, Jesus Christ, would later do in freeing God's people from servitude.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Chronicles 36:22-23](#); [Ezra 1:1-11](#); [3:7](#); [4:1-5](#); [5:6-17](#); [6:14-15](#); [Isaiah 44:28-45:13](#); [48:14-16](#); [Daniel 6:28](#); [10:1](#)

Daniel

Daniel is a strong example of faith, wisdom, and endurance during difficult times and oppression. His life and prophecies show that God is in control and will ultimately win, even when evil seems powerful.

Daniel belonged to Judah's royal family when the Babylonian army first attacked Jerusalem in 605 BC ([Daniel 1:3](#)). He was taken to Babylon with Azariah, Hananiah, and Mishael. King Nebuchadnezzar trained these young men, along with others, to serve in his expanding empire. Daniel and his friends were the smartest and healthiest students, so they held important positions in Nebuchadnezzar's court.

Daniel worked in the court for nearly seventy years (see [Daniel 1:21](#)). He quickly gained a reputation for intelligence and complete loyalty to God. When Nebuchadnezzar had a troubling dream, God revealed its meaning to Daniel, who explained it to the king ([Daniel 2](#)). Later, Daniel interpreted a second dream about the king's pride ([Daniel 4](#)). Daniel urged Nebuchadnezzar to repent, but he did not. As a result, Nebuchadnezzar temporarily lost his sanity ([Daniel 4:28-37](#)).

Daniel always showed respect to the Babylonian king. Nebuchadnezzar respected Daniel highly because of his good character and behavior. This led Nebuchadnezzar to worship the Lord, although not exclusively. Daniel's faithfulness and wisdom inspire readers in hostile cultures today.

Later, Belshazzar, the vice-regent of Babylon, used the sacred vessels from the Jerusalem Temple

disrespectfully during a banquet in 539 BC. Suddenly, a disembodied hand wrote the words “Mene, Mene, Tekel, and Parsin” on the palace wall. Daniel interpreted these words as predicting Babylon’s imminent end. That same night, Persians captured the capital and killed Belshazzar ([Daniel 5:1-31](#)).

In 539 BC, under Darius the Mede, Daniel became an administrator of the kingdom ([Daniel 6:2](#)). Daniel’s effective management angered his political enemies. They convinced Darius to issue a decree that banned worship of anyone except the king, with the punishment of being thrown into a lions’ den. To maintain his religious beliefs, Daniel broke the law, but he was miraculously unharmed by the lions. Afterward, he returned to his position ([Daniel 6:17-28](#)). Daniel’s later visions are from around this time ([Daniel 10:1, 4](#)).

Daniel’s prophecies are hard to understand in detail, but their message is clear: Evil forces are in power now, but God is in control and will save his people. Jesus and New Testament authors cited Daniel, often using his imagery when discussing the end times (for example, compare [Daniel 7:1-9](#) and [Revelation 13:1-10](#); [Daniel 7:13](#) and [Revelation 1:7](#); [Daniel 9:27](#) and [Matthew 24:15](#)). Daniel was certain that God Most High would win.

Passages for Further Study

[Ezekiel 14:14, 20](#); [28:3](#); [Daniel 1:1-12:13](#); [Matthew 24:15](#)

David

David is one of the most important people in the Bible. His time as king was a very special period in God’s plan for Israel. The things David did as king had a great and lasting effect on Israel’s future.

David was born in Bethlehem as Jesse’s youngest son. His family history goes back to Judah ([Ruth 4:18-22](#); [1 Chronicles 2:3-15](#); [Matthew 1:3-6](#); [Luke 3:31-33](#)). When he was born, the Jebusites occupied Jerusalem, and many parts of the promised land were still under foreign control, especially by the Philistines. God would use David to finish conquering the land.

As a young man, David was a simple shepherd, caring for his father’s sheep ([1 Samuel 16:11](#); [17:14-15](#)). His life changed unexpectedly when the prophet Samuel visited Jesse and anointed David as the future king of Israel. However, David did not

become king through a coup or assassination. Instead, he served King Saul faithfully. David first joined Saul’s service as a musician, playing songs that calmed Saul’s troubled mind ([1 Samuel 16:14-23](#)). This role foreshadowed David’s work as the composer of many psalms. Young David also helped Saul by famously defeating the Philistine champion Goliath in single combat ([1 Samuel 17:32-51](#)). This victory foreshadowed David’s future as a successful military leader.

David was loyal, but Saul became very suspicious of him. So, David had to flee. He escaped with help from Saul’s children, Jonathan and Michal. David led a kingdom in exile with an army of six hundred men. The prophet Gad and the priest Abiathar were with him, offering guidance from the Lord.

God’s patience with Saul eventually ended, and Saul died in battle. Even then, David found it difficult to become the ruler of all Israel. The tribe of Judah quickly made him their king, but the northern tribes initially chose Ishbosheth, Saul’s son, as their leader. Ishbosheth was weak and ineffective; he remained in power only because of his father’s military leader, Abner. However, Ishbosheth insulted Abner, so the general helped transfer the kingdom to David.

As king of a united Israel, David strengthened the kingdom. He and his men captured Jerusalem from the Jebusites and made it his capital. He forced the last of the Philistines to leave the land. David then brought the ark of the covenant into Jerusalem. He wanted to build a permanent temple for God in Jerusalem to replace the tabernacle. God denied this wish but showed love for David by making a covenant (special agreement) with him, establishing his descendants as a family of kings ([2 Samuel 7](#)).

David’s life soon worsened (see [2 Samuel 11-12](#)). When he should have been with his army, he stayed on the palace roof. He saw a beautiful woman named Bathsheba bathing and desired her. So, like other powerful kings of that time who took whatever they wanted, he took Bathsheba. She became pregnant, and his attempt to hide his adultery failed. David was desperate, so he had her husband, Uriah, killed. However, even a great king like David cannot hide secrets from God. God sent his prophet Nathan to confront David. David was sorry for what he had done (see [Psalms 32, 51](#)). But his actions affected his family and his reign.

From then on, David’s family began to have many problems and conflicts. David’s son Amnon raped

his half-sister Tamar ([2 Samuel 13:1-14](#)). Her brother Absalom then murdered Amnon ([2 Samuel 13:20-29](#)). Absalom later started a civil war as he tried to become king instead of his father ([2 Samuel 15-18](#)). Another son, Adonijah, tried to become king instead of David by declaring himself king while his father was still alive ([1 Kings 1:5-10](#)). But David gathered enough strength to ensure that Solomon would be king after him ([1 Kings 1:28-40](#)). When David died, Solomon became king. Solomon was the first of many kings from David's family (as promised in [2 Samuel 7](#)).

Most of the kings who came after David were not as good at leading as he was. His descendants rarely led the nation to worship God faithfully. The united kingdom of Israel did not last beyond Solomon. In the following centuries, David's descendants ruled only Judah in the south. Eventually, the kingdom of Judah was destroyed. A descendant of David never again ruled as king in Israel.

What about the promise to David that "your throne will be secure forever" ([2 Samuel 7:16](#))? The New Testament refers to Jesus. He was a descendant of David, and God declared him the Christ, or Messiah—the anointed king (see [Matthew 1:1; 9:27; 12:23; Mark 10:47-48; 11:10; 12:35-37; Luke 18:38-39; 20:41-44; John 7:42; Revelation 5:5; 22:16](#)). David's life and rule foreshadow the messianic reign of Jesus Christ, which will last forever (see [Luke 1:32-33; Revelation 11:15](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Ruth 4:13-22; 1 Samuel 16:1-17:58; 18:1-27:12; 29:1-30:31; 2 Samuel 1:1-24:25; 1 Kings 1:1-2:12; 1 Chronicles 11:1-29:30; Psalms 1-32, 34-41, 51-71, 86, 91-110, 122, 124, 131, 133, 138-145; Matthew 1:1; 9:27; 22:41-46; Mark 12:35-37; Luke 20:41-44; John 7:40-44; Acts 2:22-37; 13:20-43; Romans 1:3; Revelation 22:16](#)

Deborah

The prophet Deborah was one of the early judges of Israel. She was a woman of integrity and devotion to the Lord. As a prophet, she received divine messages. As a judge, she settled legal disputes. People often called her "a mother in Israel" (see [Judges 5:7](#)).

During Deborah's time, people were doing more wrong things. They stopped following God's ways, and the tribes of Israel were not united. Israel was doing "evil in the sight of the LORD" ([Judges 4:1](#)).

So, God handed Israel over to an oppressor, Jabin of Canaan. Once more, Israel cried out to the Lord for help ([Judges 4:3](#)).

God called Barak to fight Sisera, the commander of Jabin's army, through Deborah. However, Barak was not enthusiastic or brave. He insisted that Deborah accompany him. Deborah agreed but warned that a woman would receive the glory for the victory, not Barak. This came true when Barak defeated Sisera and his army, but Jael, the woman who killed Sisera, received the glory. Barak showed little courage or leadership. This was very different from the courage and leadership of Deborah and Jael. Deborah's actions led to forty years of peace for Israel ([Judges 5:31](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Judges 4:1-5:31](#)

Egypt

Egypt was a great and ancient civilization when Joseph rose to power and Jacob's family traveled there for food ([Genesis 39-41; 42-46](#); compare [12:10-20](#)). Egypt was well protected from enemies because of where it was located. The Mediterranean Sea to the north had no harbors. The rough Sinai Peninsula lay to the east, and a huge desert stretched to the west. This natural protection made Egypt a safe place for people from other lands during times when there was no rain.

People call Egypt "the gift of the Nile" because no other river has been so essential to a nation's history. Egyptians referred to it as "the River." The Nile is more than the longest river in the world. Without its water, civilization in Egypt would not have existed. The Nile is Egypt's lifeline, and Egyptians worshiped it for the life and fertility it provided. The river's yearly floods brought new, fertile soil for crops. The river provided fish and birds for food, along with clean water for drinking and washing. It also served as the main route for travel, trade, and communication. During droughts, when nearby nations faced famine, the Nile gave Egypt a steady supply of fresh water. The Nile shaped every part of life in Egypt and made Egypt what it was.

Egypt played an important role in biblical events. Abraham lived there during a famine ([Genesis 12:10-20](#)). Joseph was sold into slavery in Egypt and became a leader, similar to a prime minister ([Genesis 37-41](#)). Joseph's family later moved to the

eastern delta region of Goshen during another famine ([Genesis 42-50](#)). Their descendants were eventually enslaved ([Exodus 1](#)). God's rescue of his people during the exodus from Egypt became a key story for the Jewish people ([Exodus 2-15](#)).

Later, when Israel was ruled by kings, Egypt often joined the fight for international power (for example, [1 Kings 14:25-28](#)). After the Babylonians destroyed Jerusalem in 586 BC, some Jews moved to Egypt to escape Babylon's control ([Jeremiah 43:6-7](#)).

At the start of the New Testament, Egypt became a safe place for Joseph, Mary, and Jesus. They escaped there to avoid Herod the Great's attempts to kill Jesus ([Matthew 2:13-23](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 12:10-20; 37:1-50:26; Exodus 1:1-15:21; 1 Kings 14:25-28; Isaiah 19:1-25; Jeremiah 43:46:7-8; Ezekiel 29:1-21; Amos 8:8; 9:5; Zechariah 10:11; Matthew 2:13-23](#)

Eleazar

Eleazar was the third son of Aaron, the first high priest ([Exodus 6:23](#)). Eleazar's two older brothers, Nadab and Abihu, angered God by offering incense differently than God commanded ([Leviticus 10:1-7](#)). Because they disobeyed, God killed them. As the next oldest son, Eleazar was next in line to become high priest. He performed priestly duties during his father's life and assisted his father and Moses when some Levites rebelled, seeking equal status with Aaron's priestly family ([Numbers 16:36-40](#)).

Aaron died in the wilderness shortly before the Israelites entered the Promised Land. He could not enter because he and Moses had disobeyed God by striking the rock at Meribah ([Numbers 20:1-13](#)). Before Aaron died, he, Moses, and Eleazar went up on Mount Hor. There, Moses took the priestly garments from Aaron and gave them to his son ([Numbers 20:22-29](#)).

After this, Eleazar served as high priest for the rest of his life, including during the time when the Israelites took control of the land of Canaan. When it was time to divide the land among the tribes, Eleazar and Joshua used sacred lots to decide where each tribe would settle ([Joshua 14:1-5](#)). When Eleazar died, his son Phinehas became high priest. Phinehas had shown his faithfulness to the covenant when Israel started worshiping the gods

of Moab ([Numbers 25](#)). Eleazar's descendants included:

- Zadok, the faithful priest who replaced Abiathar ([1 Kings 2:26-27, 35](#); see [1 Chronicles 6:3-8, 50-53](#))
- Ezra, who played a key role in rebuilding Judea after the Exile (see [Ezra 7:1-5](#))

In Ezekiel's ideal temple, only Eleazar's descendants through Zadok would be allowed to serve ([Ezekiel 44:15](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 6:23-25; Leviticus 10:6-7; Numbers 3:1-4; Numbers 16:36-40; Numbers 20:22-26; Numbers 26:1-4; Joshua 14:1](#)

Eli

Eli was Israel's chief priest at the tabernacle in Shiloh, the central place of worship during the time of the judges. Eli likely descended from Ithamar, Aaron's youngest son (see [1 Kings 2:27; 1 Chronicles 18:16; 24:3](#)). Eli was sincere and devout, but he struggled to discipline his wicked sons, Hophni and Phinehas.

When Eli met Hannah at the tabernacle, he wrongly thought she was drunk because she prayed silently for a child. After realizing his mistake, Eli blessed Hannah. God answered her prayer by giving her a son named Samuel.

Samuel gained favor with the Lord and the people ([1 Samuel 2:26](#)). But Eli's sons were disrespectful and dishonest ([1 Samuel 2:12](#)). They stole from offerings and seduced women serving at the tabernacle. When Eli scolded them, they ignored him. God sent a prophet to criticize Eli's weakness and his sons' wrongdoing, announcing that God would remove the priesthood from Eli's family ([1 Samuel 2:27-36](#)). This message was confirmed when God spoke to Samuel one night, telling him that he would soon punish Eli's family ([1 Samuel 3:1-14](#)).

Soon after, Israel's army lost a battle to the Philistines, the ark of the covenant was captured, and Eli's sons died ([1 Samuel 4:1-11](#)). When Eli, who was ninety-eight years old, heard the news, he fell backward, broke his neck, and died ([1 Samuel 4:12-18](#)). His daughter-in-law went into labor and died while giving birth to Eli's grandson, named

Ichabod (meaning "where is the glory?," because the glory had left Israel ([1 Samuel 4:19-22](#))).

Eli's family continued serving as priests until King David died. Abiathar was the last of Eli's descendants to serve as chief priest. Solomon removed Abiathar from being priest because Abiathar had supported Adonijah, who tried to become king instead of Solomon. Solomon then made Zadok the chief priest ([1 Kings 2:27](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 1:9-18, 25-28; 1 Samuel 2:11-4:22; 1 Kings 2:27](#)

Elijah

Elijah from Tishbe was a prophet in Israel during the reigns of Ahab and Ahaziah, from 874 to 852 BC. His name means "my God is Yahweh." He showed that the Lord is the one true God and urged Israel to return to the Lord.

Under Ahab and Jezebel, Israel started worshiping Baal, a Canaanite god of fertility, storms, and rain. As a result, God sent a drought to Israel ([1 Kings 17:1](#)). Elijah hid until the drought ended, and God took care of him. During this time, he stayed with a widow in Zarephath, a town in Jezebel's home region of Sidon. The widow's son died, but Elijah prayed for him, and he came back to life ([1 Kings 17:8-24](#)).

In the third year of drought, Elijah challenged Baal's prophets to a contest on Mount Carmel to show who the true God was ([1 Kings 18:1-40](#)). The prophets of Baal called on Baal without success, becoming frantic to make him appear, while Elijah mocked Baal. When it was Elijah's turn, he poured water over his sacrifice and prayed a simple, powerful prayer. Fire immediately consumed the offering. In response, the people of Israel worshiped the Lord and, following Elijah's direction, killed Baal's prophets. Then Elijah prayed for rain, and the drought ended ([1 Kings 18:41-46](#)).

Despite God's great power, Ahab and Jezebel continued to mislead Israel. Jezebel was angry because her prophets were killed ([1 Kings 19:1-2](#)). She threatened Elijah, who escaped to the desert and asked God to end his life. Instead, an angel fed him until he reached Mount Sinai. Elijah complained that he was the only prophet left and that his life was in danger. God encouraged him

with a gentle voice, shared good news, and sent him back to serve ([1 Kings 19:3-18](#)).

Elijah was very dedicated to the true God. He trained an assistant named Elisha. At the end of Elijah's life on Earth, he did not die but was taken to heaven in a chariot of fire ([2 Kings 2:11-12](#)). Elisha took on Elijah's role as a prophet and continued to challenge false worship in Israel (see [2 Kings 2:1-9:13; 13:14-25](#)).

The Old Testament ends with the hope that Elijah will return before the day of the Lord ([Malachi 4:5-6](#)). John the Baptist partly fulfilled this expectation (see [Matthew 11:7-14; 17:10-13; Luke 1:17](#)). Elijah appeared with Moses during Jesus' transfiguration (when Jesus's appearance changed to show his divine glory; [Matthew 17:1-9](#)). In [Revelation 11:3-12](#), one of the two witnesses seems to be either Elijah himself or someone like him. Elijah's life shows God's kindness and the power of prayer ([Luke 4:25-26; Romans 11:2-6; James 5:17-18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 17:1-19:21; 21:1-29; 2 Kings 1:1-2:25; 9:36; 10:10, 17; 2 Chronicles 21:12-15; Malachi 4:5-6; Matthew 11:14; 16:14; 17:1-13; 27:45-49; Mark 6:15; 8:28; 9:2-13; 15:33-36; Luke 1:17; 4:26; 9:28-36; John 1:19-28; Romans 11:1-6; James 5:17](#)

Elisha

Elisha the prophet followed and succeeded Elijah in the northern kingdom of Israel during the late 800s BC. At that time, the leaders and people of the northern kingdom turned away from God and worshiped the Canaanite god Baal. Ahab and Jezebel were devoted worshipers of this false god, as were their descendants who followed them on the throne. Elisha's ministry lasted from 853 to 798 BC. It began as King Ahab's reign was ending. He played a key role in God's plan to remove Israel's idol-worshipping leaders.

Elisha began his work as a follower of Elijah and was chosen by God to replace him ([1 Kings 19:15-21; 2 Kings 2:1-18](#)). After Elijah went up to heaven, Elisha's miracles showed that God's great power was with him.

Elisha's miracles often involved water. He made the bad water of a spring near Jericho clean and made an ax head float ([2 Kings 2:19-22; 6:1-7](#)). When

King Joram ran out of water in enemy territory, Elisha accurately predicted that plenty of water would appear ([2 Kings 3:4-20](#)). People believed Baal controlled water, so these miracles showed that the Lord, not Baal, was truly in control.

Elisha showed God's power by helping people in real ways. He helped a poor woman by miraculously filling her jars with olive oil ([2 Kings 4:1-7](#)). He told a woman from Shunem she would have a son and later brought her son back to life ([2 Kings 4:8-37](#)). He healed an Aramean general named Naaman of leprosy ([2 Kings 5:1-19](#)). He also provided food for those in need ([2 Kings 4:38-44](#)).

Elisha played a role in God's plan to judge the northern kingdom. He anointed Jehu of Israel and Hazael of Aram ([2 Kings 8:7-15](#); [9:1-13](#)). He poured sacred oil on their heads to show God had chosen them. They violently ended the rule of Israel's leaders who promoted Baal worship (see [1 Kings 19:15-18](#)).

Elisha's miracles foreshadowed Jesus' work because Jesus:

- Healed people with leprosy ([Matthew 8:1-4](#))
- Brought the dead back to life ([Mark 5:21-43](#); [Luke 7:11-17](#); [John 11:1-44](#))
- Provided food in miraculous ways ([Matthew 14:13-21](#); [15:32-38](#))

Jesus spoke about healing Naaman to show that God's mercy extends beyond Israelites to gentiles ([Luke 4:27](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 19:15-21](#); [2 Kings 2:1-9](#); [13:14-21](#); [Luke 4:27](#)

Ephesus

Ephesus was at the crossroads of major trade routes, both north-south and east-west. It was famous as the "guardian" of the temple of Artemis ([Acts 19:35](#)). As guardian, Ephesus was officially recognized as the caretaker and protector of the temple. This was an important title that brought honor and economic benefits to the city.

Ionian Greeks founded Ephesus around 1044 BC on a natural harbor where the Cayster River flowed into a gulf of the Aegean Sea. Today, the ancient city's site is far inland. The city came under Roman

rule in 41 BC. During the time of the apostles, Ephesus was wealthy, serving as a commercial and religious center. It was the most important city in the Roman province of Asia.

The worship of Artemis in Ephesus was almost as old as the city. The temple of Artemis, one of the seven wonders of the ancient world, was crucial to Ephesus's wealth and trade. Pilgrims visiting for Artemis worship created many business opportunities for idol makers and other vendors.

When Paul arrived on his third missionary journey in AD 53, Ephesus had been a city for over a thousand years ([Acts 19](#)). The people were deeply devoted to their patron goddess and her temple. As more people accepted Paul's message, this reduced business for those who made and sold statues of Artemis. This made them angry, and they started a riot that almost killed Paul ([Acts 19:24, 28-31](#)).

The church of Ephesus grew strong under Paul's teaching and leadership. People who learned from Paul in Ephesus started churches in nearby communities, like Colossae (see Colossians Book Introduction, "Setting"). However, Paul warned the Ephesian church leaders about the threat of false teachers ([Acts 20:29-31](#)).

The apostle John likely settled in Ephesus around AD 70. From there, he was exiled to the island of Patmos ([Revelation 1:9](#)). John likely wrote Revelation while living on Patmos, probably in the AD 90s. By then, the Christian community's love and good works, praised in the letter to the Ephesians, had mostly faded ([Revelation 2:4](#)). According to the early Christian writer Irenaeus, John came back to Ephesus after his time on Patmos. He lived there until his death, which happened during the time when Trajan was emperor from AD 98 to 117. Tradition says that Mary, the mother of Jesus, also spent her final days in Ephesus under John's care (see [John 19:25-27](#)).

The Goths burned the Temple of Artemis in AD 262. The Goths were people from northern Europe who fought against the Roman Empire. By the time of the third ecumenical council (also called the Council of Ephesus) in Ephesus in AD 431, Artemis was no longer influential among the Ephesians. This change supports Paul's message that "man-made gods" like Artemis "are no gods at all" ([Acts 19:26](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 18:19-19:41](#); [20:16-38](#); [Ephesians 1:1](#); [Revelation 2:1-7](#)

Esau

Esau was the son of Isaac and Rebekah and Jacob's older twin brother ([Genesis 25:24-26](#)). He was named Esau because he was hairy at birth. His descendants became known as Edomites. "Edom" means "red," referring to:

- Esau's reddish color at birth ([Genesis 25:25](#))
- The red lentil stew he got from Jacob ([Genesis 25:30](#))
- The reddish color of the land where he settled (see study note on [Genesis 25:25](#))

Esau was a skilled hunter who brought flavorful wild meat to his father. Isaac preferred its strong taste over the mild meat Jacob provided from the family flocks. One day, Esau came home very hungry after an unsuccessful hunt. Jacob convinced Esau to give up his rights and privileges of being firstborn in exchange for food ([Genesis 25:29-34](#)). Esau did not value his birthright and was driven by his physical desires (see [Hebrews 12:16](#)).

He also married two local women who were not descendants of Abraham ([Genesis 26:34-35](#)). This may have influenced Rebekah's favoritism toward Jacob and her plan to take Isaac's blessing meant for Esau ([Genesis 27:1-40](#)). Esau's anger upon discovering his brother's deception caused Jacob to flee to Haran. The brothers reunited twenty years later when Esau showed gracious forgiveness ([Genesis 33:1-16](#)).

Esau was born with Jacob holding his heel. People saw this as a sign that Esau's descendants would serve Jacob's descendants. The Edomites began serving the Israelites during David's time ([2 Samuel 8:11-15](#); [1 Chronicles 18:11-13](#)) and continued until Jehoram's reign ([2 Kings 8:20-22](#); [2 Chronicles 21:8-10](#)). After a rebellion in 845 BC, the Edomites briefly gained independence but were conquered again by Amaziah, who ruled from 796 to 767 BC. They regained their freedom in 735 BC and stayed independent from Judah.

In the New Testament, Esau symbolizes Abraham's descendants who did not have faith and were rejected by God for his promised blessings (see [Romans 9:6-24](#)). Herod the Great was an Edomite.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 25:21-34](#); [26:34-35](#); [27:1-42](#); [28:6-9](#); [32:3-20](#); [33:1-16](#); [35:28-29](#); [36:1-43](#); [Deuteronomy 2:1-8](#), [12](#), [22](#), [29](#); [Joshua 24:4](#); [Malachi 1:2-5](#); [Romans 9:6-13](#); [Hebrews 11:20](#); [12:16-17](#)

Esther

Esther was queen of Persia during the reign of Xerxes I (also called Ahasuerus), who ruled from 486 to 465 BC. She was part of the *Diaspora* ("scattering"), descended from Jews who had been scattered among the nations during the exile in Babylon. Her family had not returned to Judah, unlike some Jews (see [Ezra 1-2](#)), but chose to stay in Persia, like many others. Her cousin Mordecai's important role in the Persian government suggests her family had become wealthy and comfortable.

Esther was an orphan raised by her cousin Mordecai, a minor official in the Persian government in Susa. She became queen after King Xerxes removed Queen Vashti for refusing to attend a banquet when he commanded her to do so ([Esther 1:11-12](#)).

After Esther's coronation, she quietly gained Xerxes' trust by telling him about an assassination plot ([Esther 2:21-23](#)). This later allowed her to save her people from a massacre planned by Haman, a high official to the king. Through her wise advice and brave actions, Esther exposed Haman. He was executed, and the Jewish people were saved. The Jewish Festival of Purim was created to celebrate these events.

Passages for Further Study

[Esther 2:7-20](#); [4:4-5:8](#); [7:1-9:32](#)

Ezekiel

Ezekiel was a priest and prophet. He was born around 623 BC. He likely grew up in Jerusalem and was married ([Ezekiel 24:16-18](#)). In 597 BC, he went into exile in Babylon with Jehoiachin and lived by the Kebar River. He received his calling as a prophet in Babylon on July 31, 593 BC ([Ezekiel 1:1](#)). We learn about his personal life from the book named after him.

Ezekiel often used unusual actions to emphasize his prophetic messages from God. For example, he demonstrated the severe food shortage during Jerusalem's final siege by eating food cooked over

dung ([Ezekiel 4:12](#)). Another time, he lay still for 430 days, with each day representing a year of Israel's and Judah's sin ([Ezekiel 4:4-7](#)). When Ezekiel's wife died suddenly, he was not allowed to mourn her publicly ([Ezekiel 24:16-18](#)); her death served as a serious warning of what would happen in Judah ([Ezekiel 24:15-27](#)). Ezekiel's unusual actions were meant to capture people's attention.

Initially, people rejected Ezekiel's messages. However, his prophecies were proven true, and the nation stopped worshipping false gods. He taught about holiness, purity, resurrection, and ritual law (religious rules and practices). His hopeful message encouraged exiles to stay faithful during their captivity. After their return, it inspired them to look forward to greater fulfillment.

We do not know how Ezekiel died, and he is not mentioned elsewhere in the Old Testament. The New Testament refers to Ezekiel's prophecies over sixty times, mostly in the book of Revelation. Ezekiel's prophetic vision looked beyond his near future to the final judgment (God's final decision about all people) and the great hope of heaven.

Passages for Further Study

[Ezekiel 2:1-10](#); [24:15-27](#)

Ezra

Ezra was a priest and scribe (teacher and copier of Scripture). He came from an important family of high priests descended from Zadok ([Ezra 7:1-5, 11-12](#); see also [Nehemiah 8:2, 9](#)). He led in Judah after the Jews returned from exile. As a scribe, Ezra was more than a copyist; he was a dedicated student of God's laws ([Ezra 7:6](#)). He was qualified to teach, preach, and explain the Scriptures.

Ezra, an important official who helped the king with Jewish matters in the Persian Empire, visited Jerusalem around 458 BC. He brought items for the Temple and aimed to establish God's laws and the laws of Persia. One of his first actions was to address the issue of intermarriage with non-Jewish neighbors ([Ezra 9:1-10:44](#)). Later, after the city walls were rebuilt in 445 BC ([Nehemiah 6:15](#)), Ezra led the community to follow God's law more closely ([Nehemiah 8:13-15](#)).

Ezra honored God by managing finances well. The Persian king trusted Ezra's judgment and let him request more money when needed ([Ezra 7:15-20](#)). Ezra gave financial responsibilities to others

whenever possible and demanded strict financial honesty ([Ezra 8:24-30](#)). He identified some financial resources as sacred and belonging to God.

Ezra humbled himself before God when the people began their journey ([Ezra 8:21-23](#)), when he learned about the people's unholy marriages ([Ezra 9:5-15](#)), and when he gathered those required to divorce their pagan wives ([10:6](#)). He always recognized that God's gracious hand—not his own ability or wisdom—made good things happen ([Ezra 7:6, 9, 28](#); [8:18, 22, 31](#); [9:8-9](#)). He studied and lived by God's Word and taught others to follow what God revealed ([Ezra 7:10](#)). He was a teacher and servant-leader, not a self-important official who dominated others.

Ezra showed his devotion through prayer and fasting. This showed his strong desire to help people follow God. He set an example for life in the Jewish community after the exile, focusing on God's Word and worship as main priorities.

Passages for Further Study

[Ezra 7:1-10:44](#); [Nehemiah 8:1-18](#); [12:1, 26, 36](#)

Gideon

Gideon was an Israelite judge and the son of Joash from the tribe of Manasseh. He said his clan was the weakest in Manasseh, and he was the least important in his clan. His story shows how God can use a weak person for great purposes.

During this period, Midian oppressed Israel, and the people cried out to God for help ([Judges 6:6](#)). In response, God sent a prophet to reprimand them for ignoring Him and worshipping other gods. He also sent His angel to call Gideon to save Israel.

Gideon's first appearance is not promising. He was threshing wheat at the bottom of a winepress to hide from the Midianites. When the angel of the Lord appeared to Gideon there, Gideon asked why God had not saved his people like during the Exodus. God told Gideon that he was chosen to be Israel's deliverer and that God would be with him. Gideon was hesitant to believe and asked for a sign. He brought an offering, and when the angel touched it, fire came from the rock beneath.

This sign gave Gideon enough faith to take action in his community. God instructed him to tear down his father's altar to Baal, cut down the Asherah pole, and build an altar to the Lord instead. Gideon

obeyed God's command and became a warrior for God against false gods.

The Spirit of God came upon Gideon, and he gathered an army to fight the Midianites and their allies. Gideon remained cautious and asked God for another sign to confirm his mission. He placed a fleece outside on two different nights, asking God to show his power by making the dew settle on the fleece and the ground in miraculous ways. God did this, and Gideon was ready to follow God's plan.

Gideon successfully recruited 32,000 men for the army. However, God instructed him to reduce the number to 300 men. Gideon led these 300 men against a much larger force and won.

Gideon wisely refused the people's request to become their ruler. However, he made an ephod from the earrings of the defeated soldiers, and it became an idol ([Judges 8:22-27](#)). Gideon, who was weak in faith and relied on visible signs, eventually turned away from worshiping the invisible God and worshiped idols. Israel experienced peace during his lifetime, but his lack of faith led to problems after his death ([Judges 8:33-9:57](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Judges 6:1-8:35](#); [1 Samuel 12:11](#); [Isaiah 10:26](#); [Hebrews 11:32](#)

Hagar

Hagar was the Egyptian servant of Sarai, Abram's wife. When God told Abram to leave Mesopotamia, He promised Abram many descendants and a new land ([Genesis 12:2, 7](#)). After ten years in Canaan without children, Sarai followed a Mesopotamian custom. She gave Hagar to Abram as a concubine (secondary wife). Any son from this union was considered the wife's child (see [Genesis 30:1-8](#)).

Hagar became pregnant and started disrespecting Sarai. Sarai reacted by treating her harshly, so Hagar ran away into the desert ([Genesis 16:4-6](#)). An angel of the Lord appeared to her at a desert well and told her to return to Abram's house and obey Sarai.

Hagar gave birth to a son named Ishmael when Abram was eighty-six years old ([Genesis 16:1-16](#)).

Fourteen years later, God gave Abraham and Sarah their promised son, Isaac. When Isaac was weaned, around age three, they held a traditional feast. During the event, Ishmael mocked Isaac ([Genesis](#)

[21:9](#)), so Sarah insisted that Abraham send Hagar and Ishmael away. God supported this decision ([Genesis 21:12](#)), so Hagar and Ishmael left to wander in the wilderness of Beersheba. When their water ran out, God miraculously saved them and promised Hagar that Ishmael would become the father of a great nation ([Genesis 21:17-19](#)).

Paul used an analogy in [Galatians 4:22-31](#) where Hagar symbolizes Mount Sinai, the place of the old covenant (God's special agreement with the Israelites). Sarah symbolizes the heavenly Jerusalem, the community of those who gain salvation through faith in Christ. Just as Isaac was Abraham's son through faith in God's promise, Christians who are free from the law are spiritual children of Sarah.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 16:1-16](#); [21:9-21](#); [25:12](#); [Galatians 4:22-31](#)

Hellenistic Kingdoms

For 300 years after Alexander's death in 323 BC, Greek kings ruled the lands he had conquered. During this time, Greek ways of life, beliefs, and customs spread throughout these lands. This spread of Greek culture is called Hellenization. It allowed both Jewish and Greek learning to thrive.

However, it also created problems for the Jewish people because Greek customs often went against Jewish beliefs. These problems became very serious in the 160s BC. Greek rulers tried to force the Jewish people to abandon their faith. Greek culture later mixed with Roman rule to prepare the way for the Messiah (God's chosen one), just as the prophet Daniel had said would happen. This era's history is accurately described in several of Daniel's prophecies (see [Daniel 7:6](#); [8:8-14](#), [21-26](#); [11:4-45](#)).

Successors (*Diadochoi*), 323 to 301 BC

After Alexander died suddenly in 323 BC, his top generals fought for power and control. These generals were called *diadochoi*, meaning "successors."

6. *Ptolemy I* was one of Alexander the Great's strongest and most capable Macedonian generals. He became the governor of Egypt in 323 BC, the year Alexander died, and he ruled Egypt successfully until his death in 285 BC.
7. *Antigonos* was a high-ranking general in Alexander's army and acted as the active regent for much of Alexander's empire. In 315 BC, Antigonos invaded Syria and Palestine. However, his attempt to reunite the empire did not succeed, and he died in battle in 301 BC.
8. *Seleucus I*, one of Alexander's high-ranking generals, became the governor of Babylon in 321 BC. When he learned about Antigonos's plans to reunite the empire, he sought protection from Ptolemy in Egypt in 316 BC. After regaining control of Babylon in 315 BC and Syria in 312 BC, he ruled until his death in 281 BC.
9. *Lysimachus* became the governor of Thrace and Bithynia (in Asia Minor, modern-day Turkey) after Alexander died.
10. *Cassander* served as the governor of Macedonia until 294 BC. Demetrius I, the son of Antigonos, then took control of Macedonia and Achaia. He founded the Antigonid dynasty, which ruled until the Romans took over Greece after the Battle of Pydna in 168 BC.

Alexander's empire was divided into four kingdoms ruled by Macedonian Greeks:

11. Egypt
12. Babylon and Syria
13. Macedonia and Achaia
14. Parts of Asia Minor

During the 200s BC, the Ptolemies and the Seleucids fought many wars over Palestine. [Daniel 11](#) accurately describes this conflict.

Ptolemies, 323 to 30 BC

Ptolemy I and his descendants (known as the "king of the south" in [Daniel 11](#)) ruled Egypt for nearly three hundred years. After Ptolemy I took control of Judea in 319 BC, he moved some Jewish people to Alexandria. This city became a large and important Jewish community and a center for both Jewish and Greek learning. The Septuagint, the Greek translation of the Old Testament, was created in Alexandria during this time. Although the Ptolemies were worshiped as gods and spread Greek culture in Egypt, they were generally tolerant of the Jews and their belief in one God. The Ptolemaic dynasty ended with Cleopatra VII's death when Rome took control of Egypt in 30 BC.

Seleucid Empire, 321 to 64 BC

Seleucus I and his descendants (known as the "king of the north" in [Daniel 11](#)) ruled Syria and, for a time, Babylon until the Roman general Pompey took control of Syria in 64 BC. The Seleucids, like the Ptolemies, spread Greek culture and the worship of rulers in their territories. However, they were less tolerant of the Jews' refusal to participate than the Ptolemies.

After the Seleucid king Antiochus III took control of Judea around 200 BC, he gave important jobs and authority to Jews who adopted Greek ways of living. His son, Antiochus IV, harshly persecuted the Jews. He executed those who observed the Sabbath, kept copies of the Torah, or refused to worship at the altar of Zeus (the main Greek god) that he set up in the temple in Jerusalem. This event is noted in Daniel as the "abomination of desolation" ([Daniel 11:31](#)). This persecution led to the revolt of the Jewish priest Mattathias and his sons. The Jewish state gained some freedom to rule themselves for nearly one hundred years under their descendants, the Hasmoneans.

Passages for Further Study

[Daniel 11:4-39](#)

Herod Agrippa I

Herod Agrippa I was the grandson of Herod the Great, the nephew of Herod Antipas, and the brother of Herodias. Agrippa I ruled all of Palestine for a short time after Jesus's death, during the early days of the Christian movement, from AD 41 to 44.

While attending school in Rome, Agrippa lived recklessly and accumulated many debts. He once expressed a wish for his friend Gaius Caligula to be emperor instead of Tiberius. Someone reported this to Tiberius, who then imprisoned Agrippa. He stayed in prison until Tiberius died six months later.

When Caligula became emperor, he rewarded Agrippa by freeing him and giving him Philip the Tetrarch's lands and the northern part of Lysanias's territory, along with the title of king. This title made Herodias jealous, and her husband, Herod Antipas, was both critical and envious of Agrippa. Agrippa accused Antipas of conspiracy, leading to Antipas's banishment. Agrippa then took over all of Antipas's lands and property in AD 39.

When his friend Caligula died in AD 41, Agrippa gained favor with the new emperor, Claudius. Claudius then added Judea and Samaria to Agrippa's domain. This territory was once ruled by his grandfather, Herod the Great.

Agrippa actively persecuted early Christians. He is known for killing the apostle James and arresting Peter, actions that pleased the Jews ([Acts 12:1-4](#)). The Jews liked him more than any other Herod. Agrippa died suddenly in AD 44, soon after his subjects praised him as a god ([Acts 12:20-23](#); see also Josephus, *Antiquities* 19.8.2; 19.9.1; *War* 2.11.5).

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 12:1-4, 18-23](#)

Herod Agrippa II

Herod Agrippa II was the son of Herod Agrippa I. He became king after his father and ruled in Palestine from AD 50 to 100. He eventually controlled about the same area as his great-grandfather, Herod the Great. Agrippa II managed the temple treasury and could appoint the high priest. He was unpopular among Jews because of his inappropriate sexual relationship with his sister Bernice. The Romans asked for his advice on religious matters. This is likely why Festus invited him to hear the apostle Paul's defense at Caesarea in AD 59 ([Acts 25:13-26:32](#)).

In May AD 66, the Jewish war against the Romans began (Josephus, *War* 2.14.4). When Agrippa's attempt to stop the revolt failed, he became a strong ally of the Romans throughout the war from

AD 66 to 70. During this time, Nero killed himself, the new emperor Galba was murdered, and Vespasian became the emperor. After pledging loyalty to Vespasian, Agrippa joined Titus, Vespasian's son, who led the war effort (Tacitus, *History* 5.81). After Jerusalem fell on August 6, AD 70, Agrippa likely attended the celebration of his people's defeat.

In AD 79, Vespasian died, and Titus became emperor. Little is known about Agrippa's rule after this. However, he wrote to the historian Josephus, praising him for *The Jewish War*, and he bought a copy of it (Josephus, *Life* 65; *Against Apion* 1.9.47-52).

The Talmud suggests Agrippa II had two wives (Babylonian Talmud, *Sukkah* 27a). However, Josephus does not mention any wives or children. Agrippa II died around AD 100, ending the Herod family of kings.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 25:13-26:32](#)

Herod Antipas

Herod Antipas was the sixth son of Herod the Great. He ruled Galilee and Perea from 4 BC to AD 39. This was during Jesus's lifetime. He ruled areas where Jesus and John the Baptist focused their work.

Herod Antipas, like his father, founded cities. Sepphoris, his first project, became the largest city in Galilee. It served as Antipas's capital until he built Tiberias, named after Emperor Tiberius, who ruled from AD 14 to 37. Tiberias was on the western shore of the Sea of Galilee. Antipas completed it in AD 23 and made it his capital.

Herod Antipas upset many Jews by divorcing his wife and marrying Herodias, who was his half-brother, Herod Philip's wife. This marriage broke the law of Moses because Herod's brother Philip was still alive ([Leviticus 18:16; 20:21](#)). When John the Baptist strongly criticized this unlawful marriage, Antipas imprisoned him ([Mark 6:17-18](#)). Herod feared that John's criticism would cause an uprising against him (*Antiquities* 18.5.2). Later, at a banquet, Herodias's daughter impressed Herod with her dancing. This led him to make a reckless promise to give her anything she wanted. Herodias used this chance to have John beheaded ([Matthew 14:1-12](#)).

When Jesus was finally arrested, Pilate could find no fault in Jesus, so he sent him to Herod Antipas, who was in Jerusalem for Passover. Pilate may also have been attempting to improve his relationship with Antipas. Their relationship had been troubled since the massacre in Galilee ([Luke 13:1](#)). Pilate had also brought shields with the image of Tiberius to Jerusalem. These were blasphemous to the Jews (Philo, *On the Embassy to Gaius* 299–304). These actions greatly disrespected God and his laws, which deeply offended the Jewish people. When Jesus was brought before Antipas, Herod only mocked him and sent him back to Pilate ([Luke 23:6–11](#)). The main political effect of this event was that Herod and Pilate's relationship improved ([Luke 23:12](#)).

Herod Antipas was later defeated in war by King Aretas, whose daughter he had divorced. Jews saw this defeat as divine judgment. Later, in AD 39, Emperor Gaius removed Antipas from power. He exiled Antipas after Herod Agrippa I accused him of plotting against Rome.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 14:1–12](#); [Mark 1:14](#); [6:14–29](#); [Luke 3:1](#), [19–20](#); [9:7–9](#); [13:31–33](#); [23:7–12](#), [15](#); [Acts 4:27](#)

Herod the Great

Herod the Great was the Roman-appointed king of Judea from 37 to 4 BC. Herod the Great was king when Jesus was born ([Matthew 2:1](#); [Luke 1:5](#)). He was a strong military leader, a skilled politician, and a harsh ruler. He was born into an Idumean (Edomite) family with Roman connections. He gained power by making the Romans like him, and he kept this power by being cruel to anyone who opposed him.

Herod was famous for his large building projects. His greatest achievement was rebuilding and beautifying the Jerusalem Temple, which began around 20 BC (Josephus, *Antiquities* 15.8.1). This made it one of the most impressive buildings in the ancient world. He also built Caesarea and made it the Roman headquarters in Palestine. Herod earned the title "the Great" due to his reputation as an excellent builder.

Herod was known for his family problems and harsh treatment of opponents or perceived threats. He killed two of his wives and three of his sons when he suspected them of plotting against him. Caesar Augustus once said he would rather be

Herod's *swine* (pig) than his *son* (a play on words in Greek since the two words sound alike—*hus*, *huios*). When Jesus was born near the end of Herod's reign and Herod heard him called a future "king," he tried to have him killed. Unable to find the boy, Herod ordered the killing of all boys under two years old in the Bethlehem area (see [Matthew 2:1–20](#)). This act was typical of his cruelty and paranoia.

Herod was called "king of the Jews," but the Jewish people did not accept him as their true king. He was not from King David's family line and was an Edomite, a descendant of Esau, not a Jew.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 2:1–20](#); [Luke 1:5](#)

Hezekiah

Hezekiah was one of Judah's best kings. He ruled from 728 to 686 BC. His father, Ahaz, stopped worshipping God. But Hezekiah encouraged true worship of God. He fixed the temple doors, had the Levites prepare themselves for holy service, and restarted religious ceremonies. He offered sacrifices, restored the priestly temple service, and invited people from Judah and Israel to celebrate Passover in Jerusalem ([2 Chronicles 29–30](#)). After the celebration, he destroyed pagan worship sites.

After Hezekiah began his rule, the Assyrians, led by Shalmaneser V and later Sargon II, defeated the northern kingdom. They deported its people and brought in foreigners in 722 BC. When Sargon II died in 705 BC, his son Sennacherib took power, causing widespread rebellion. Hezekiah stopped paying the tribute his father Ahaz had paid ([2 Kings 18:7](#); see [16:7](#)). As a result, in 701 BC, Sennacherib invaded Judah. Hezekiah tried to appease the Assyrian ruler with a large tribute, but this failed. The Assyrian forces threatened Jerusalem and mocked Hezekiah's trust in the Lord ([2 Kings 18:17–35](#)). Hezekiah responded with mourning and prayer. The Lord, through the prophet Isaiah, assured Hezekiah that his prayers were heard and that Sennacherib would not conquer Jerusalem ([2 Kings 19:1–34](#)).

Around that time, Hezekiah became very ill ([2 Kings 20:1–11](#)). Isaiah told him to prepare for death, but Hezekiah prayed to the Lord for healing. The Lord promised him fifteen more years of life and deliverance from the Assyrians. After he recovered, Hezekiah unwisely hosted the

Babylonian king Merodach-baladan in his palace. He showed him the temple treasures and sought support from Babylon instead of the Lord. Isaiah predicted that those treasures would be taken to Babylon ([2 Kings 20:12-19](#)).

After the Assyrian threat in 701 BC, Hezekiah enjoyed peaceful and successful years. He died in 686 BC, and his son Manasseh succeeded him.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Kings 18:1-20:21](#); [2 Chronicles 28:27-32:33](#); [Isaiah 36:1-39:8](#)

Hittites

For many years, only the Bible mentioned the Hittite people. Some scholars questioned whether the Bible's historical accounts about the Hittites were accurate. They thought the Hittites were not a real people. However, archaeologists and historians have uncovered information about them.

The Hittites had an empire centered in Asia Minor, with their capital at Hattusha (modern Baghazkoy). The empire grew much larger because many cities signed agreements to follow its rule. These cities were not officially part of the empire's territory, but they had to do what the empire said. The Hittite armies were strong enough to challenge the Egyptian armies under the proud Rameses II, who ruled from 1279 to 1213 BC. The Hittites fought Rameses II at Kadesh on the Orontes around 1274 BC. Neither side won the battle. During the time of Abraham and the other early fathers of Israel, the Hittite people controlled cities in Canaan, such as Hebron.

Heth, the ancestor of the Hittites, is the second son of Canaan in the "table of nations" ([Genesis 10:15](#); see also [1 Chronicles 1:13](#) and the footnote there). Most mentions of Heth's sons are in the story of Abraham buying the cave of Machpelah ([Genesis 23](#)). Later, God told the Israelites to destroy all Hittites in the promised land ([Deuteronomy 7:1-2](#)). But the Israelites did not fully obey God ([1 Kings 9:20-21](#)). Some of David's best warriors were Hittites ([1 Samuel 26:6](#); [2 Samuel 11-12](#)). Solomon traded with Hittite kings ([1 Kings 10:29-11:1](#)). The Bible shows that the Hittites were important people.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 23:3-20](#); [26:34-35](#); [27:46-28:2](#); [Deuteronomy 7:1](#); [1 Samuel 26:6](#); [2 Samuel 11:2-27](#); [1 Kings 9:20](#)

Isaac

The name Isaac means "he laughs," which reflects how he was born. When God promised Isaac's birth, both Abraham and Sarah laughed in disbelief ([Genesis 17:15-19](#); [18:9-15](#)). God had promised Abraham a son ([Genesis 15:4-6](#)). But, no son had come, and Abraham and Sarah were too old to have children. So, when Isaac was born, they laughed with joy ([Genesis 21:6-7](#)).

When Isaac was a teenager, God tested Abraham by telling him to sacrifice Isaac ([Genesis 22:1-19](#)). Abraham's faith stayed strong. He obeyed and Isaac submitted to his. God then intervened and provided a ram to sacrifice instead of Isaac. Because of Abraham's faith, God promised him great blessings ([Genesis 22:15-18](#)).

Isaac married Rebekah and was ready to continue the chosen family line, but Rebekah could not have children ([Genesis 25:21](#)). Instead of trying to solve problems by himself as his father had done (see [Genesis 16:1-16](#)), Isaac prayed to the Lord, and Rebekah gave birth to twin sons. Isaac preferred Esau, the older son, while Rebekah preferred Jacob. This favoritism led to Jacob deceiving Isaac when he was old and blind ([Genesis 27:1-40](#)). Favoritism continued to be an issue among Isaac's descendants (see [Genesis 29:30](#); [33:1-2](#); [37:4](#)).

Isaac followed his father Abraham's example in dealing with nearby nations. During a famine, he visited another kingdom and, out of fear, said his wife was his sister ([Genesis 26:1-11](#); compare [12:10-20](#); [20:1-18](#)). Like his father, Isaac became wealthy in that land and was asked to leave ([Genesis 26:12-16](#); compare [12:16-20](#)). He faced disputes over water and land with other herdsmen ([Genesis 26:17-22](#); compare [21:25-31](#)). He also made a treaty with the king of the Philistines ([Genesis 26:26-31](#); compare [21:22-32](#)).

Isaac received the same promise as his father ([Genesis 26:2-5](#), [23-25](#); compare [22:16-18](#)). He showed his commitment by continuing the practice of circumcision, which symbolized the covenant (see [Acts 7:8](#)). As the child of promise, Isaac represents all who are Abraham's children through faith in Christ. They are free to live as God's children, not as slaves (see [Galatians 4:21-5:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 17:19-21](#); [21:1-12](#); [22:1-19](#); [24:1-8](#), [14:62-67](#); [25:5-11](#), [19-28](#); [26:1-28:9](#); [31:42](#); [35:12, 27-28](#); [48:15-16](#); [49:31](#); [Exodus 3:6](#); [Joshua 24:3-4](#); [Romans 9:6-10](#); [Galatians 4:21-31](#); [Hebrews 11:8-9](#), [17-20](#)

Isaiah

Isaiah was a prophet from Judah during the reigns of Uzziah, Jotham, Ahaz, and Hezekiah. He was the son of Amoz ([Isaiah 1:1](#)). He might have been related to King Amaziah. Isaiah lived in Jerusalem, was well-educated, and greatly understood human nature. He served as a prophet for a long time, from about 740 to 685 BC. As Judah's political and religious advisor, he had access to kings and was likely the court historian ([2 Chronicles 26:22; 32:32](#)). Isaiah's wife was called a "prophetess" (see Study Note on [Isaiah 8:3](#)). Their sons were Shear-jashub and Maher-shalal-hash-baz ([Isaiah 7:3; 8:3](#)).

Isaiah opposed all social and political evil. He criticized fortune-tellers and rebuked kings for their stubbornness and indifference. He condemned wealthy, influential people who ignored their duties. He urged everyone to follow God's covenant. Isaiah opposed Canaanite idolatry and insincere religious practices ([Isaiah 1:10-17; 29:13](#)). He warned of judgment and stated that only a righteous few would survive ([Isaiah 6:11-13](#)). He predicted the coming Messiah, a peaceful prince of God's kingdom ([Isaiah 9:6-7](#); [11:1-11](#)). The Messiah would also be an obedient, suffering servant ([53:3-12](#)). The book of Isaiah has more connections to the New Testament than any other Old Testament book and is often quoted by New Testament authors.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Kings 19:1-20:19](#); [2 Chronicles 26:22; 32:20, 32](#); [Isaiah 1:1-66:24](#); [Matthew 3:3](#); [4:14-16](#); [8:17; 12:17-21](#); [13:14-15](#); [15:7-9](#); [Mark 1:2-3](#); [7:6-7](#); [Luke 3:4-6](#); [4:17-19](#); [John 1:23](#); [12:38-41](#); [Acts 8:28-34](#); [28:25-27](#); [Romans 9:27-29](#); [10:15-16, 20-21](#); [15:12](#); [Galatians 4:27](#)

Ishmael

Ishmael was Abraham's first son, born to Hagar, Sarah's Egyptian servant. The boy was born near Hebron when Abraham was eighty-six years old

([Genesis 13:18](#); [16:16](#)). God promised to make a great nation from the childless Abraham ([Genesis 12:2](#)). God assured him he would have a son as his heir ([15:4](#)). Ishmael was born when Abraham tried to fulfill God's promise by human means (see [Genesis 16:1-16](#); [Galatians 4:23](#)). But God would still achieve his purposes through Sarah (see [Genesis 17:15-18:15](#); [21:1-7](#)).

God said Sarah would have a son to fulfill the promise ([Genesis 17:15-16](#)). Abraham asked God to accept Ishmael ([17:17-18](#)). Ishmael was not the promised son because God's special agreement (covenant) would be with Isaac ([Genesis 17:19](#)). Still, God blessed Ishmael and made him the father of a great nation ([Genesis 17:20-21](#)).

When Ishmael was thirteen, he was circumcised as part of God's covenant with Abraham ([Genesis 17:9-14, 23-27](#)). At Isaac's weaning celebration, when Ishmael was about seventeen, he mocked Isaac ([Genesis 21:9](#)). As a result, Abraham sent Ishmael and Hagar away with supplies. An angel of God helped Hagar survive in the wilderness, and Ishmael became a hunter. He settled in the wilderness of Paran and married an Egyptian woman ([Genesis 21:20-21](#)). Ishmael helped bury Abraham ([Genesis 25:9-10](#)). He gave his daughter Mahalath in marriage to Esau ([28:9](#)). Abraham died at age 137 ([25:17](#)). His twelve sons are listed in [Genesis 25:13-15](#).

Paul mentioned Ishmael to encourage the Galatians to trust in God instead of the law (see [Galatians 4:21-31](#)). Those who rely on the law will not inherit the kingdom, just as the slave woman's son did not inherit with the free woman's son ([Galatians 4:30](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 16:11-16](#); [Genesis 17:18-26](#); [21:8-21](#); [25:9-18](#); [28:9](#); [Galatians 4:21-31](#)

Jacob

Jacob was the younger twin son of Isaac and Rebekah. He struggled with his twin brother Esau in the womb and was born holding Esau's heel ([Genesis 25:21-26](#)). God told Rebekah that the boys symbolized two nations and that the older son would serve the younger ([Genesis 25:23](#)).

Isaac favored Esau, who loved the outdoors, while Rebekah preferred Jacob, who enjoyed staying at home. One day, Esau came back very hungry from

hunting, and Jacob traded him some red stew for his inheritance rights ([Genesis 25:27-34](#); see [Hebrews 12:16](#)). Later, Isaac asked Esau to prepare wild game for him to eat so he could bless him ([Genesis 27:1-4](#); compare [25:28](#)). However, Rebekah sent Jacob to trick Isaac into giving him the blessing instead, and her plan worked ([Genesis 27:5-29](#)). Jacob's deception was soon discovered ([Genesis 27:30-35](#)). But legally, valid blessings were unchangeable promises ([27:33](#)). So Isaac gave Esau a lesser blessing ([Genesis 27:36-40](#)). Esau planned to kill Jacob ([27:41](#)). Rebekah persuaded Isaac to send Jacob to her brother Laban so Jacob could marry within the family ([Genesis 27:42-46](#)).

Isaac gave the covenant promises to Jacob and sent him to Haran ([Genesis 28:1-5](#)). On the way, God appeared to Jacob in a dream and confirmed the promises of land and descendants given to Abraham and Isaac ([Genesis 28:10-15](#)). Jacob worshiped the Lord and named the place Bethel, meaning "house of God."

In Haran, Jacob worked for his uncle Laban ([Genesis 29-31](#)). Jacob loved Laban's daughter Rachel and worked seven years to marry her. However, Laban tricked him by giving him his older daughter Leah on the wedding night. Jacob then worked another seven years for Rachel and six more years to build his own flocks ([Genesis 30:25-43](#); see also [31:38-42](#)). Despite many challenges, he had thirteen children and became very wealthy.

After twenty years, God told Jacob to return to Canaan ([Genesis 31:3](#)). Jacob feared Laban and his sons ([Genesis 31:1-2](#)). So, he organized his caravan and left while Laban was away ([31:4-21](#)). Laban chased after him, but God stopped him from harming Jacob ([Genesis 31:22-24, 29](#)). Instead, Laban scolded Jacob for leaving secretly and accused him of stealing his idols ([Genesis 31:25-30](#)). Jacob allowed Laban to search his tents, but the idols were not found ([Genesis 31:33-35](#)). Jacob then became angry ([Genesis 31:36-42](#)). Although their conflict was unresolved, the two men made a peace agreement ([Genesis 31:43-54](#)). The location became a lasting boundary between Israel and Aram.

Jacob now faced Esau and God. When Esau came with four hundred men, Jacob asked for God's protection and sent gifts to make peace with his brother, whom he had not seen for many years ([Genesis 32:3-21](#)). That night, in an event symbolizing his life, Jacob wrestled with a man who dislocated his hip and gave him the blessing he

wanted ([Genesis 32:22-32](#)). God also changed his name to Israel, meaning "God fights."

In the morning, Jacob met Esau, and they reconciled ([Genesis 33:1-11](#)). Esau was kind and forgiving, and Jacob shared some of his blessings. Esau then returned to Seir, while Jacob continued to Canaan. In Shechem, Jacob bought land and built an altar ([Genesis 33:18-20](#)). He then moved to Bethel and removed all foreign idols from his household ([Genesis 35:1-8](#)). God reaffirmed Jacob's new name, Israel, and renewed his promises of land and descendants ([Genesis 35:9-15](#)).

Jacob favored Rachel and her son Joseph ([Genesis 37:1-3](#)). Joseph's brothers grew jealous and hated him. Joseph's dreams made them angrier ([Genesis 37:4-11](#)), so they sold him as a slave ([Genesis 37:12-28](#)). For over twenty years, Jacob thought Joseph was dead. Jacob only learned Joseph was alive after sending Benjamin to Egypt with Judah. Joseph then helped his family during the famine ([Genesis 43:1-14; 45:24-28](#)). Jacob felt renewed and moved to Egypt. He joyfully reunited with Joseph in Goshen ([Genesis 46:28-30](#)) and thrived for seventeen more years.

When Jacob was near death at age 147, he planned for his family's future. He made Joseph promise to bury him in Canaan ([Genesis 47:29-31; 49:29-32](#)). He gave Joseph's sons his main blessing and placed Ephraim, the younger son, first ([Genesis 48:1-20](#)). He assured the family they would return to Canaan ([Genesis 48:21-22](#)). Then he blessed each of his sons and predicted the future of their descendants ([Genesis 49:1-28](#)). He died and was buried in the cave of Machpelah, accompanied by his sons and a large Egyptian procession ([Genesis 49:33-50:13](#)). His death marked the end of the patriarchal age and the start of Israel's growth as a nation in Egypt until they returned to live in the promised land (see Exodus—Joshua).

The name "Jacob" became another name for the nation of Israel (see [Numbers 23:7, 21; 24:5; Hosea 12:2](#)). God called the nation to serve him as their ancestors did ([Hosea 12:3-14](#)). He promised Israel the same love he showed Jacob ([Malachi 1:2](#)). He also promised that a powerful leader would come from Jacob's descendants ([Genesis 49:8-12; Numbers 24:17-19](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 25:19-34; 27:1-35:29; 37:1-35; 42:1-4, 29-38; 43:1-13; 45:25-50:14; Exodus 1:1-5; Numbers 23:7-10, 20-23; 24:5-9, 17-19;](#)

[Deuteronomy 26:5](#); [Joshua 24:4, 32](#); [Hosea 12:2-14](#); [Malachi 1:2](#); [John 4:5-6, 12](#); [Acts 7:8-16](#); [Romans 9:10-13](#); [Hebrews 11:8-9, 20-21](#)

James, Brother of Jesus

James was one of Jesus' brothers ([Matthew 13:55](#); [Mark 6:3](#); [Galatians 1:19](#); compare [Jude 1:1](#)). He became the leader of the church in Jerusalem soon after Jesus rose from the dead. According to tradition, this James is the author of the New Testament book of James.

Jesus' brothers were initially doubtful of his claims ([John 7:2-5](#)). But they later became believers ([Acts 1:14](#)). James's personal encounter with the risen Jesus might have convinced him ([1 Corinthians 15:7](#)). Two of Jesus' brothers, James and Jude, had important roles in the early Christian community. James quickly became the leader of the church in Jerusalem. At the council in Jerusalem, James helped Jewish church leaders accept gentile (non-Jewish) believers without requiring circumcision. This decision was essential for Paul and the early mission to gentiles ([Acts 15:13-21](#)). Paul visited James in Jerusalem after his third missionary trip, just as he had done earlier after his conversion ([Acts 21:18](#); [Galatians 1:19](#)).

Like most Jewish Christians, James followed the law of Moses. He stressed the importance of observing certain key laws when among Jews ([Acts 15:20-21](#); [21:18-25](#)). James recognized Paul's mission and focus on salvation through faith alone ([Galatians 2:6-9](#)), but many Jewish Christians did not agree. These Jewish believers, whom Paul associated with James once (see [Galatians 2:12](#)), insisted that gentiles who became Christians must be circumcised and follow the law of Moses to join the Christian community.

James's Jewish background is evident in his letter, which offers wise, practical advice for living. Much of it aligns with traditional Jewish Scripture wisdom. One paragraph of his letter ([James 5:1-6](#)) resembles the work of Old Testament prophets (for example, compare [Amos 5:21-24](#); [6:1-7](#)).

James, known as "the Just" by people of his time, was killed for his faith by Jewish priests in Jerusalem (Josephus, *Antiquities* 20.9; Eusebius, *Church History* 2.23.4-18).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 13:55](#); [Mark 6:3](#); [Acts 12:17](#); [Acts 15:13-21](#); [Acts 21:18-25](#); [1 Corinthians 15:7](#); [Galatians 2:9](#); [Galatians 2:12](#); [James 1:1-5:20](#); [Jude 1:1](#)

James, Son of Zebedee

James, son of Zebedee and brother of John, was one of the twelve apostles. He was among the first to die as a follower of Jesus. His mother might have been the sister of Mary, Jesus' mother, making him Jesus' cousin (see [Matthew 27:56](#); [Mark 15:40](#); [16:1](#); [John 19:25](#)). His name usually appears before John's, which might mean James was older. This James was not James, son of Alphaeus (see [Luke 6:15](#)) or James, brother of Jesus.

James and John were fishermen like their father ([Matthew 4:21](#); [Mark 1:19](#)). They fished with Peter and Andrew, another pair of brothers who became disciples ([Luke 5:10](#)). They were among the first people Jesus called to be his disciples. They left everything, including their father, to follow him ([Matthew 4:22](#); [Mark 1:20](#); [Luke 5:11](#)). Jesus called them "Sons of Thunder" ([Mark 3:17](#)). This might mean they had strong personalities (see [Luke 9:54](#)), though the exact meaning is unclear.

James and his brother John were very close to Jesus. Along with Peter, they formed a trusted group of disciples who joined Jesus on special occasions. They were with him when he healed Jairus's daughter ([Mark 5:37](#); [Luke 8:51](#)), talked with Elijah and Moses on a mountain ([Matthew 17:1-3](#); [Mark 9:2-4](#); [Luke 9:28-30](#)), and prayed in the garden ([Matthew 26:37](#); [Mark 14:33](#)). At one time, the two brothers upset the other disciples by asking for special positions in the coming kingdom of God ([Matthew 20:20-28](#); [Mark 10:35-45](#); compare [Luke 22:24-27](#)).

Herod Agrippa had James killed soon after Jesus' death, which pleased the Jewish leaders ([Acts 12:1-3](#)). Herod might have done this because James was an important leader among the disciples. This event fulfilled Jesus' prediction that James would share in his suffering ([Matt 20:23](#); [Mark 10:38-39](#)).

James was an ordinary worker whom Jesus called to be his disciple. He left his job, family, and home to follow Jesus with simple trust. Eventually, he died for Jesus, making him a model of committed discipleship.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 4:21-22](#); [10:2](#); [17:1](#); [20:20-24](#); [26:37-46](#);
[Mark 1:19-20](#), [29](#); [3:17](#); [5:37](#); [9:2](#); [10:35-41](#); [13:3-4](#); [14:33-42](#); [Luke 5:10](#); [6:14](#); [8:51](#); [9:28](#), [54-55](#);
[John 21:2](#); [Acts 1:13](#); [12:2](#)

Jehoshaphat

Jehoshaphat became the fourth king of Judah after his father Asa, who ruled from 872 to 848 BC. Like Hezekiah and Josiah, Jehoshaphat trusted the Lord throughout his life. He worked to remove most pagan worship from Israel ([2 Chronicles 17:6](#)).

Jehoshaphat continued his father Asa's religious reforms but changed his foreign policy. He stopped Judah's war with Israel over their borders (see [1 Kings 22:2](#)). He allied with Ahab. To strengthen this alliance, he arranged for his son Jehoram to marry Ahab's daughter Athaliah ([2 Chronicles 18:1-2](#); [2 Kings 8:18](#)). He also supported the north in wars against the Arameans and Moabites ([2 Chronicles 18:3-34](#); [1 Kings 22](#); [2 Kings 3:4-27](#)). The prophet Jehu criticized Jehoshaphat for his unwise alliance with Israel ([2 Chronicles 19:1-3](#)). This led to his son Jehoram being influenced by Ahab and Jezebel. Jehoram and his son Ahaziah turned Judah toward idol worship.

During his reign, Jehoshaphat kept the worship of the Lord pure. He closed the temples of prostitution ([1 Kings 22:46](#)) and sent teachers of God's law throughout the land ([2 Chronicles 17:7-9](#)). He also set up a system of judges and told them to act as the Lord's representatives so that justice would prevail ([2 Chronicles 19:4-7](#)). He appointed Levites, priests, and family leaders to handle religious cases and resolve disputes among citizens ([2 Chronicles 19:8-10](#)).

Before going to battle, Jehoshaphat insisted on hearing from a true prophet of the Lord. In one of the most powerful descriptions of war in the Old Testament, Jehoshaphat spoke to the army before entering battle. As a result, God caused the armies from Ammon, Moab, and their allies to turn against each other ([2 Chronicles 20](#)).

Jehoshaphat died at around sixty years old and was buried in Jerusalem. His son Jehoram became the next king of Judah ([2 Chronicles 21:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 15:24](#); [22:1-50](#); [2 Kings 3:1-27](#); [2 Chronicles 17:1-21:1](#)

Jeremiah

Jeremiah was a prophet in Jerusalem before its destruction in 586 BC. People sometimes call him the "weeping prophet" because he shared his struggles and sorrows while delivering God's messages.

Jeremiah was born in Anathoth, near Jerusalem, during Manasseh's reign. His father was Hilkiah from the tribe of Benjamin. Jeremiah became a prophet in the thirteenth year of Josiah's reign (627 BC). At first, Jeremiah hesitated to accept his role ([Jeremiah 1:6](#)), but God promised to guide and protect him and to provide the words he needed, even when facing opposition ([Jeremiah 1:7-8](#), [18-19](#)).

Jeremiah warned the kings and people of Judah to repent to avoid exile. They had broken God's covenant (special agreement), mainly through idol worship ([Jeremiah 10:1-16](#)), and faced the consequences ([Deuteronomy 27-28](#)). They refused God's call to repent, so Jeremiah later announced that God's judgment was unavoidable.

Judah's leaders especially disliked Jeremiah. King Jehoiakim despised him and tried to stop him from speaking. King Zedekiah secretly asked for Jeremiah's advice but gave in to his officials when they wanted to silence the prophet. However, God's word could not be stopped. The promised judgment occurred in 586 BC: Jerusalem was attacked, the temple was destroyed, and Judah's leaders were either killed or sent to Babylon.

Nebuchadnezzar, the king of Babylon, knew about Jeremiah and liked him ([Jeremiah 39:11-12](#)). Because of this, the captain of the Babylonian army let Jeremiah stay with the people left in Judah. Jeremiah advised those who stayed to accept Babylon's rule, even after Judean rebels killed Gedaliah, the governor appointed by Babylon. The Judeans ignored Jeremiah's advice and fled to Egypt. Jeremiah was taken with them, and little more is known about him after that. Tradition says he was stoned to death by Jewish exiles in Tahpanhes, Egypt.

Jeremiah was constantly rejected, imprisoned, and physically abused during his life. But, his ministry did have positive aspects. He predicted that the exile to Babylon would be temporary ([Jeremiah 25:1-14](#)) and that God would create a new covenant with his people ([31:31-34](#)). Jesus Christ fulfilled this promise ([Luke 22:20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Chronicles 35:25; 36:12, 21; Jeremiah 1:1-10; Jeremiah 13:1-14; 18:1-12; 19:1-20:6; 24:1-10; 26:1-29:32; 32:1-15; 36:1-44:30; Daniel 9:2; Matthew 16:14; 27:9](#)

Jeroboam I

Jeroboam I was the son of Nebat from the tribe of Ephraim. He was the first king of the northern kingdom of Israel. He ruled from 931 to 910 BC. He led the northern ten tribes into actions that caused the kingdom's destruction.

Jeroboam started his political career by managing Solomon's labor forces in Ephraim and Manasseh ([1 Kings 11:26-28](#)). Since Solomon had turned away from the Lord, God decided to take the ten northern tribes from David's family. The prophet Ahijah told Jeroboam that the Lord chose him to lead those tribes and promised him a lasting dynasty if he remained faithful ([1 Kings 11:29-39](#)). Solomon found out and tried to kill Jeroboam, who fled to Egypt for safety ([1 Kings 11:40](#); compare Saul and David, [1 Samuel 18:5-20:42](#)).

When Solomon died, his son Rehoboam became king in Judah. However, the northern tribes needed to confirm his rule separately. Seeing an opportunity, Jeroboam led the northern leaders to Rehoboam to ask for relief from the hard labor Solomon had imposed on them ([1 Kings 12:1-4](#)). Rehoboam unwisely rejected their request ([1 Kings 12:5-14](#)), leading the north to rebel and choose Jeroboam as their king ([12:20](#)). Thus, the kingdom divided, as God had promised.

Jeroboam did not stay loyal to God. He feared that if his people worshiped at the temple in Jerusalem, they would support the southern kingdom. Lacking faith in God to secure his rule, he made his own plan to win his people's spiritual loyalty. He built two gold calf shrines at the north and south of his kingdom ([1 Kings 12:26-33](#)). God was unhappy with these shrines and sent a prophet to condemn Jeroboam. Although Jeroboam initially reacted to the prophet's display of divine power, the calf shrines remained throughout the northern kingdom's history from 931 to 722 BC. Jeroboam's false religion was a main reason for the northern kingdom's destruction in 722 BC ([1 Kings 14:14-16; 2 Kings 17:5-23](#)).

Because of Jeroboam's sins, God did not grant him a lasting dynasty ([1 Kings 13:33-34](#)). Although Jeroboam's son Nadab became king after his

father's death, a usurper named Baasha assassinated him and the rest of Jeroboam's descendants two years later ([1 Kings 14:20; 15:25-31](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 11:26-14:20; 15:6-7, 25-28; 2 Chronicles 10:1-13:22](#)

Jeroboam II

Jeroboam II was the son of Jehoash. He ruled as king of Israel for 41 years, from 793 to 753 BC. His time as king was longer than any other northern king. He followed the bad example of Jeroboam I ([2 Kings 14:23-24](#)). Jeroboam II was not a relative of Jeroboam I, but they had the same name.

During his time, the northern kingdom reached its largest size and greatest wealth since Solomon. Archaeological evidence from Jeroboam's capital, Samaria, shows the wealth of Israel's royal house during his reign. One reason for Israel's new prosperity was Assyria's decline in power, which allowed the northern kingdom to grow. The prophet Jonah predicted this prosperity as God's promise ([2 Kings 14:25](#)). Even after 150 years of turning away from God in the northern kingdom, God showed his faithful love by offering Israel his mercy ([2 Kings 14:26-27](#)).

During Jeroboam II's reign, wealth increased, but justice did not. Rich landowners oppressed poorer ones, forcing them to leave their farms for cities. Government corruption, economic depression, and political weakness grew, while Israel's spiritual state worsened. God sent prophets to challenge Israel's leaders and people. Amos and Hosea spoke against the widespread corruption. Amos strongly criticized the rich for oppressing the poor. He warned of Jeroboam's upcoming death and Israel's punishment ([Amos 7:10-17](#)).

After Jeroboam II died, the northern kingdom quickly declined. Between 753 and 722 BC, six kings ruled one after another, and most were assassinated. In 722 BC, about 30 years after Jeroboam II's reign ended, Assyria destroyed the northern kingdom and deported its people. This action was seen as a judgment on the sins of Jeroboam II and other northern kings.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Kings 13:13; 14:16, 23-29; Hosea 1:1; Amos 1:1; 7:10-17](#)

Jethro (Reuel)

Jethro, also known as Reuel ([Exodus 2:16-18](#); [Numbers 10:29](#)), was the priest of Midian ([Exodus 2:16](#)). Moses saved Jethro's seven daughters from rough shepherds at a well and helped them water their flocks. At home, they told their father about this surprising encounter with an Egyptian. Jethro was grateful and invited Moses for a meal. Moses decided to settle there. Later, Jethro gave his daughter Zipporah to Moses in marriage.

While Moses lived in Midian with his father-in-law, he met God at the burning bush ([Exodus 3:1-2](#)). Before going to Egypt, Moses asked Jethro for permission to leave. Later, he sent his family to stay with Jethro during the exodus from Egypt.

While Moses and the Israelites were in the wilderness, Jethro returned with Moses' family. Jethro heard about Yahweh saving his people from Egypt and recognized him as greater than all other gods. He worshiped Yahweh with a burnt offering and sacrifices, aligning himself with Israel ([Exodus 18:11](#)). In response, Israel's leaders joined him for a sacrificial meal in God's presence ([Exodus 18:12](#)).

Jethro noticed Moses was overwhelmed with managing the many Israelites. He advised Moses on organizing the people better and resolving their disputes ([Exodus 18:13-23](#)). Moses followed this advice and chose capable men to help as leaders and judges ([Exodus 18:24-27](#)). Jethro returned to Midian and did not interact further with Israel, but his son ([Numbers 10:29-33](#)) and other descendants later settled with the Israelites ([Judges 1:16](#); [4:11](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 2:16-25](#); [3:1](#); [18:1-27](#); [Numbers 10:29](#); [Judges 1:16](#); [4:11](#)

Jewish Leaders

Jesus often disagreed with Jewish leaders during his public ministry. These leaders believed they were protecting the temple, its sacrifices, the synagogue, and its teachings. In Jesus' last week in Jerusalem, these arguments became more intense and helped build the case against him (see [Matthew 23](#)).

When John wrote his Gospel, local Jewish synagogues were attacking followers of Jesus in

their areas. This conflict influenced John's writing (see [Acts 14:19](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:14](#); compare [Galatians 1:13-14](#)).

The Greek term for "Jewish leaders" could also mean "Jews." However, it specifically referred to the temple leaders who opposed Jesus, judged him, and planned his death on the cross (see [John 1:19](#); [2:18](#); [5:9-18](#); [9:18-22](#)). This distinction is important because some view the New Testament, especially John's Gospel, as prejudiced against Jewish people. However, Jesus, who was Jewish, did not oppose all Jews. His opponents were the "Jewish leaders," the religious authorities in first-century Jerusalem.

Passages for Further Study

[John 1:19-24](#); [2:18-20](#); [5:9-18](#); [7:1](#), [10-13](#), [35-36](#); [9:13-34](#); [11:45-54](#); [12:41-43](#); [18:28-36](#); [19:6-8](#), [12-16](#), [31](#), [38](#); [20:19](#); [Acts 6:10-12](#); [7:54-58](#); [12:11](#); [21:11](#); [25:1-3](#), [7](#); [26:1-11](#); [28:17-24](#); [2 Corinthians 11:24](#)

Jezebel

Jezebel, daughter of Ethbaal, king of Sidon ([1 Kings 16:31](#)), married King Ahab of Israel, likely to strengthen a political alliance between their nations. Jezebel supported Baal worship and insisted on total control for the king and queen.

Jezebel persuaded Ahab to start Baal worship in Samaria and to set up an Asherah pole ([1 Kings 16:30-33](#)). She attempted to eliminate God's prophets ([1 Kings 18:4](#)) and supported many of Baal's prophets in the royal palace ([1 Kings 18:19](#)).

Elijah confronted Jezebel and Ahab on Mount Carmel ([1 Kings 18:19-40](#)). There, he challenged Israel to follow the true God. After God showed His power, the Israelites recognized Him and assisted Elijah in killing the false prophets. When Jezebel learned of this, she threatened Elijah, causing him to flee ([1 Kings 19:1-3](#)).

Later, Jezebel advised her husband on how to take a vineyard from their neighbor Naboth. When Naboth refused to sell it, Jezebel made a plan to falsely accuse him of cursing God and the king. As a result, Naboth was executed. Ahab took the vineyard, but God sent Elijah to announce judgment on Jezebel and Ahab ([1 Kings 21:20-24](#)). Ahab died soon after ([1 Kings 22:29-40](#)), but Jezebel lived through her son Ahaziah's reign. She was later executed when Jehu destroyed the ruling

family, fulfilling God's judgment against her ([2 Kings 9:30-37](#)).

Jezebel's evil influence reached the southern kingdom of Judah when her daughter Athaliah married Jehoram, the son of King Jehoshaphat (see [2 Kings 8:18, 26-27](#)).

Her name has long been linked with evil. In [Revelation 2:20](#), Jezebel is a prophetess who led the Christians of Thyatira to commit sexual sins and eat food offered to idols.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 16:31-21:28](#); [2 Kings 9:1-37](#); [Revelation 2:20](#)

Joab

Joab was David's nephew and the son of David's sister Zeruiah ([1 Chronicles 2:13-16](#)). His brothers were Abishai and Asahel. Joab became the commander of David's armies due to his bravery and military skill ([2 Samuel 2:18](#); [8:16](#); [11:1](#); [1 Chronicles 18:15](#)). He earned the commander's position by being the first to attack the Jebusite city of Jerusalem ([1 Chronicles 11:4-9](#)). Joab also stopped a rebellion among the Arameans and Ammonites ([2 Samuel 10:1-19](#); [1 Chronicles 19:8-15](#)). He won many important battles for David against the northern army of Israel, which was under Abner's strong leadership ([2 Samuel 2:12-32](#)).

Joab often acted to support what he thought were David's interests. For example, he worked with David in the death of Uriah the Hittite to hide the king's adultery with Bathsheba ([2 Samuel 11:1-27](#)). He convinced David to let Absalom return to court ([14:1-33](#)). He also tried to stop David from taking a census that made God angry ([2 Samuel 24:1-9](#); [1 Chronicles 21:1-6](#)).

Joab was loyal to David but sometimes acted for himself and ignored the king's orders. When Abner killed Joab's brother Asahel ([2 Samuel 2:23](#)), Joab took revenge by killing Abner ([2 Samuel 3:26-30](#)), even though Abner had become loyal to David ([2 Samuel 3:12-19](#)). Later, Joab killed his cousin Amasa, who had led Absalom's army ([2 Samuel 20:8-10](#); [17:25](#)). This happened after David made Amasa the commander instead of Joab ([2 Samuel 19:13](#); [20:4](#)).

Joab also killed Absalom against David's direct order ([2 Samuel 18:5](#), [10-17](#)). He then criticized

David for mourning Absalom's death instead of praising the army ([2 Samuel 19:5-7](#)). Joab was ruthless and regained the top position in David's army ([2 Samuel 20:23](#); [24:2](#); [1 Kings 1:19](#)).

Joab's decision to support Adonijah's claim to the throne led to his death ([1 Kings 1:5-7](#)). Near the end of his life, David ordered Solomon to put Joab to death for killing Abner and Amasa. After becoming king, Solomon ordered Benaiah to kill Joab. Joab ran to the altar and grabbed its horns (corners) for protection ([1 Kings 2:28-34](#)). Joab faced the same end he had given others, and his executioner became the new commander of Israel's army ([1 Kings 2:35](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 2:13-32](#); [3:22-39](#); [8:16](#); [10:7-14](#); [11:1-25](#); [12:26-28](#); [14:1-33](#); [17:25](#); [18:2-19:13](#); [20:7-23](#); [24:2-9](#); [1 Kings 1:7](#), [19](#); [2:28-35](#); [11:15-16](#); [1 Chronicles 2:16](#); [11:6-8](#); [18:15](#); [19:8-15](#); [20:1](#); [21:2-6](#); [26:28](#); [27:24](#), [34](#); [Psalm 60:1-12](#)

John Mark

John Mark, who wrote the first Gospel (the Gospel of Mark), helped three early missionaries:

- Barnabas
- Paul
- Peter

Barnabas and Paul took Mark as an assistant on their first missionary journey. However, Mark left them and returned to Jerusalem before the trip ended ([Acts 12:25](#); [13:4-5](#), [13](#)). Because of this, when Barnabas wanted to bring Mark on the second trip, Paul refused. This disagreement split the team: Barnabas took Mark, his cousin, while Paul chose Silas. The two pairs then went their separate ways ([Acts 15:36-41](#)).

Later, Paul and Mark reconciled, and Mark became his assistant again. In Colossians, Paul calls Mark a coworker and suggests he might soon send him to visit the church in Colossae ([Colossians 4:10](#); see also [Philemon 1:24](#)). Even later, when Paul awaited execution in a Roman prison, he asked Timothy to bring Mark because he believed Mark would be helpful in his ministry ([2 Timothy 4:11](#)).

Mark likely helped Peter with his missionary work in Italy near the end of Peter's life. In one of Peter's letters, he affectionately calls Mark his "son" who is

with him ([1 Peter 5:13](#)). Early Christian tradition describes Mark as Peter's "interpreter" and suggests that Mark got his information about Jesus' life and words directly from Peter (Eusebius, *Church History* 3.39.16).

Mark's Gospel is generally considered the earliest of all the Gospels. It was almost certainly a primary source for Matthew and Luke when they wrote their own Gospels. For this reason, Mark's Gospel is one of the most influential early Christian writings.

Mark's story shows that God can fix human mistakes and mend difficult relationships for Christ and the good news. Early failures do not stop someone from having a meaningful and impactful life of service.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 12:12, 25; 13:4-5, 13; 15:36-39; Colossians 4:10; 2 Timothy 4:11; Philemon 1:23-24; 1 Peter 5:13](#)

John the Baptist

John the Baptist was a passionate preacher who lived in the desert and called people to repent (to change their lives by stopping their wrongdoing and turning to God). He became known as "the Baptist" (or "the Baptizer") because he baptized (immersed) people in water as a sign that they were turning away from their sins. John acted like Elijah to prepare people for the Messiah's arrival ([Malachi 4:4-5; Matthew 11:14; 17:12; Mark 9:13](#)).

John's birth, like Jesus', was extraordinary. John's parents were very old and unable to have children ([Luke 1:5-25](#)). His mother, Elizabeth, was a relative of Mary, Jesus' mother ([Luke 1:36](#)). So, John was related to Jesus. These two miraculous births around the same time marked the start of God's redeeming work.

John was filled with the Holy Spirit from birth and dedicated his life to preparing people for the Lord's arrival ([Luke 1:15-17](#)). He began teaching people when he was about thirty years old while living in the desert ([Luke 1:80](#)). He wore clothes made of camel's hair with a leather belt, similar to what ancient prophets wore, and ate desert food (locusts and wild honey, see [Matthew 3:4; Mark 1:6](#)). John urged everyone to repent and be baptized ([Matthew 3:1-2; Mark 1:4; Luke 3:1-3](#)). He even criticized the religious leaders who came to listen to him ([Matthew 3:7-10](#)).

John baptized Jesus, though at first he felt unworthy to do so ([Matthew 3:13-17](#)). John knew Jesus was greater than him. While John used water, Jesus would "baptize with the Holy Spirit" ([John 1:33; Matthew 3:11; Mark 1:7-8; Luke 3:16; compare John 3:23-30](#)). John encouraged his followers to become Jesus' disciples. Many did, including:

- Andrew ([John 1:35-40](#))
- Apollos ([Acts 18:24-26](#))
- The twelve disciples at Ephesus ([Acts 19:1-7](#))

John criticized Herod Antipas for marrying Herodias, his brother Philip's wife, which was against the law. To satisfy Herodias, Herod imprisoned and then executed John ([Matthew 14:3-12; Mark 6:17-29; Luke 3:19-20](#)). John's imprisonment marked the start of Jesus' public preaching ([Matthew 4:12; Mark 1:14](#)).

Shortly before his death, John appeared confused about Jesus. He sent messengers from prison to ask if Jesus was truly the Messiah (God's chosen one). Jesus did not do what most people expected the Messiah to do. Instead of bringing judgment and a visible kingdom, he brought forgiveness, healing, and a spiritual kingdom. To reassure John, Jesus spoke of the miraculous things God was doing through him ([Luke 7:18-23](#)).

John stayed true to his mission throughout his life. He consistently preached about repentance and God's judgment, even to those who did not want to listen. Jesus called John one of the greatest servants of God who ever lived ([Matthew 11:2-19; Luke 7:18-35](#)). John was the last in a long line of prophets who predicted the coming of God's Kingdom ([Luke 16:16](#)). He stood at the start of a new era, announcing its arrival to everyone willing to hear.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 3:1-15; 4:12; 9:14; 11:2-19; 14:1-12; 16:14; 17:10-13; 21:24-27, 31-32; Mark 1:1-9, 14; 2:18; 6:14-29; 8:28; 9:11-13; 11:29-33; Luke 1:13-17, 36, 39-43, 57-66, 76-80; 3:1-21; 5:33; 7:18-35; 9:7-9, 19; 11:1; 16:16; 20:3-8; John 1:6-37; John 3:23-36; 4:1-3; 10:40-42; Acts 1:5; 10:37; 11:16; 18:25-26; 19:1-7](#)

John, Son of Zebedee

John was one of Jesus' twelve closest followers (called apostles). He was the brother of James and the son of Zebedee. Jesus chose these twelve men as his special representatives and gave them authority to teach others about him. Their work helped start the early church. Early tradition says John, Son of Zebedee, wrote the Gospel of John, the Letters of John, and the Book of Revelation.

John and his brother James were among Jesus' closest followers ([Mark 5:37](#); [9:2](#); [13:3](#); [14:33](#)). Their mother, Salome, might have been Mary's sister, who was Jesus' mother (compare [Matthew 27:56](#); [Mark 15:40](#); [16:1](#); [John 19:25](#)). John's name usually appears after James's, suggesting John was younger. James and John were fishermen like their father ([Matthew 4:21](#); [Mark 1:19](#)). They fished with Peter and Andrew, another pair of brothers who became disciples ([Luke 5:8-10](#)).

They were among the first disciples Jesus called, and they left everything to follow him ([Matthew 4:22](#); [Mark 1:20](#); [Luke 5:11](#); compare [John 1:35-40](#)). Jesus named them "Sons of Thunder" ([Mark 3:17](#)). This name might mean they were loud or quick-tempered (see [Luke 9:54](#)). At one point, the brothers upset the other disciples by asking for special positions in the future kingdom ([Matthew 20:20-28](#); [Mark 10:35-45](#); compare [Luke 22:24-27](#)).

People believe John is the unnamed "disciple Jesus loved" and "another disciple" mentioned in the Gospel of John ([John 13:23-25](#); [18:15-16](#); [19:26-27](#); [20:2-10](#); [21:20-24](#)). He might have been the unnamed disciple of John the Baptist who, along with Andrew, became an early follower of Jesus ([John 1:35-40](#)).

John's name appears three times in Acts. Each time, he works with Peter ([Acts 3:1-11](#); [4:1-23](#); [8:14-25](#)). Paul called him one of the "pillars" of the church in Jerusalem ([Galatians 2:9](#)). This meant John was an important leader in the Jerusalem church.

The most common tradition about John's later life is that he moved to Ephesus, where he eventually became the bishop of Asia Minor. He lived to an old age and died peacefully among friends. John's Gospel gives a deep picture of Jesus, and his letters ([1 John](#), [2 John](#), and [3 John](#)) offer an inspiring view of the Christian life.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 4:21-22](#); [10:2](#); [17:1](#); [20:20-24](#); [26:37-46](#); [Mark 1:19-20](#), [29](#); [3:17](#); [5:37](#); [9:2](#), [38](#); [10:35-41](#); [13:3-4](#); [14:33-42](#); [Luke 5:10](#); [6:14](#); [8:51](#); [9:28](#), [49](#), [54](#); [John 13:23-25](#); [18:15-16](#); [19:26-27](#); [20:2-10](#); [21:2](#), [7](#), [20-24](#); [Acts 1:13](#); [3:1-11](#); [4:1-22](#); [5:17-42](#); [8:14-25](#); [Galatians 2:9](#)

Jonathan

Jonathan was King Saul's oldest son. He was supposed to be the next king after Saul. However, when God rejected Saul and chose David, Jonathan supported David's rise to power ([1 Samuel 18:1-4](#); [19:1-7](#)).

Jonathan was an excellent military leader. He led his father's army to victory over the Philistine garrison at Geba ([1 Samuel 13:3-4](#)). In another bold move, Jonathan and his armor bearer attacked a Philistine outpost alone. This caused confusion and chaos among the Philistine army. This allowed the main Israelite army to attack and win ([1 Samuel 14:1-23](#); see also David's tribute to Jonathan, [2 Samuel 1:22](#)).

Saul had unwisely made an oath that no one should eat until they won. Jonathan did not know about the vow and ate some honey. When he learned of Saul's vow, Jonathan criticized it strongly. Saul would have had Jonathan killed after the battle he helped win if the people had not intervened.

When Jonathan and David met, they quickly became friends ([1 Samuel 18:1-4](#)). Jonathan showed his deep love for David by giving him his robe, tunic, sword, bow, and belt. This might have meant that Jonathan believed David should be the next ruler. When Saul tried to kill David, Jonathan spoke up for David and helped him escape safely.

Jonathan stayed with his father even after the Lord made it clear that He had left Saul. As a result, Jonathan died with Saul while fighting the Philistines ([1 Samuel 31:2](#); [1 Chronicles 10:2](#)). Jonathan was a virtuous, brave, and selfless man who always spoke and acted with honesty. His love and courage helped David survive King Saul's mad attacks.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 13:1-14:46](#); [18:1-4](#); [20:1-42](#); [23:16-18](#); [31:2](#); [2 Samuel 1:1-27](#); [4:4](#)

Joseph

Joseph is famous for his dreams and the beautiful coat his father, Jacob, gave him. He is an example of faith, wisdom, and skill in managing. Despite many challenges, Joseph saved Canaan, Egypt, and his family from starvation during seven years of drought.

Joseph was Jacob's eleventh son and the first child of Jacob's favorite wife, Rachel. Joseph's name means "may he add," showing Rachel's wish for God to give her another son ([Genesis 30:24](#)). Rachel later died while giving birth to Benjamin, Joseph's only full brother.

Joseph's brothers were jealous of him because of his dreams. They sold him to a passing caravan and made Jacob think an animal had killed him. In Egypt, Joseph quickly became important, but he was jailed when his master's wife falsely accused him. In prison, he correctly interpreted dreams for other inmates and was later called when Pharaoh could not understand his own dreams. Joseph explained Pharaoh's dreams, which were about a coming famine, with insight and wisdom.

Pharaoh released him thirteen years after he had been brought to Egypt as a slave and appointed him to lead the nation in preparing for the famine. When Joseph's brothers came to buy grain in Egypt, they appeared before him but did not recognize him. Later, their regret and Judah's plea led Joseph to reveal his identity. The family reconciled and reunited when Jacob came to live in Egypt.

Jacob blessed Joseph's sons, Ephraim and Manasseh, and adopted them as his own ([Genesis 48:5-20](#)). Each became a separate tribe in Israel. Jacob placed Ephraim first and gave him the birthright ([Genesis 48:17-20](#)). Ephraim became one of Israel's strongest tribes and led the northern kingdom after it split during Rehoboam's reign (see [1 Kings 11:26-12:33](#)). Several prophets refer to the northern kingdom as Ephraim (for example, [Ezekiel 37:15-19](#); [Hosea 5:3-5](#)) and Joseph (for example, [Obadiah 1:18](#)).

Joseph believed the Israelites would return to the land God promised them. His dying wish was for his bones to be buried in Canaan when they left Egypt ([Genesis 50:24-26](#); see [Exodus 13:19](#); [Joshua 24:32](#)). Joseph's story shows the life of a faithful man with godly character who followed God's plan. His name appears often in Scripture, indicating that later Israelites respected him. The Psalms summarize his story ([Psalm 105:16-22](#)), and

Stephen mentions him in his speech before his martyrdom ([Acts 7:9-14](#)).

Joseph's life shows that God controls history, even when bad things occur ([Genesis 50:20](#)). God shows his power through his caring and faithful love for his people. Joseph also demonstrates strong faith in God and personal integrity during tough times.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 30:22-24](#); [37:2-36](#); [39:1-45:28](#); [48:1-22](#); [49:22-26](#); [50:1-26](#); [Exodus 13:19](#); [Deuteronomy 33:13-17](#); [Joshua 24:32](#); [Psalm 105:16-22](#); [Acts 7:9-14](#)

Joshua

Joshua was the son of Nun. He was Moses' assistant and became Israel's leader after him. Joshua led the young nation across the Jordan River into Canaan, the land God promised to Abraham, by faithfully following God's guidance.

Before Israel reached Mount Sinai, Joshua led Israel's warriors when Amalek attacked them ([Exodus 17:8-13](#)). Soon after, he was one of the twelve men Moses sent to explore the promised land ([Numbers 13:1-16](#)). Despite popular opinion, Joshua and Caleb urged Israel to take Canaan immediately ([Numbers 13:22-14:9](#)). As a result, only they, among the twelve spies, entered Canaan ([Numbers 14:30, 36-38](#)).

God chose Moses to appoint Joshua as his successor ([Numbers 27:15-23](#); [Deuteronomy 34:9](#)). After Moses died, Joshua led the Israelites across the Jordan River ([Joshua 1:1-18](#); [3:1-4:24](#)) to conquer Jericho ([6:1-27](#)). When Israel lost at Ai, Joshua sought the Lord's guidance and removed sin from Israel ([Joshua 7:1-26](#)). Then, Israel defeated Ai ([8:1-29](#)). Following God's instructions to Moses ([Deuteronomy 11:29-32](#); [27:1-28:68](#)), Joshua built an altar on Mount Ebal ([Joshua 8:30-32](#)). There he read the blessings and curses of God's special agreement (covenant) with Israel ([8:33-35](#)). Joshua led campaigns against two groups of Canaanite kings, one in the south and one in the north ([Joshua 10:1-43](#); [11:1-15](#)). These victories allowed the Israelites to settle in the hill country.

After overseeing the division of land among the tribes of Israel, Joshua received his own share in Ephraim ([Joshua 19:49-50](#)). He established the cities of refuge where people could go if they accidentally killed someone ([Joshua 20:1-9](#)).

Joshua also established cities for the Levites to live in ([21:1-45](#)). The Levites were the tribe chosen to serve God in the temple, but they did not receive their own territory like the other tribes of Israel. Instead, they were given these cities spread throughout the land.

Joshua allowed the two and a half tribes that settled east of the Jordan River to return home ([Joshua 22:1-9](#)). As he aged, Joshua urged Israel to stay loyal to God ([Joshua 23:1-24:28](#)). His farewell speech at Shechem reviewed God's actions with Israel and ended with the well-known challenge, "choose for yourselves this day whom you will serve... As for me and my house, we will serve the LORD" ([Joshua 24:15](#)). Joshua died at 110 years old and was buried in Timnath-serah ([Joshua 24:29-30](#); [Judges 2:8-9](#)).

Joshua showed great faithfulness throughout his life, except when he dealt with the Gibeonites ([Joshua 9:1-27](#)). He did not ask the Lord for guidance on a decision. Israel served God faithfully under Joshua and the elders he trained ([Joshua 24:31](#); [Judges 2:7](#)). Stephen mentions Joshua in his sermon before his martyrdom ([Acts 7:45](#)). The writer of Hebrews uses Joshua's conquest of Jericho to illustrate faith ([Hebrews 11:30](#)). Joshua and Jesus are the same name in the Hebrew language. This connection is meaningful because both men were leaders who helped save people. Joshua helped the people of Israel by leading them into the land of Canaan, where they could live safely, while Jesus leads all who believe in him into eternal salvation.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 17:8-15](#); [Numbers 13:1-14:38](#); [27:15-23](#); [34:17](#); [Deuteronomy 34:9](#); [Joshua 1:1-18](#); [4:1-24:33](#); [Judges 2:6-9](#); [Hebrews 11:30](#)

Josiah

Josiah was king of Judah from 640 to 609 BC. He was a godly man, unlike his grandfather Manasseh and his father Amon. Josiah followed the Lord with all his heart, soul, and strength. He obeyed all the laws of Moses ([2 Kings 23:25](#)).

Manasseh was king from 697 to 642 BC. During this time, the kingdom of Judah was very wicked and worshiped idols. Even though Manasseh repented near the end of his reign, things got worse under his son Amon, who ruled from 642 to 640 BC. Amon was so bad that his own officials killed him. Then,

they made Josiah king ([2 Kings 21:23-24](#); [22:1](#); [2 Chronicles 33:24-34:1](#)). He was eight years old.

When Josiah was sixteen, he started to seek the God of his ancestor David ([2 Chronicles 34:3](#)). From then on, he focused on purifying the worship of God's people. At twenty, Josiah began removing pagan worship places, especially the disliked pagan worship center at Bethel. Josiah fulfilled prophecy ([1 Kings 13:1-3](#)) by destroying its altar and burning the bones of pagan priests to desecrate the site ([2 Kings 23:15-18](#)).

When Josiah was twenty-six, he organized repairs to the temple ([2 Kings 22:3-7](#)). During this process, the priest Hilkiah found the Book of the Law and read it to Josiah. Josiah was upset by its warnings against abandoning faith ([2 Kings 22:8-20](#)). He then tried harder to follow God's instructions and led the people in worshiping the Lord. He celebrated Passover as the law required, destroyed many objects used in Baal and sun worship, and removed pagan shrines in Judah ([2 Kings 23:4-14](#)). The prophets Zephaniah and Jeremiah, who spoke for God during his time, apparently supported Josiah in all this.

On one important occasion, Josiah did not listen to God's guidance, which led to his death ([2 Kings 23:29-30](#); [2 Chronicles 35:20-25](#)). In 609 BC, Pharaoh Neco marched toward Carchemish to help the Assyrian army against Babylon. Josiah delayed Neco at Megiddo, possibly to support the Babylonians. Neco claimed that the Lord wanted him to fight Babylon, but Josiah attacked him and was killed in battle. Jeremiah and the people of Judah mourned Josiah deeply ([2 Chronicles 35:25](#)).

Josiah was faithful, but the people were not. After he died, his sons and successors turned away from the Lord. Despite Jeremiah's increased efforts, the people did not repent. The turbulent years after Josiah's death ended with the destruction of Jerusalem and the exile of its citizens to Babylon from 605 to 586 BC.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 13:2](#); [2 Kings 21:24-23:30](#); [2 Chronicles 33:25-35:27](#); [Jeremiah 1:1-4](#); [22:13-23](#); [25:3](#); [36:2](#); [Zephaniah 1:1](#)

Judah

Judah is most famous for being the ancestor of King David and of Jesus Christ. Judah was not the oldest

son and did wrong things as a grown man ([Genesis 38](#)). Despite that, God chose Judah to continue the lineage of King David and of the Messiah (see [1 Chronicles 2:1-17](#); [3:1-24](#); and [Genesis 49:8-12](#); [Matthew 1:1-16](#); [Luke 3:23-34](#)).

Judah was the fourth son of Jacob's twelve sons ([Genesis 35:23](#); [1 Chronicles 2:1](#)). Leah was happy to have her fourth son. She named him Judah, which means "praise" ([Genesis 29:35](#)).

Judah had five sons:

15. Er
16. Onan
17. Shelah
18. Perez
19. Zerah

Bathshua, a woman from Canaan, was the mother of Er, Onan, and Shelah ([Genesis 38:1-5](#); [1 Chronicles 2:3](#)). Perez and Zerah were twins. Tamar, Judah's daughter-in-law, was their mother ([Genesis 38:27-30](#); [1 Chronicles 2:4](#)).

God killed Judah's first two sons, Er and Onan, in Canaan because of their disobedience ([Genesis 46:12](#)). Judah later moved his family to Egypt with his father and brothers ([Exodus 1:1-2](#)).

Judah acted recklessly with Tamar but he took responsibility for Benjamin's safety in Egypt ([Genesis 38:6-30](#)). He also interceded with Joseph for his brothers ([Genesis 44:14-34](#)). When Jacob gave his dying blessing, he granted Judah a leadership role. Future kings of Israel would come from Judah's descendants (see [Genesis 49:10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 29:35](#); [37:26-27](#); [38:1-30](#); [43:1-10](#); [44:14-34](#); [46:28](#); [49:8-12](#); [Ruth 4:12](#); [1 Chronicles 2:3-4](#); [5:2](#); [Psalm 108:8](#)

Judas Iscariot

Judas Iscariot is well-known for betraying Jesus to the authorities ([Matthew 10:4](#); [Mark 3:19](#); [Luke 6:16](#)).

The meaning of the name "Iscariot" is unclear. It might refer to a village named Kerioth. Judas Iscariot is different from Judas, son of James ([Luke 6:16](#); [John 14:22](#)).

Among the apostles (Jesus' closest followers), people knew Judas Iscariot as greedy. He carried the money bag and had a reputation for stealing from it ([John 12:4-6](#)). The leading priests later offered him a bribe, which convinced him to betray Jesus ([Matthew 26:14-16](#); [Mark 14:10-11](#); [Luke 22:3-6](#)).

Jesus called Judas "a devil" ([John 6:70-71](#)). He also predicted his betrayal ([Mark 14:18-21](#)). The devil put the idea of betrayal into Judas's mind, and Satan entered him during the betrayal ([Luke 22:3-4](#); [John 13:2, 27](#)). Judas led soldiers and officers to the garden of Gethsemane at night. There, he found Jesus with his followers. Judas had planned to identify Jesus to the soldiers by giving him a kiss, which was a normal way to greet someone at that time ([Mark 14:43-46](#)). Later, Judas was very sorry for betraying an innocent man. He killed himself by hanging himself ([Matthew 27:3-10](#); [Acts 1:18-19](#)).

Jesus understood Judas's betrayal as part of God's plan for redemption. It led to the death of Jesus, the Messiah, as the ultimate sacrifice for sin ([Matthew 26:24, 53-54](#); [Mark 14:21](#); [Luke 22:22](#); [John 17:12](#)). Although Judas played a role in God's plan, his tragic end was deserved ([Acts 1:24-25](#)). It would have been better for Judas if he had never been born ([Matthew 26:24](#); [Mark 14:21](#)). Judas's fate serves as a warning to those who seem to follow Jesus but have not personally committed to him (see [Hebrews 6:4-6](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 10:4](#); [26:14-16, 23-25, 46-50](#); [27:3-10](#); [Mark 3:19](#); [14:10-11, 18-21, 43-45](#); [Luke 6:16](#); [22:3-6, 22, 47-48](#); [John 6:70-71](#); [12:4-6](#); [13:2, 18, 21-30](#); [17:12](#); [18:2-5](#); [Acts 1:16-26](#)

Leah

Leah was Laban's first daughter, Jacob's first wife whom he did not love, and Rachel's older sister.

Jacob tricked his father Isaac into giving him the blessing meant for Esau ([Genesis 27:1-40](#)). Then he went to his uncle Laban in Mesopotamia. He wanted to escape Esau's anger and find a wife ([Genesis 27:41-28:5](#)). Jacob fell in love with his cousin Rachel and agreed with her father to marry her after working for seven years ([Genesis 29:17-20](#)). During the wedding feast, Laban tricked Jacob by giving him Leah instead of Rachel ([Genesis 29:21-25](#)). Laban said the custom required the older daughter to marry first ([Genesis 29:26](#)). Leah

was less attractive than her sister ([Genesis 29:17](#)). Jacob did not love her ([Genesis 29:30–35](#)).

Jacob loved Rachel so much that he worked another seven years to marry her. Because Jacob favored Rachel, the Lord blessed Leah with six sons and a daughter before Rachel could have children ([Genesis 29:31–30:22](#)):

20. Reuben
21. Simeon
22. Levi
23. Judah
24. Issachar
25. Zebulun
26. Dinah

At one point, Rachel traded with Leah for some mandrakes in exchange for time with Jacob. People thought mandrakes helped women become pregnant. After a night with Jacob, Leah became pregnant and gave birth to her fifth son ([Genesis 30:14–17](#)). This increased her advantage in her rivalry with Rachel.

Leah was the mother of two important tribes in Israelite history. The tribe of Levi was the tribe of priests. The tribe of Judah became the royal tribe, leading to Jesus Christ, the promised descendant ([Genesis 3:15](#); [12:2–3](#); [2 Samuel 7:16](#); [Matthew 1:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 29:14–35](#); [30:9–21](#); [31:4–16](#); [33:1–7](#); [34:1](#); [46:8–15](#); [49:31](#); [Ruth 4:11](#)

Lot

Lot was Abraham's nephew and the ancestor of the Moabites and Ammonites. Like Abraham, Lot was born in Ur and traveled with Terah to Haran ([Genesis 11:27–32](#)). After Terah died, Lot joined Abraham on the journey to Canaan and Egypt.

When Lot and Abraham returned from Egypt to Canaan, their flocks and herds became too large for them to live together. So, Abraham allowed Lot to choose land for himself. Lot chose the fertile plain of the Jordan, which was like "the garden of the LORD" ([Genesis 13:10](#)). Eventually, he settled in Sodom. Lot's growing involvement with the corrupt cities of the plain weakened his moral values.

While Lot lived in Sodom, four Mesopotamian kings defeated the kings of five nearby towns. They stole things from the towns they had defeated and took Lot, his family, and his possessions ([Genesis 14:1–12](#)). When Abraham heard about this, he led an attack against the invaders and rescued the prisoners and property ([Genesis 14:13–16](#)).

Due to the wickedness of Sodom and Gomorrah, God decided to destroy these cities. He sent two angels to Lot in Sodom to urge him to leave the city that was about to be destroyed ([Genesis 19:1–15](#)). The city's evil was clear when there was an attempted attack on the visitors. Lot's offer to sacrifice his daughters and his hesitation to leave showed his moral decline. Only his immediate family left with him, and his wife was destroyed when she disobeyed by looking back.

After Sodom's destruction, Lot's daughters, worried about not having husbands, made Lot drunk to have children with him. Their sons, Moab and Ben-ammi, became ancestors of the Moabites and Ammonites ([Genesis 19:30–38](#)). These two nations that became constant enemies of Israel (see [Deuteronomy 23:3–6](#)). Despite Lot's actions, Peter describes Lot as a "righteous man, living among them day after day, was tormented in his righteous soul by the lawless deeds he saw and heard" (see [2 Peter 2:6–9](#)). This view of Lot may come from Jewish tradition, as it is hard to see in the Genesis story.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 11:27](#), [31](#); [12:4–5](#); [13:1–14](#); [14:12–16](#); [19:1–38](#); [Deuteronomy 2:9](#), [17–19](#); [Psalm 83:4–8](#); [Luke 17:28–33](#); [2 Peter 2:6–9](#)

Luke

Luke was a gentile (non-Jewish) doctor who became a Christian and a trusted helper of Paul in his missions. He wrote both the Gospel of Luke and the Acts of the Apostles, which make up about one-quarter of the New Testament.

We know little about Luke's background, but he likely first met Paul in western Asia Minor. There, he became a Christian. He left his home to serve Jesus and spread the good news about him as Paul's dedicated assistant. Paul warmly calls him "the beloved physician" and a faithful "fellow worker" ([Colossians 4:14](#); [Philemon 1:24](#)). Luke was the only Christian who stayed with Paul when he awaited execution in Rome ([2 Timothy 4:11](#)). He is

also the only non-Jewish person whose writings are in the New Testament.

During Paul's last trip to Jerusalem, Luke likely gathered information for his Gospel and the early part of the book of Acts. He interviewed people in Judea while Paul was imprisoned there for two years. Luke spoke with those who heard and saw Jesus and studied what others had written about him. He then wrote his own detailed account of Jesus's life and teachings (see [Luke 1:1-4](#)).

When Paul traveled by ship to Rome for his trial, Luke went with him. While Paul was under house arrest, waiting for his trial, Luke might have used this time to write the book of Acts. The first fifteen chapters give an account of the earliest missionary work in the order that it happened and as told to him by the early followers of Jesus. Paul himself probably told him some of these things. Starting at [Acts 16:10](#), Luke writes about what he saw and experienced himself when he joined Paul's team. In Acts, Luke emphasizes how the Holy Spirit empowered and guided the early missionaries in their work (see [Acts 1:4-5, 8](#)). The book ends with Paul still under house arrest in Rome ([Acts 28:30-31](#)).

We owe Luke for many unique passages. These include his account of Jesus's birth, descriptions of Jesus's ministry to women, and many words about Jesus caring for the poor. He also provides the only comprehensive account of the first thirty years of Christian missionary activity, all carefully documented. Through Luke's writings, we gain a deeper appreciation of the crucial work of the Holy Spirit in the ministry of Jesus and the early missionaries.

Passages for Further Study

[Luke 1:3](#); [Acts 1:1](#); [16:10](#); [Colossians 4:14](#); [2 Timothy 4:11](#); [Philemon 1:24](#)

Maccabees

The Maccabees, which means "hammers," led a successful revolt against Antiochus IV because he persecuted the Jews. They and their descendants, known as the Hasmoneans, ruled Judea for nearly 100 years. They helped shape Jewish society as it was during the time of Jesus.

The Maccabean Revolt (166-142 BC)

In 167 BC, Antiochus IV made practicing Judaism punishable by death. Many Jews complied, while others resisted quietly and lost their lives. Soon, more active resistance began. When an official of Antiochus IV came to Modein to force the Jews to perform a pagan sacrifice, a priest named Mattathias killed him. He then declared, "Everyone who is passionate about the law of Moses and wants to follow the covenant, come with me!" (*1 Maccabees 2:27*). He fled to the mountains with his sons and some followers.

Mattathias, who was very old, soon died. Before his death, he appointed his son Judas to lead the revolt. Judas was a skilled and inspiring military leader. He, his brothers, and their followers defeated Seleucid attacks and freed most of Judea. After taking control of Jerusalem, Judas and his rebels cleansed the temple and restored daily sacrifices, allowing worship to resume. This restoration and rededication became the Festival of Dedication or Lights (Hanukkah). Judas opposed the appointment of a high priest who was influenced by Greek culture. He also sought more political freedom. He defeated the Seleucid army sent to stop the uprising, but the Seleucid king responded by sending a much larger army. Most of Judas's men deserted, and Judas died in the battle of Elasa in 160 BC.

After Judas died, the Maccabees reorganized under his younger brother Jonathan, a skilled politician and commander. Over the next few years, the Maccabees regained control of Judea. Jonathan secured the high priesthood and formed an alliance with Rome. However, the Seleucid general Tryphon deceived him, took him hostage, and killed him in 143 BC.

Another brother, Simon, became the leader of the Maccabees after Jonathan. In 142 BC, Simon secured a treaty with Seleucid King Demetrius II, making Judea independent. Simon kept the position of high priest, and it was passed down within his family. In 135 BC, Simon's son-in-law assassinated him.

Hasmonean Rule (142-63 BC)

When Simon, the son of Mattathias, became their leader, the Maccabees changed from being rebels to becoming a ruling family (called the Hasmoneans). The Hasmoneans were named after Mattathias's great-grandfather Asmoneus. Simon's family ruled Judea for nearly one hundred years.

During this time, Jewish political leaders became more influenced by Greek culture. Meanwhile, the Pharisees became popular as they worked to preserve traditional Judaism. Separatist groups like the Essenes completely withdrew from Jewish society. Toward the end of this period, a power struggle between two brothers, Aristobulus and Hyrcanus II, caused political instability. This situation allowed Rome to step in, bring peace, and take control.

Roman Rule (beginning 63 BC)

In 63 BC, the Roman general Pompey marched on Jerusalem, making Judea an area that paid taxes to and was controlled by Rome. Judea then experienced a period of relative peace. With the end of Hasmonean rule, the Jewish people awaited a new and strong religious leader, the long-expected Messiah.

Manasseh

Manasseh was the thirteenth king of Judah, ruling from 697 to 642 BC. He was king for many years and became known for doing evil things ([2 Kings 21:1-18](#); [2 Chronicles 33:1-9](#)). This was surprising because his father, King Hezekiah, was a good and faithful king ([2 Kings 20:21](#)).

In 697 BC, Manasseh became co-ruler with his father, Hezekiah, at age twelve ([2 Chronicles 33:1](#)). In 686 BC, Hezekiah died, and Manasseh became the only king. He was king for fifty-five years ([2 Kings 21:1](#)). He was king longer than any other king in Judah or Israel. Sadly, he was the most wicked king of Judah. He rebuilt the high places for pagan worship, encouraged the worship of Baal, the sun, the moon, and the stars, and even sacrificed his son ([2 Kings 21:2-9](#); see [2 Kings 23:10](#); [Jeremiah 7:31](#)). He allowed divination (seeking knowledge of the future through supernatural methods) and sorcery (using magic with the help of evil spirits) in Judah. He “shed so much innocent blood that he filled Jerusalem... with innocent blood” ([2 Kings 21:16](#); [24:3-4](#)).

Assyrian records say that Manasseh sent men to move timber from Lebanon to Nineveh for King Esarhaddon, who ruled from 680 to 669 BC. He also paid tribute to King Ashurbanipal, who ruled from 668 to 626 BC, after an Assyrian military campaign in Egypt in 667 BC. Manasseh was more loyal to Assyria than to the Lord.

Due to Manasseh's great sin, God decided to “wipe out Jerusalem as one wipes out a bowl—wiping it and turning it upside down” ([2 Kings 21:13](#)). However, Manasseh repented late in life. The Assyrian army captured him, put a hook through his nose, and exiled him to Babylon ([2 Chronicles 33:10-13](#)). There, Manasseh turned to the Lord. God heard his prayers, restored him as king, and blessed the rest of his reign as Manasseh worked to restore proper worship of God alone ([2 Chronicles 33:14-17](#)).

Sadly, Manasseh's sins had spread among the people of Judah ([2 Chronicles 33:17](#)). God did not change his decision to judge the kingdom ([2 Kings 23:26](#); [24:3-4](#)). This shows how serious Manasseh's sins were. Even Jeremiah, one hundred years later, declared, “I will make them a horror to all the kingdoms of the earth because of what Manasseh son of Hezekiah king of Judah did in Jerusalem” ([Jeremiah 15:4](#)). The destruction of Jerusalem and its Temple and the exile of Judah's people followed.

When Manasseh died in 642 BC at age 67, he was buried in his own garden ([2 Kings 21:18](#)). He was not buried with respected leaders like Jehoiada and Hezekiah ([2 Chronicles 24:15-16](#); [32:33](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Kings 20:21-21:18](#); [23:26](#); [24:3](#); [2 Chronicles 32:33-33:20](#); [Jeremiah 15:4](#)

Martha, Mary, and Lazarus

The sisters Martha and Mary lived with their brother Lazarus in Bethany, near Jerusalem. Jesus loved this family and spent time with them. The Gospels of Luke and John mention Martha and Mary, while Lazarus appears only in John. This Lazarus is not the beggar from [Luke 16:19-31](#).

Luke's account of these two sisters ([Luke 10:38-42](#)) highlights the contrast between Martha and Mary. When Jesus visited their home, Martha was busy in the kitchen and became upset with her sister for not helping her prepare the meal. Jesus defended Mary's choice to sit and learn from him, saying it was the most important thing.

The Gospel of John tells the story of Jesus raising Lazarus from the dead ([John 11:1-44](#)). Jesus arrived in Bethany four days after Lazarus died. The sisters were upset that Jesus had not come earlier to heal their brother. Jesus felt deeply

moved by the family's and friends' tears. He went to the tomb and told Lazarus to come out. To everyone's surprise, Lazarus came out, still wrapped in burial cloths. This miracle shows Jesus as the giver of eternal life ([John 11:25-26](#)). Ironically, this act also pushed the Jewish leaders to plan Jesus's death because many people believed in Jesus's miracles ([John 11:47-53; 12:10-11](#)).

Shortly after, the family invited Jesus to their home for a celebration meal. Mary poured a very expensive bottle of perfume on Jesus. When people criticized her for wasting it, Jesus defended her. He said her action anticipated his upcoming death ([John 12:1-8](#); see also [Matthew 26:6-13](#); [Mark 14:3-9](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 26:6-13](#); [Mark 14:3-9](#); [Luke 10:38-42](#); [John 11:1-44](#); [12:1-11](#), [17](#)

Mary, Mother of Jesus

Mary, the wife of Joseph, was the virgin mother of Jesus. Luke tells us that as a young girl in Nazareth, Mary was engaged to Joseph, a local carpenter. Before they married, an angel told her she would become pregnant by God's Spirit and give birth to the Son of God ([Luke 1:26-35](#)). Mary accepted this extraordinary message with simple faith, humbly agreeing to God's will ([Luke 1:38](#); see also [Luke 1:46-55](#)). Soon after, her relative Elizabeth confirmed the message, calling Mary the most blessed of all women ([Luke 1:39-45](#)). People saw Mary's miraculous bearing of the Son of God as a fulfillment of prophecy ([Isaiah 7:14](#)).

Jesus was born under unusual circumstances. Joseph took Mary to Bethlehem for a Roman census. The child was born in a stable because no other lodging was available ([Luke 2:1-7](#)). Later, Mary and Joseph fled to Egypt to protect the child from Herod's massacre of young boys in Bethlehem ([Matthew 2:13-18](#)). When they returned, they settled in Nazareth to raise their family ([Matthew 2:19-23](#)). After Jesus's birth, Mary likely had several other sons and daughters ([Matthew 13:55-56](#); [Mark 6:3](#)). Mary probably told Luke the details of Jesus's birth and the unusual events surrounding it (see [Luke 2:51](#)).

When Jesus was twelve, he stayed in the temple during a family trip to Jerusalem. Mary and Joseph scolded him for staying behind when they left, but they did not understand his response ([Luke 2:41-](#)

[51](#)). Early in Jesus's public ministry, Mary urged him to perform a miracle at a wedding in Cana ([John 2:1-11](#)). Later, when she and Jesus's brothers went to see him, he said that his disciples were his "real family" ([Matthew 12:46-50](#); [Mark 3:31-35](#); [Luke 8:19-21](#)).

When Jesus was hung on the cross, Mary was among the women watching (see [Mark 15:40, 47](#); [John 19:25](#)). As Jesus was dying, he asked John, the "disciple whom He loved," to care for Mary as his own mother ([John 19:26-27](#)). After Jesus died and came back to life, Mary was part of the believing community. She is mentioned among those praying together when the Holy Spirit came on the Day of Pentecost ([Acts 1:14](#)).

God chose Mary to bring his Son, the Savior, into the world. For all Christians, she serves as a model of humility and obedience to God's will.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 1:16](#), [18-25](#); [2:11](#), [13-23](#); [Luke 1:26-2:51](#); [John 19:25-27](#); [Acts 1:14](#)

Matthew (Levi)

Matthew worked as a tax collector for the Romans and later became one of Jesus' twelve closest followers (called apostles). Early tradition says he wrote the Gospel of Matthew.

He is called Matthew in all the lists of the apostles ([Matt 10:3](#); [Mark 3:18](#); [Luke 6:15](#); [Acts 1:13](#)). But, in two accounts of his calling, he is called Levi, his other name ([Mark 2:14-15](#); [Luke 5:27-29](#); compare [Matthew 9:9-10](#)). His father was Alphaeus ([Mark 2:14](#)). We do not know if he is the brother of James, the son of Alphaeus, since they are not said to be brothers in the lists of the apostles (as the other pairs of brothers are).

Jews who collected taxes for the Romans were often seen as sinners by other Jews. They made money by working for the occupying forces and practiced legal extortion. It is important that Jesus chose a tax collector to be one of his followers. When the Pharisees criticized Jesus for accepting Matthew's dinner invitation and eating with tax collectors and other sinners, Jesus used the moment to teach about compassion. He stressed that he came for sinners, not for those who saw themselves as righteous ([Matthew 9:9-13](#); [Mark 2:14-17](#); [Luke 5:27-32](#)). Matthew immediately followed Jesus' call, leaving everything behind

([Luke 5:28](#)). This suggests he never returned to tax collecting or his old life.

Matthew's Gospel was written for Jews and offers a Jewish view of Jesus's life and teachings. It includes topics important to those with a Jewish background. This Gospel was very popular in the early church, which is likely why it appears first in the New Testament.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 9:9-10](#); [10:3](#); [Mark 2:14-15](#); [3:18](#); [Luke 5:27-29](#); [6:15](#); [Acts 1:13](#)

Melchizedek

Melchizedek is a mysterious figure in the Bible. His name means "king of righteousness." He was a Canaanite priest and king. There is no record of his family, birth, or death.

Abraham met Melchizedek after defeating four Mesopotamian kings. The Mesopotamians had raided Sodom and Gomorrah and captured Abraham's nephew Lot ([Genesis 14:1-16](#)). When Abraham returned from battle, Melchizedek, king of Salem (which is Jerusalem; see [Psalm 76:2](#) and footnote there), was with the grateful kings of the Dead Sea confederacy. Melchizedek gave Abraham bread, wine, and his blessing, acting as a "priest of God Most High" ([Genesis 14:18](#)), the true God who created heaven and earth (see [Psalms 7:17](#); [47:2](#); [57:2](#); [78:56](#)). Melchizedek understood that Abraham worshiped the true God, and he praised God for giving victory to Abraham ([Genesis 14:19-20](#)). Abraham accepted Melchizedek's gifts and gave him a tithe, showing Melchizedek's importance (see [Hebrews 7:4-10](#)).

Genesis includes family histories for many people, but Melchizedek appears suddenly without one. He disappears just as quickly. Much later in Israel's history, King David may have thought about this when he said the Messiah (God's chosen one) is "a priest forever in the order of Melchizedek" ([Psalm 110:4](#); compare [Hebrews 7:15-25](#)). The book of Hebrews uses the idea that Melchizedek had no record of his family history to compare the temporary Levitical priesthood with the eternal priesthood of Jesus Christ. Hebrews also explains that Melchizedek is remembered as "like the Son of God" but was not the Son of God ([Hebrews 7:3](#)). His priesthood lasts forever as a model that comes before the Messiah's priesthood. Like Melchizedek,

but unlike the kings of Israel, Jesus is a king who also performs priestly roles.

Melchizedek, a royal priest, was greater than Levi, the ancestor of Israel's priests. Similarly, the Messiah, Jesus Christ, is a superior priest compared to Aaron's descendants. Jesus offers lasting forgiveness for sins and direct access to God ([Hebrews 7:24-28](#)). He leads his people through the Holy Spirit instead of the law ([Hebrews 8:7-13](#)). He remains forever as priest and king for those who trust in him.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 14:17-20](#); [Psalm 110:4](#); [Hebrews 5:6-10](#); [6:20-7:28](#)

Michal

Michal was King Saul's younger daughter ([1 Samuel 14:49](#)). She was King David's first wife ([18:17-27](#)). She was important in the change from Saul's rule to David's.

In the ancient Near East, leading families often arranged marriages for political reasons. Saul tried to trap David by promising him his older daughter, Merab, if he fought the Philistines. David, a strong warrior, was becoming a leader in Saul's kingdom. The king should have been glad to have such an ally, but he soon became jealous of David's success and suspicious of his goals.

Saul hoped David would die in battle, but the plan failed. Later, Saul found out that his younger daughter, Michal, loved David ([1 Samuel 18:20](#)). This gave him another chance to lure David into fighting the Philistines. This time, David agreed. When David returned victorious, Saul had to give David his daughter in marriage. This marriage alliance helped David when he was building his reputation with the northern tribes ([2 Samuel 3:13-16](#)).

Michal loved David early in their relationship and even tricked her father to help David escape a plan to kill him ([1 Samuel 19:11-17](#)). After David left Saul's court, Saul arranged another marriage for her ([1 Samuel 25:44](#)). But David later ended that marriage to bring her back ([2 Samuel 3:13-16](#)). Michal showed disrespect toward David when he danced happily before the ark of the covenant as it was brought into Jerusalem ([2 Samuel 6:16-23](#)). Because she showed disrespect toward King David, Michal was not able to have children.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 14:49; 18:17-30; 19:11-17; 2 Samuel 3:13-16; 6:16-23](#)

Moab and Ammon

The Moabites descended from Moab, the son of Lot and his oldest daughter ([Genesis 19:36-38](#)). They settled on the high plateau east of the Dead Sea. Most of Moab is gently rolling tableland divided by ravines. Even at its peak, ancient Moab covered a small area, but its location on the King's Highway was strategically important (see [Numbers 21:21-22; Judges 11:15-18](#)).

Before the Israelites passed through the Transjordan, the Moabites were under the control of Sihon, the Amorite king who ruled at Heshbon (see [Numbers 21:13, 26](#)). After Israel defeated Sihon, King Balak of Moab feared Israel might conquer his land, and Moab waged war against them ([Numbers 22:1-25:3; Joshua 24:9](#)). From that time onward, Moab and Israel were often in conflict ([Judges 3:12-30; 1 Samuel 14:47; 2 Samuel 8:2; 2 Kings 3](#)). But there were also times of peace between them ([Ruth 1:1-2](#)). A Moabite woman named Ruth showed great kindness to her Israelite mother-in-law, Naomi, who experienced many tragedies. Ruth became part of the family line that produced King David and Jesus.

The Ammonites were descendants of Ammon, the son of Lot's younger daughter ([Genesis 19:36-38](#)). They settled in the Transjordan area, northeast of the Dead Sea. When the Israelites arrived after leaving Egypt, God told them not to take Ammonite land, as it belonged to Lot's descendants ([Deuteronomy 2:18-19, 37](#)). The Ammonites helped the Moabites fight against Israel and were banned from joining the Lord's congregation for ten generations ([Deuteronomy 23:3-6; Nehemiah 13:1-2](#); see [Numbers 22:1-25:3](#)). After that, the Ammonites often fought with Israel ([Judges 10-11; 1 Samuel 11; 14:47; 1 Chronicles 20:1-3; 2 Chronicles 20:1-24](#)). But, David seemed to have allied with them for a while ([2 Samuel 17:27-29; 23:37](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Deuteronomy 23:3-6](#)

Moses

Moses was the first leader of Israel as a nation. God used Moses at a very important time in the history of his people. He was the prophet who received the law and mediated God's covenant (special agreement) with Israel at Mount Sinai ([Exodus 19:3-6](#)). He was also the first known writer of Scripture.

Moses was the younger brother of Miriam and Aaron. He was born in Egypt during a dangerous time ([Exodus 1:15-2:2](#)). The Egyptian pharaoh, fearing a rebellion, ordered all Hebrew boys to be killed at birth. Moses' mother, Jochebed, trusted God and placed her baby in a reed basket on the Nile River. Pharaoh's daughter discovered him and raised him as her own child in the palace ([Exodus 2:3-10](#)).

We do not know much about Moses' early life. Jewish tradition says he learned administration and military skills in Pharaoh's household. When he was about forty years old, he killed an Egyptian to save a Hebrew slave and then fled to Midian ([Exodus 2:11-15](#); see also [Acts 7:23-29](#)). There, he saved young women from harassment while they watered their flocks. Their father, Jethro, invited Moses to his home. Moses married one of the women, Zipporah, and started a family while caring for his father-in-law's flocks.

About forty years later, God appeared to Moses in a burning bush. He told Moses to return to Egypt to free his people from slavery ([Exodus 3:1-4:17](#)). Moses hesitated because he feared the Israelites would not accept him as their leader. So God revealed his covenant name, Yahweh, to Moses and chose Aaron to speak for Moses.

Moses and Aaron traveled to Egypt and confronted Pharaoh. Pharaoh stubbornly refused Moses' demand to free the Israelite slaves. Moses announced a series of plagues, which eventually convinced Pharaoh to let the Israelites go. After they left Egypt, Pharaoh changed his mind and chased them to the Red Sea. God helped the Israelites cross safely by dividing the waters. The Egyptian army was destroyed when the waters closed over them.

Moses led Israel to Mount Sinai, where he had met God at the burning bush. God revealed himself to Moses again on that mountain, giving him the law, including the Ten Commandments ([Exodus 20:1-23:19](#)). He also gave him instructions for building the tabernacle. When Moses came down from the mountain, he found the people had abandoned the

true God by worshipping a gold calf ([Exodus 32](#)). Moses broke the two tablets of the law and gathered the Levites to punish some offenders with death. After praying for the people, he received a new copy of the law and led them in building the tabernacle.

Moses led a complaining, rebellious, and distrustful group through the wilderness. Even his own brother and sister questioned his leadership, using his marriage to a Cushite woman as an excuse ([Numbers 12](#)). Moses responded with great humility, and God confirmed that Moses was his spokesperson and trusted friend.

Moses was a great man, but he was not perfect. When the people tested his patience by complaining about the lack of water, Moses did not follow God's instructions. He struck a rock instead of speaking to it ([Numbers 20:1-13](#)). His actions did not show God's holiness, and he suggested that he brought the water by his own power ([Numbers 20:10](#); compare [Psalms 106:32-33](#)). As a result, God did not allow him to enter the promised land.

Before he died, Moses gave a final sermon, which we know as the book of Deuteronomy. The first generation of Israelites who left Egypt had died in the wilderness. Moses spoke to a new generation. He renewed the covenant with them, reminded them of its terms, and encouraged them to obey it and serve only the Lord.

After delivering this sermon and before Israel entered Canaan, Moses climbed Pisgah Peak on Mount Nebo, where he died. "Since that time, no prophet has risen in Israel like Moses, whom the LORD knew face to face" ([Deuteronomy 34:10](#)). Only Jesus surpassed Moses as a mediator between God and humans ([Acts 3:17-26](#); [Hebrews 3](#)).

Moses is mentioned in the New Testament more than any other person from the Old Testament. He appeared at Jesus' transfiguration (when Jesus' appearance was changed). The New Testament emphasizes his role as a lawgiver and uses his experiences to show what life under the new covenant is like. Like Moses, Jesus was saved as a baby from a ruler's evil plans ([Matthew 2:13-18](#)). Jesus' new law in his Sermon on the Mount mirrors the law given at Sinai (see [Matthew 5-7](#)). It shows Jesus as the true interpreter of God's will. The letter to the Hebrews compares Christ with Moses. Paul's letter to the Galatians and the Gospel of John contrast Moses' law with a believer's new relationship with God (see [John 1:17](#); [Galatians 3:1-5](#); [Hebrews 3:5-6](#); [9:11-10:18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 2:1-22](#); [3:1-19:25](#); [20:19-21](#); [24:1-18](#); [31:18](#); [32:1-34:35](#); [39:42-43](#); [40:16](#); [Leviticus 8:1-36](#); [10:1-20](#); [24:10-23](#); [Numbers 7:1-11](#), [89](#); [9:1-14](#); [10:29-14:45](#); [15:32-36](#); [16:1-17:13](#); [20:1-29](#); [21:4-9](#); [25:1-5](#); [27:1-23](#); [31:1-32:33](#); [33:1-2](#); [Deuteronomy 1:1-5](#); [31:1-34:12](#); [1 Chronicles 23:13-17](#); [Psalms 77:20](#); [90:1-17](#); [103:7](#); [105:26-27](#); [106:32-33](#); [Mark 9:2-13](#); [Acts 7:17-44](#); [1 Corinthians 10:1-14](#); [2 Corinthians 3:7-18](#); [Galatians 3:19](#); [Hebrews 3:1-19](#); [8:5](#); [9:19-22](#); [11:23-28](#); [12:18-29](#)

Nebuchadnezzar II

King Nebuchadnezzar II ruled Babylon from 605 to 562 BC. He strengthened and expanded the empire of his father, Nabopolassar, who ruled from 626 to 605 BC. Besides the Bible, many ancient Babylonian documents describe Nebuchadnezzar's achievements.

In 626 BC, Babylon, like Judah, was under Assyrian control. That year, Nabopolassar started a revolt that changed the world. In 612 BC, the Babylonians captured Nineveh, the capital of Assyria, and defeated the Assyrians again at Haran in 609 BC. By this battle, Nabopolassar's son, Nebuchadnezzar, led the army. In 605 BC, Nebuchadnezzar defeated the remaining Assyrian army at Carchemish. This victory also forced the Egyptians back within their borders. In the same year, Nabopolassar died, and his son became king.

After winning at Carchemish in 605 BC, Nebuchadnezzar conquered Syria and nearby regions, including Judah. That year, he besieged Jerusalem for the first time ([2 Kings 24:1](#); [1:1-2](#)). He took some temple vessels and several young leaders from Judah, including Daniel and his three friends. Nebuchadnezzar captured Jerusalem again in 597 BC ([2 Kings 24:10-17](#)). He besieged Jerusalem in 588 BC and destroyed the city and temple in 586 BC, exiling most of the remaining people ([2 Kings 25:1-21](#)).

A detailed and interesting description of Nebuchadnezzar is found in the book of Daniel. He brought Daniel and his friends to Babylon to educate them in Babylonian ways. However, God used Daniel to teach Nebuchadnezzar about God. After being humbled for his great pride ([Daniel 4:28-33](#)), Nebuchadnezzar acknowledged the Lord's sovereignty and power ([Daniel 4:34-37](#)).

However, he probably never worshiped the true God exclusively.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Kings 24:1-25:30](#); [2 Chronicles 36:6-21](#); [Jeremiah 21:1-10](#); [22:24-27](#); [24:1](#); [25:1-14](#); [27:4-8](#); [28:14](#); [29:1-23](#); [32:1-5](#); [26-31](#); [34:1-3](#); [37:1](#); [39:1-14](#); [43:10-13](#); [46:2](#); [13-26](#); [49:28-33](#); [50:17](#); [51:34](#); [52:4-16](#); [28-30](#); [Ezekiel 26:7](#); [29:18-20](#); [30:10-11](#); [Daniel 1:1-4:37](#)

Nehemiah

Nehemiah was a strong leader of God's people in Judea after the exile to Babylon. He encouraged and strengthened God's people during difficult times.

Before Nehemiah went back to Judea, he served as the cup-bearer to the Persian king Artaxerxes I, who ruled from 465 to 424 BC. The cup-bearer brought wine to the king, tasting it first to ensure it was not poisoned. He was a trusted adviser. Nehemiah heard about Jerusalem's poor condition and felt compassion. He asked the king for permission to return to Judea to help his people. The king agreed and appointed him governor of Judea for twelve years to assist his fellow Jews and rebuild Jerusalem's walls ([Nehemiah 1:1-2:8](#)).

Nehemiah had the support of the Persian king, but he faced opposition from the local people. These people, of mixed heritage, were the ancestors of the New Testament Samaritans. Nehemiah showed great courage and skill as he helped the people of Judea rebuild the walls that protected Jerusalem.

Nehemiah had strong faith, shown by his prayers and his trust in divine guidance and help ([Nehemiah 1:4-11](#); [2:4](#), [8](#), [18](#), [20](#)). He also supported economic justice. He criticized some wealthy Judeans for taking advantage of a food shortage by charging high interest to their poorer relatives. He set an example of better behavior ([Nehemiah 5](#)).

Nehemiah cared deeply about the people's faithfulness. He personally confronted men who had married non-Jewish women ([Nehemiah 13:23-29](#)). He was committed to maintaining temple worship. He led the Jewish community to promise support for temple workers and to give offerings ([Nehemiah 10:32-39](#)). He also improved how they observed the Sabbath ([Nehemiah 13:15-22](#)).

Even though problems remained at the end of his time in Jerusalem (see [Nehemiah 13](#)), Nehemiah

was a strong leader. He helped the Jewish settlers regain their national and religious identity during a time of political and economic weakness.

Passages for Further Study

[Nehemiah 1:1-7:73](#); [8:9-10](#); [10:1-13:31](#)

Nero

Nero became the emperor of Rome in AD 54 at 17 years old after his mother poisoned her husband, the emperor Claudius. Nero loved receiving attention. He was known for his immoral behavior and wasteful spending. During the early years of his rule, he had two advisers who managed the empire well:

- Burrus was the Prefect of the Praetorian Guard (commander of the emperor's elite soldiers).
- Seneca was a famous philosopher who followed Stoicism, a philosophy that emphasizes reason, self-control, and virtue.

By the time Paul wrote to the Romans around AD 57, urging them to "submit himself to the governing authorities" as being "appointed by God" ([Romans 13:1](#)), Nero's immoral character was widely known.

Nero's worst actions occurred after he arranged his mother's murder in AD 59 (the same year Paul appealed to Caesar, [Acts 25:11](#)). In AD 62, he banished and then executed his wife, married his lover, and forced Burrus and Seneca to retire. In AD 64, a fire destroyed a large part of Rome. At the time, Nero was away from the city, but many believed the rumor that he had started the fire himself. Nero blamed Christians, accusing them of the crime. People saw Christians as hostile to society and deserving of punishment, even if few believed they started the fire. They were "convicted not so much of arson as of hatred of the human race" (Tacitus, *Annals* 15.44). The persecution of Christians in Rome was severe; it is likely that Peter and Paul were executed in Rome during this time.

In AD 66, a Jewish revolt began in Caesarea. Nero sent his general, Vespasian, to stop the revolt. Nero showed little interest in governing and spent two years performing in Greece. He left the governing to a Roman prefect. When he returned to Rome, governors in France, Spain, and Africa opposed

him. As a result, Nero killed himself in AD 68, saying, "What an artist dies with me!" He was the last and worst emperor from Julius Caesar's line. (See also the study notes on Revelation 13:3, 11, 18; 17:8, 10–11.)

Passages for Further Study

[Romans 13:1–7](#)

Nicodemus

Nicodemus was a respected Jewish Pharisee ([John 3:1](#)) and a prominent member of the high council. He seems to have become a follower of Jesus. The Gospel of John is the only place where he is mentioned.

Nicodemus was curious about Jesus' authority and miracles. So, Nicodemus visited Jesus secretly at night to learn more about him. Jesus told Nicodemus he must be born again to enter the kingdom of God ([John 3:1–8](#)). The Gospel does not reveal Nicodemus's response.

Later, in contrast to his colleagues on the Jewish high council, he argued strongly that Jesus deserved a fair trial ([John 7:50–51](#)). After Jesus died on the cross, he purchased seventy-five pounds of expensive perfumed ointment for the burial. He took it to the tomb and helped Joseph of Arimathea bury Jesus ([John 19:39–42](#)). Thus, Nicodemus seems to be a Pharisee who came to believe in Jesus and was willing to show his commitment publicly after Jesus' death.

Passages for Further Study

[John 3:1–9](#); [7:50](#); [19:39–42](#)

Noah

Noah was the son of Lamech and a descendant of Seth ([Genesis 5:3–29](#)). Lamech might have hoped that Noah, whose name means "rest" or "relief," would ease the curse of hard work on the land. Instead, God used Noah to help rid the world of evil.

God planned to destroy creation because of widespread human evil ([Genesis 6:1–7](#); see [Matthew 24:37–39](#); [Luke 17:26–27](#)), but he chose to save Noah ([Genesis 6:8](#)). God gave Noah, who was righteous and blameless ([Genesis 6:9](#)), detailed instructions to build the ark. Only Noah's family of eight and every kind of creature would be saved ([Genesis 6:14–8:19](#)). After the flood, Noah

and his family left the ark. Noah pleased God by building an altar and offering sacrifices. God promised never to flood the entire earth again or disrupt the seasons, despite human sin ([Genesis 8:20–9:17](#)).

Noah's sons were Shem, Ham, and Japheth. All the nations of the earth came from them ([Genesis 9:18–19](#)). When Noah got drunk from wine he made, his sons and their descendants were either cursed or blessed based on their actions towards him ([Genesis 9:20–27](#)). Noah lived for 950 years, including 350 years after the flood ([Genesis 9:28–29](#)). He is as an example of righteousness, obedience, courage, and faith (see [Ezekiel 14:12–20](#); [Hebrews 11:7](#); [2 Peter 2:5](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 5:28–10:1](#); [1 Chronicles 1:4](#); [Isaiah 54:9](#); [Ezekiel 14:12–20](#); [Matthew 24:37–38](#); [Luke 3:36](#); [Luke 17:26–27](#); [Hebrews 11:7](#); [1 Peter 3:20–21](#); [2 Peter 2:5](#)

Paul (Saul)

Paul was first an enemy who attacked the early Christians, but he later became one of Jesus Christ's most important followers. He became one of the greatest early Christian missionaries and spent his life telling non-Jewish people (gentiles) about Jesus. Paul influenced Christianity more than anyone else except Jesus. We learn about Paul from two main sources in the New Testament: the book of Acts, where Luke writes about how Paul became a Christian and what he did afterward, and the thirteen letters in the New Testament that are attributed to Paul.

Paul was born in the city of Tarsus to Jewish parents. His parents were Roman citizens, which allowed Paul to become a Roman citizen as well. He grew up in a traditional Jewish home. He worked as a tentmaker (or leatherworker). He studied in Jerusalem under a famous Jewish rabbi named Gamaliel and became a Pharisee. (The Pharisees were a Jewish religious group that carefully followed Jewish laws and oral traditions.) When Paul was a young man, he violently attacked and hurt Christians ([Acts 22:3–5](#)).

But then something happened that completely changed his life. The risen Jesus appeared to Paul ([Acts 9:3–6](#); [22:6–10](#)). After this experience, Paul became a follower of Jesus. He spent the rest of his life traveling around the Mediterranean Sea, telling

people that Jesus is the Savior and Lord (see [Galatians 1:11-16](#)). God specially chose Paul to teach non-Jewish people (gentiles) about Jesus. Because of Paul's hard work and dedication, many new churches started in different cities during the first century AD. Most of the letters Paul wrote in the New Testament were written to these churches.

Paul believed Jesus was the Jewish Messiah (the special leader God had promised to send to save his people). This made Paul different from other Jews of his time. His vision of Jesus helped him understand that through Jesus' death and resurrection believers can be made right with God and have their lives changed. Paul no longer, before, Paul thought people had to carefully follow all of Moses's laws to please God. But now he understood that being right with God was a gift that came through trusting in Jesus, who died to free people from sin ([Romans 4:1-8](#)). He was sure this gift was for everyone, both Jewish people and non-Jewish people.

Paul wrote thirteen letters in the New Testament that discuss many different topics. Some letters explain what Christians believe about salvation and about Jesus Christ (Romans, Galatians, Ephesians, Colossians). Other letters help solve problems in local churches (1 Corinthians). Some teach about how Christians should live together as a community (Ephesians, Colossians). In some letters, Paul explains why he has the authority to teach as an apostle (2 Corinthians, Galatians).

Paul also wrote letters to encourage Christians who were suffering because of their faith (Philippians, 1 Thessalonians). When people were teaching wrong things about Jesus, Paul wrote letters to correct these false teachings (Galatians, Colossians, 2 Thessalonians). He wrote some letters to individual people, giving them advice about their life and work for God (1-2 Timothy, Titus, Philemon).

Together, these thirteen letters teach us much about how the first Christians lived and what problems they faced. The letters also show us how Paul understood the Christian faith as being centered on God's gift of grace through Jesus.

Paul's letters focus strongly on Jesus Christ because Paul was completely devoted to him. Paul believed two main things:

27. People can only be saved by trusting in Jesus as their Savior ([Galatians 2:16](#)).
28. Believers should give every part of their life to serving Jesus as their Lord ([Romans 14:7-9](#); [2 Corinthians 5:15](#)).

Among New Testament writers, Paul explains salvation most clearly ([Romans 1-8](#)). He provides a detailed view of the Christian life and community. His letters also emphasize the Holy Spirit's power in the lives of believers ([Romans 8:9-13](#); [Galatians 5:16-25](#); compare [Galatians 2:20](#); [Colossians 1:27](#)). He encourages believers to keep growing to become more like Jesus ([Romans 8:30](#); [Ephesians 4:13, 15](#); [5:1-2](#)).

Believers should live a life of love ([1 Corinthians 13:1-13](#); [Ephesians 5:2](#)). They should fully submit to Jesus. More than any other New Testament writer, Paul shows us how and why Christians must base their lives on Jesus's gift of grace ([Romans 12:1-2](#)). For Paul, a believer's entire life (and the whole universe) centers on Jesus alone. Everything finds its true meaning only in relation to Jesus ([Colossians 1:15-20](#); [2:6-3:4](#)).

Luke's account of Paul's missionary life covers about thirty years. It starts with Paul's preaching in Damascus soon after he became a follower of Jesus (around AD 32 to 35). It ends with his imprisonment in Rome in AD 60 to 62. However, the Pastoral Letters (1 Timothy, 2 Timothy, and Titus) seem to be written later. Reliable traditions suggest Paul was released from prison around AD 62 and continued his missionary work. He was later arrested again. Paul had suffered many hardships throughout his life while sharing the good news about Jesus. Finally, he was killed during a time when the Roman emperor Nero was attacking and killing Christians (around AD 64 to 67).

Paul wanted to be like Jesus in every way (even in suffering and death). Paul died knowing that just as Jesus rose from death, he too would one day be raised to new life ([Philippians 3:10-11](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 7:58-8:3](#); [9:1-31](#); [11:25-30](#); [12:25-28:31](#); [Romans 1:1-16:27](#); [1 Corinthians 1:1-16:24](#); [2 Corinthians 1:1-13:14](#); [Galatians 1:1-6:18](#); [Ephesians 1:1-6:24](#); [Philippians 1:1-4:23](#); [Colossians 1:1-4:18](#); [1 Thessalonians 1:1-5:28](#); [2 Thessalonians 1:1-3:18](#); [1 Timothy 1:1-6:21](#); [2](#)

[Timothy 1:1-4:22](#); [Titus 1:1-3:15](#); [Philemon 1:1-25](#); [2 Peter 3:15-16](#)

Pharaoh

"Pharaoh" is an Egyptian word that means "great house." It refers to the royal palace and is also a title for the king of Egypt. During Joseph's time, the pharaoh viewed the Israelites favorably. Joseph interpreted the pharaoh's dreams, which led to his promotion as second-in-command in Egypt ([Genesis 41:1-44](#)). Pharaoh gave Joseph's family the best land in Egypt ([Genesis 45:16-20](#)). The Israelites grew in number and prospered there.

Two pharaohs are mentioned in the book of Exodus, and neither valued the Hebrew people (see [Exodus 1:8-10](#)). The first pharaoh ruled when Moses was born. He feared the Hebrews and ordered the killing of all Hebrew baby boys. Moses escaped death and was raised by Pharaoh's daughter in the palace. This pharaoh died after Moses fled from Egypt ([Exodus 2:23](#)).

A new pharaoh came to power, and Moses and Aaron later confronted him. This pharaoh was determined to keep the Israelites in Egypt. He stayed stubborn even when he saw God's power. The Bible describes his unwillingness to change (see [Exodus 8:32](#); [9:12](#), [34-35](#); compare [Romans 1:18-32](#)).

As king, the pharaoh represented the gods' rule over Egypt, giving him complete power. The plagues were God's attacks on Egypt's false gods (see [Exodus 12:12](#)). The final plague, the death of the firstborn, targeted Pharaoh's household. This decisive plague convinced Pharaoh to let Israel go. However, after the Israelites left, Pharaoh changed his mind and pursued them to the Red Sea. God's rescue of the defenseless Israelites and the destruction of the powerful Egyptians at the Red Sea is one of the most dramatic rescues in the Old Testament. The Lord revealed himself at the Red Sea as a warrior who fought for his people ([Exodus 15:3](#)).

The pharaohs in Exodus are not named, likely following Egyptian tradition. If the Israelites left Egypt in the 1400s BC, the pharaoh might have been Thutmose III, who ruled from around 1504 to 1450 BC. If it occurred in the 1200s BC, based on another timeline, the pharaoh might have been Rameses II, who ruled from around 1279 to 1213 BC.

Passages for Further Study

[Exodus 1:8-22](#); [2:14-15](#), [23](#); [5:1-15:21](#)

Philip

Philip was among the first to share the good news about Jesus with people outside Judea. Highly respected by early Christians, he was one of seven men selected to manage the food distribution program for needy believers in Jerusalem ([Acts 6:1-6](#)). Philip was a powerful and effective evangelist (preacher of the good news) through the Spirit's power.

After Stephen's death, Christians fled Jerusalem ([Acts 8:1-5](#)). Philip took the message of Christ to Samaria, a city with diverse people. There, he healed many and drove out evil spirits, and people eagerly accepted his message ([Acts 8:5-8](#)). Many, including a well-known sorcerer named Simon, were baptized ([Acts 8:9-13](#)).

An angel then guided Philip to travel southwest from Jerusalem toward Gaza ([Acts 8:26](#)). There, the Spirit led him to meet Ethiopia's treasurer, who was returning home from Jerusalem ([Acts 8:27-28](#)). The Ethiopian asked Philip to explain [Isaiah 53](#). Philip shared the message about Jesus ([Acts 8:30-35](#)) and baptized the man by the roadside ([8:36-38](#)). The Spirit of God then suddenly took Philip to Azotus ([Acts 8:39-40](#)). He preached the message there and traveled through coastal towns until reaching Caesarea, a large Roman city, where he likely settled ([Acts 8:40](#); [21:8-9](#)).

Many years later, Paul stayed overnight at Philip's home in Caesarea ([Acts 21:8](#)). By then, people knew Philip as Philip the Evangelist. He had four unmarried daughters, and all of them had the gift of prophecy ([Acts 21:9](#)).

Philip represents early Christian evangelists. The Holy Spirit empowered and guided them to confirm their message (see also [Acts 1:8](#); [3:4-8](#); [5:12-16](#); [6:8](#); [10:9-20](#); [13:2](#); [16:6-10](#); [19:11-12](#); [20:22-23](#)). Philip followed the Spirit's power and guidance, and God used him to spread the good news beyond Judea.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 6:5](#); [8:4-13](#), [26-40](#); [21:8-9](#)

Philippi

Philippi was a small village in Thrace until around 357 BC. Philip II of Macedon, Alexander the Great's father, conquered and rebuilt it. He named the village after himself, fortified it as a military base, and used the nearby gold mines. Philippi became famous worldwide in 42 BC. It was where Octavian and Mark Antony's imperial armies defeated Brutus and Cassius, Julius Caesar's assassins. This victory paved the way for the Roman Empire under Octavian Augustus.

Many veterans from the war of 42 BC and other battles settled in Philippi. When Paul visited the city, it still showed its Roman military heritage. Located on the Egnatian Way, it was an important stop on the major military road connecting the Adriatic Sea with the Aegean Sea. It had strong civic pride as a Roman colony, enjoying many privileges like tax exemption, and promoted Latin as its official language. Its government was based on the municipal constitution of Rome, and the people considered themselves Romans (see [Acts 16:21](#)).

Paul visited the city on his second missionary journey, and the book of Acts describes this visit in detail ([Acts 16:12-40](#)). The story often highlights the city's Roman background. Paul uses his Roman citizenship to defend himself successfully ([Acts 16:37-39](#)). The city leaders hold the Latin title *praetor*, translated as *stratēgos* in Greek ([Acts 16:20-22, 38](#)). There seems to have been a small Jewish community there.

The church started with Jewish women who believed and met outside the city because there was no synagogue. Later, they gathered in the home of a well-known woman convert named Lydia ([Acts 16:14-15, 40](#)). Luke likely stayed in Philippi when Paul left for Thessalonica ([Acts 16:12, 40](#)) and rejoined Paul at Philippi during Paul's third missionary journey several years later ([Acts 20:6](#)). Paul wrote a friendly letter to the church at Philippi during one of his imprisonments.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 16:12-40; 20:6; Philippians 1:1; 2:19-30; 4:2-3, 10-22; 1 Thessalonians 2:2](#)

Pontius Pilate

Pontius Pilate was the Roman governor of Judea from AD 26 to 36. He ordered Jesus to be crucified

(killed by nailing him on a cross) around AD 30 or 33.

As the governor of Judea, Pilate controlled the Roman forces and the temple, including its funds. He alone could order criminals to be punished with death (see [John 18:31](#)). Therefore, the Jewish authorities had to present charges to Pilate to have Jesus killed ([Mark 15:1-4](#)).

Pilate often acted harshly as governor. He took temple funds to build a thirty-five-mile aqueduct (water system) for Jerusalem, causing a major protest. In response, Pilate sent soldiers in disguise to the crowds. They beat the protesters to death with clubs (Josephus, *War* 2.9.4; *Antiquities* 18.3.2).

On another occasion, Pilate killed some Galileans while they were offering sacrifices at the temple ([Luke 13:1](#)). This incident might have caused tension with the Galilean ruler Herod Antipas. Pilate also attempted to bring images of Caesar into Jerusalem for worship. Later, in AD 36, Pilate killed pilgrims who followed a Samaritan false prophet. This event led to his removal by Emperor Tiberius in the same year.

Each Gospel describes Pilate's role in Jesus' death ([Matthew 27:11-26](#); [Mark 15:1:1-15](#); [Luke 23:1-25](#); [John 18:28-19:16](#); see also [Acts 3:13; 4:27; 13:28; 1 Timothy 6:13](#)). After questioning Jesus, Pilate believed Jesus did not deserve death. He tried to return the case to the Jewish authorities. When they refused, he attempted to send Jesus to Herod Antipas, who also declined. Pilate then tried to use a Roman tradition of releasing a prisoner during Passover.

Meanwhile, his wife was troubled by a dream about "that innocent man" ([Matthew 27:19](#)). However, the crowd became threatening, and Jewish leaders suggested Pilate was not taking Jesus' threat to Rome seriously. Pilate gave in to their pressure. He ordered Jesus to be whipped and crucified, with the title "King of the Jews" on a sign above him. Pilate did this only after strongly objecting and declaring himself innocent of this unjust death ([Matthew 27:18-25](#); [Mark 15:14](#); [Luke 23:4, 13-23](#); [John 18:38; 19:4-16](#)). Pilate's attitude shows that Jesus was not a threat to Rome, only to the Jewish leaders. This might have been important for later Christians, who were seen as a threat to Rome.

After Jesus died, Pilate allowed Joseph of Arimathea to take Jesus' body from the cross and bury it ([Matthew 27:57-61](#); [Mark 15:42-46](#); [Luke 23:50-53](#); [John 19:38-42](#)). Pilate also let the Jewish leaders seal the tomb to prevent anyone from

stealing the body or making false claims about Jesus rising from the dead ([Matthew 27:62-66](#)).

We do not know much about what happened to Pilate after he was removed as governor in AD 36. A church historian named Eusebius wrote that Pilate killed himself during the time when Caligula was the Roman emperor, from AD 37 to 41 (Eusebius, *Church History* 2.7).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 27:2, 11-26, 57-58, 62-65](#); [Mark 15:1-15, 43-45](#); [Luke 3:1; 13:1; 23:1-25, 52; 18:28-19:16; 19:31, 38](#); [Acts 3:13; 4:27; 13:28](#); [1 Timothy 6:13](#)

Priscilla and Aquila

Priscilla and Aquila were a Christian couple. Paul lived and worked with them in his early days in Corinth. Later, they were active in Christian ministry and helped Apollos truly understand Jesus. They often welcomed other Christians into their home.

Paul first met Priscilla and Aquila in Corinth. They had recently arrived because the Roman emperor Claudius Caesar had deported all Jews from Rome in AD 49. Paul got to know them, and since they were tentmakers (or possibly leatherworkers) like him, he lived and worked with them during his first year and a half in Corinth, from AD 50 to 52 ([Acts 18:1-3](#)).

When Paul left Corinth, he took Priscilla and Aquila with him and left them in Ephesus ([Acts 18:18-19](#)). He returned to Jerusalem and Antioch. Later, when Apollos came to Ephesus, he preached enthusiastically about Jesus in the synagogues. Priscilla and Aquila took him aside and explained the truth of Jesus more fully. With their help, Apollos became a powerful teacher who shared the good news about Jesus and defended the Christian faith ([Acts 18:24-28](#)).

Later, Paul mentions their home as a meeting place for Christians in Ephesus. He includes their greeting with his own to the church in Corinth ([1 Corinthians 16:19](#); see also [2 Timothy 4:19](#)). It seems they later returned to Rome, likely after Claudius's edict was relaxed. Paul sends his greetings to them first when he writes to the church in Rome ([Romans 16:3-5](#)). Their home there also became a meeting place. Paul clearly felt a strong friendship with them and valued their

work for Jesus. He calls them “my fellow workers in Christ Jesus” and mentions they risked their lives for him.

Priscilla and Aquila were early Christians who boldly shared their faith in their daily work. They actively served others as a married couple dedicated to Jesus. Priscilla's name often appears first, which was unusual then. This might indicate her strong role in their ministry and witness.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 18:1-3, 18-19, 24-28](#); [Romans 16:3-5](#); [1 Corinthians 16:19](#); [2 Timothy 4:19](#)

Rachel

Rachel was Laban's younger daughter. She was beautiful, and Jacob loved her more than his other wives. He first met her when he arrived at Paddan-aram in Haran. He helped her remove the stone from a well and watered her father's sheep ([Genesis 29:10](#)). Jacob agreed to work seven years for Laban to marry Rachel. The time felt like only a few days because he loved her so much.

Laban tricked Jacob into marrying Leah, his older and less attractive daughter, before allowing him to marry Rachel. Unlike Leah, Rachel could not have children at first ([Genesis 29:31; 30:1](#)). She gave her servant Bilhah to Jacob to have children for her, resulting in the births of Dan and Naphtali ([Genesis 30:3-8](#)). Eventually, Rachel became pregnant and gave birth to Joseph ([Genesis 30:22-24](#)). Soon after, Jacob left Haran with his wives, children, and possessions.

Between Bethel and Bethlehem, Rachel died while giving birth to Benjamin ([Genesis 35:16-20](#)). Jacob set up a pillar over her tomb, which remained a landmark even during Saul's time ([1 Samuel 10:2](#)). Rachel and Leah are respected for building up the house of Israel ([Ruth 4:11](#)). In [Jeremiah 31:15](#), Rachel is shown crying for her children taken into captivity. Matthew refers to Jeremiah's words during Herod's killing of male infants around Bethlehem shortly after Jesus's birth ([Matthew 2:16-18](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 29:6-30:24; 31:4-19, 31-35; 33:1-7; 35:16-20; 46:19-22; 48:7](#); [Ruth 4:11](#); [1 Samuel 10:2](#); [Jeremiah 31:15](#); [Matthew 2:18](#)

Rahab

Rahab was a prostitute and a woman of faith. She remains mysterious even hundreds of years after her brief role in Israel's history. She believed in Israel's God and helped two Israelite scouts who visited her house. Because of this, her life was spared when Israel captured Jericho.

Rahab's house was on the city wall, so Joshua's scouts went there when they entered Jericho. Rahab might have been both an innkeeper and a prostitute. Other documents from the Old Testament era mention women who were both innkeepers and prostitutes. If Rahab's house was an inn, it would have been a sensible place to go. Joshua's scouts could hope to avoid unwanted attention there.

Rahab's agreement with the scouts was a strong statement of faith in Yahweh, the God of Israel ([Joshua 2:8-21](#)). As a Canaanite woman, Rahab likely followed the fertility cult of Baal, the god of storms and rain, and his partner Asherah, the earth goddess. However, after hearing about Israel's progress toward her land, Rahab realized that Yahweh, the God of Israel, is "God in the heavens above and on the earth below" ([Joshua 2:11](#)).

After Joshua conquered Jericho, Rahab married Salmon from the tribe of Judah. She had a son named Boaz ([Ruth 4:21](#); [Matthew 1:5](#)). Rahab became Ruth's mother-in-law, another foreign woman who joined Israel. Rahab was also King David's great-great-grandmother. She is listed with Moses, David, Samson, and Samuel as an example of faith shown through good deeds ([Hebrews 11:31](#); [James 2:25](#)). Rahab is one of five women, including Mary, mentioned in Matthew's genealogy of Jesus, the human family tree of God's Son ([Matthew 1:5](#)). Rahab shows the wide reach of God's grace.

Passages for Further Study

[Joshua 2:1-21](#); [6:17](#), [22-25](#); [Matthew 1:5](#); [Hebrews 11:31](#); [James 2:25](#)

Rebekah

Rebekah was the wife of Isaac. [Genesis 24](#) tells the story of Abraham's servant who seeks a wife for Isaac. Following Abraham's instructions, he traveled to Haran in Aram-naharaim (northwest Mesopotamia) to find Abraham's relatives. Abraham did not want Isaac to marry a local

Canaanite. The servant prayed that the woman God chose for Isaac would offer him a drink and also water his camels ([Genesis 24:12-14](#)). This would confirm God's choice and show her character, hospitality, and work ethic.

God clearly answered his prayer by providing Rebekah, Bethuel's daughter ([Genesis 22:23; 25:20](#)). Bethuel was the son of Abraham's brother Nahor ([24:24](#)).

Abraham's servant explained how God guided him ([Genesis 24:34-49](#)). Rebekah's family saw it as God's work, but they hesitated to let her leave right away ([24:50-56](#)). However, Rebekah showed faith in God's plan and was ready to leave her family immediately to marry Isaac ([Genesis 24:57-58](#)). Rebekah's faith was greatly rewarded. The blessing her family gave her when she left came true when she had the next generation of God's chosen line with Isaac ([Genesis 24:59-60](#)).

Rebekah gave birth to twins, Esau and Jacob ([Genesis 25:20-26](#)). She favored Jacob, the younger son, because God told her he would be stronger and lead the two ([Genesis 25:23](#)). Rebekah helped Jacob take the firstborn's blessing by tricking Isaac ([Genesis 27:1-40](#)). She then arranged for Jacob to go to Haran to escape Esau's anger ([Genesis 27:41-28:5](#)). Rebekah's deceit caused a lasting division in the family. She likely never saw Jacob again. However, she was buried with Isaac in the family burial site ([Genesis 49:31](#)). She fulfilled God's plan as the mother of Jacob, the founding father of Israel.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 22:23](#); [Genesis 24:12-67](#); [Genesis 25:20-28](#); [Genesis 26:7-8](#), [35](#); [Genesis 27:5-17](#), [42-46](#); [Genesis 29:12](#); [Genesis 35:8](#); [Genesis 49:31](#); [Romans 9:10-13](#)

Rehoboam

Rehoboam was the son of Solomon and an Ammonite woman ([1 Kings 14:21](#)). He became king at forty-one. He ruled for seventeen years, from 931 to 913 BC. He is known for causing the division of Solomon's kingdom and for being the first king of Judah, the southern kingdom.

When Solomon died in 931 BC, Judah quickly made Rehoboam king. The ten northern tribes hesitated to support him. They wanted relief from Solomon's harsh policies (see [1 Kings 12:4](#); [2 Chronicles 10:4](#)). The king's older advisers suggested he agree to

their requests, but he ignored them. Instead, he listened to younger advisers who told him to be tougher than his father. The northern tribes rebelled and made Jeroboam, Solomon's former labor official, their king. Rehoboam went to war to control the north, but God sent the prophet Shemaiah to tell him it was useless. The split was God's judgment ([2 Chronicles 11:1-4](#)). So, Rehoboam returned to Judah and strengthened his borders ([2 Chronicles 11:5-12](#)).

When Jeroboam started a new false religion in the northern kingdom, priests and Levites moved south. They strengthened the spiritual life of the area and helped keep Judah stable ([2 Chronicles 11:13-17](#)). However, Rehoboam eventually turned to idol worship too. The people of Judah built high places and pagan sanctuaries across the land, adopting corrupt religious practices from nearby nations ([1 Kings 14:22-24](#)). God stopped supporting Rehoboam, leaving him vulnerable when King Shishak of Egypt attacked in 926 to 925 BC and took many valuable items from the temple ([1 Kings 14:25-26](#); [2 Chronicles 12:1-5](#)). Rehoboam then replaced Solomon's gold shields with bronze ones ([1 Kings 14:27](#)). This symbolized the loss of Judah's glory due to false worship.

Passages for Further Study

[1 Kings 12:1-24](#); [14:21-31](#); [2 Chronicles 9:31-12:16](#)

Roman Emperors

29. *Augustus* (Octavian) ruled from 27 BC to AD 14. He became the first Roman emperor after defeating Marc Antony at the Battle of Actium in 31 BC. He ruled wisely and managed the empire well. He received the title "Augustus" in 27 BC, starting the practice of emperor worship.

See [Luke 2:1](#).

30. *Tiberius* ruled from AD 14 to 37. He was Augustus's adopted son. Augustus chose Tiberius to be emperor after him. Tiberius was a wise and humble ruler who appointed Pontius Pilate as governor of Judea.

See [Luke 3:1](#); [John 19:12](#).

31. (Gaius) *Caligula* ruled from AD 37 to 41. He was the son of Augustus's general, Germanicus. He earned the nickname Caligula, meaning "Little Boot," due to his military clothing. He lost his ability to think clearly, spent all the kingdom's money foolishly, ruled cruelly over his people, and was killed by his enemies.
32. *Claudius* ruled from AD 41 to 54. He was Tiberius's nephew. He became emperor after the royal guards (Praetorian Guard) chose him following Caligula's death. He was a friend of Herod Agrippa I. Claudius stopped the persecution of Jews in Alexandria but later expelled Jews from Rome around AD 49. He married Nero's mother, Agrippina, who poisoned him.

See [Acts 18:2](#).

33. *Nero* ruled from AD 54 to 68. He was adopted by Claudius and became emperor after he died. He spent much time on personal pleasures. Paul appealed to him, instructing Roman Christians to obey Nero. Later, Nero murdered his wife and mother. He was the first to persecute Christians.

See [Acts 25:11](#); [Romans 13:1-7](#).

34. *Vespasian* ruled from AD 69 to 79. He was a successful general and the son of a tax collector. He started the Jewish War by invading Galilee in AD 67. As emperor, he improved Rome's finances, reorganized the armies, and was known for his fairness. He also began building the Colosseum. He died from an illness.
35. *Titus* ruled from AD 79 to 81. He was the son of Vespasian. He ended the Jewish War by destroying Jerusalem in AD 70. As emperor, he completed the Colosseum and provided disaster relief after Mount Vesuvius erupted in AD 79 and a fire occurred in Rome in AD 80. He died from a fever.

36. *Domitian* ruled from AD 81 to 96. He was the younger son of *Vespasian*. He grew up overshadowed by his brother *Titus* and desired power. As emperor, he was a capable administrator. He rebuilt damaged areas of Rome and declared himself a god. He imposed new taxes and, in his later years, harshly persecuted Christians. He was eventually killed by his enemies.

Passages for Further Study

[Revelation 17:9-11](#)

Rome

In the first century AD, Rome was a diverse city and a powerful empire. It brought peace and stability to the Mediterranean region.

The Founding and Early Growth of Rome

According to tradition, Rome was founded in 753 BC on the Tiber River in Italy by a Latin-speaking farming tribe. The earliest Senate was a group of chieftains.

Around 600 BC, the Etruscans from central Italy invaded Rome and became its rulers. They built many structures, including the forum. The forum became the city's social, commercial, and political center. They also built a temple for the Roman gods Jupiter, Juno, and Minerva. Roads now connected Rome to the Etruscans in the north, the Greek trading cities in the south, the sea to the west, and the inland highlands to the east.

The Roman Republic

When Rome's kings became too controlling, the Latin people rebelled. In 509 BC, Rome formed a "republic." Rome's republic was an oligarchy (a form of government in which a small number of people have power). Powerful families controlled the Senate (Rome's governing council). The small city-state gradually gained control of the region, spreading their influence across the Mediterranean. In 273 BC, they made a treaty with the Ptolemies of Egypt. They expanded into North Africa, defeating the rival city-state Carthage during the three Punic Wars from 264 to 146 BC, and then moved into Spain. Rome's many conquests brought great wealth.

As Italy expanded geographically, social changes occurred. Between 200 and 100 BC, wealthy landowners purchased land from small independent farmers. These farmers then moved to Rome, becoming landless and unemployed. Next to areas of great wealth and beautiful buildings, many poor people lived crowded together in terrible conditions. More and more people became unhappy with how Rome was being ruled, which made the government grow weaker.

The Beginning of the Empire: Julius and Octavian

During a time of social and political change, Julius Caesar aimed to centralize power. Senators who supported the old republic assassinated him in 44 BC. However, their plan failed. Julius's grandnephew and heir, Octavian, became a senator, consul, and commander-in-chief in 43 BC with Senate support. The Senate declared Julius a god in 42 BC. After Octavian defeated Mark Antony and Cleopatra in 31 BC and took control of Egypt, the Senate gave him the titles Augustus (meaning "illustrious") and Princeps (meaning "first citizen") in 27 BC. Octavian started calling himself "son of a god" because people had declared Julius Caesar to be a god after his death. While Rome kept its old forms of government, a new system had actually begun. Emperors were treated as divine (like gods).

Jesus and the Birth of the Church

"When the time had fully come, God sent his Son" ([Galatians 4:4](#)). The change into an empire brought peace and stability, known as *pax Romana* ("Roman peace"). This peace lasted into the 100s AD. Many have noted that Roman rule in the first century AD was ideal for spreading Christianity. The borders were secure, and the roads were good, making travel easy. Roman laws and customs protected citizens' rights (see, for example, [Acts 16:35-40](#); [22:24-29](#)). Judaism was protected, and Romans saw Christianity as a Jewish sect (see, for example, [Acts 25:13-19](#)). Thus, Romans often dismissed complaints against Christians based on religion (see, for example, [Acts 19:23-41](#)). Christians could freely share the good news about Jesus, and many people from various backgrounds became followers of Christ.

The Changing Status of Christianity

This favorable situation began to change during Nero's rule. Nero blamed Christians for the fire that

destroyed much of Rome in AD 64, leading to the first major persecution of Christians. The open persecution stopped in AD 66, but Christianity was no longer seen as a part of Judaism and lost its protected status. Later, the empire required people to burn incense to the emperor. Those who refused were usually Jews (who were protected) or Christians (who were not). As a result, from Domitian's time around AD 81 to 96 to Galerius's time, from AD 305 to 311, Christianity was officially illegal, punishable by death, and experienced different levels of persecution based on the leaders' enthusiasm. For over two hundred years, Rome shed "the blood of the saints and witnesses for Jesus" ([Revelation 17:6](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 2:10; 18:2; 19:21; 23:11; 28:14, 16; Romans 1:1-7, 15; 2 Timothy 1:17](#)

Ruth

The story of Ruth is about a kind and loyal woman. It shows how God's hidden guidance helps those who love Him ([Romans 8:28](#)). This story is part of the history leading to the Messiah (God's chosen one). It begins with sadness but ends happily.

Ruth lived during the chaotic time of the judges. She was a foreigner from Moab who married into an Israelite family from Bethlehem while they were in Moab. All the men in this family died in Moab, leaving three widows—Ruth, her mother-in-law Naomi, and her sister-in-law Orpah. When Naomi decided to return to Bethlehem, Ruth chose to go with her. Ruth's expression of love, loyalty, and faith in the Lord, who was Naomi's God, is unmatched ([Ruth 1:16-17](#)).

As Naomi expected, life in Bethlehem was hard for her and her daughter-in-law. Ruth took the initiative to solve their food problem by gleaning in the grain fields. This task was hard and risky ([Ruth 2:2](#)). She acted with modesty, grace, and courtesy, but also with determination, focus, and endurance.

With Naomi's encouragement, Ruth asked Boaz, a wealthy landowner who supported her gleaning, to be the family redeemer ([Ruth 3:1-9](#)). This included marriage. By doing this, Ruth showed great family loyalty ([Ruth 3:10](#)). Ruth's generous and diligent care for Naomi is a major theme in this book. Boaz responded to Ruth's proposal by calling her a virtuous woman ([Ruth 3:11](#)). She showed what it means to be a virtuous and capable wife (see

[Proverbs 31:10-31](#), which uses the same Hebrew phrase and is placed immediately before Ruth in the Hebrew Bible).

Boaz resolved the legal matters and then married Ruth. The book concludes with the birth of a baby boy, Obed. This ending reveals an important purpose of the book of Ruth. Obed became King David's grandfather. The New Testament mentions Ruth as one of only five women in the genealogy of Jesus Christ ([Matthew 1:5](#)). Ruth's everyday faithfulness had eternal significance as God fulfilled his purposes through her.

Passages for Further Study

[Ruth 1:4-4:13; Matthew 1:5](#)

Samaritans

Samaria was a region north of Judea. It was centered around the ancient city of Shechem, which is called Sychar in the New Testament. After the conquest of Israel in 722 BC, the cities of Samaria and Shechem were destroyed. People from across the Assyrian empire repopulated the area ([2 Kings 17:21-41](#)). These new residents brought many pagan practices, making the land's religious impurity well-known. Over time, the Jewish belief in one God became the main belief, but some things about how people practiced their faith changed. The Samaritans only accepted the Pentateuch (the first five books of the Old Testament) as Scripture. They also worshiped at a new temple on Mount Gerizim above Shechem.

The Samaritans and Jews had a long history of conflict, starting after the Jews returned from exile (see [Ezra 4:1-5; Nehemiah 4:1-23](#)). Alexander the Great and later Greek generals made Shechem an important base because they found anti-Jewish allies there. In 128 BC, the Jews destroyed Shechem and burned the Samaritan temple on Mount Gerizim. In AD 6 to 9, the Samaritans fought back by dishonoring the Jerusalem Temple. They scattered human bones from a cemetery during Passover. By the time of Jesus, tension between Judea and Samaria was still strong.

During Jesus's time, Jews avoided traveling through Samaria because they saw its people as hostile and impure. When Jesus traveled through Samaria and met a Samaritan woman, the tensions of this relationship were clear. Someone living in the first century would hardly expect Jesus and the woman to acknowledge each other, let alone speak.

Yet Jesus went beyond his ethnic identity and invited even a Samaritan woman with a bad reputation to believe.

Passages for Further Study

[2 Kings 17:21-41](#); [Ezra 4:1-5](#); [Nehemiah 4:1-23](#); [John 4:1-42](#)

Samson

Samson is a good example of God using someone for good even when they do wrong and do not care. Samson rescued Israel without trying or caring. He did not seem to care about his people, family, or God. He only cared about himself. Nonetheless, God placed him in situations where he harmed the Philistines, whom God allowed to oppress sinful Israel.

The first example of how God used Samson happened when he told his parents he wanted to marry a Philistine girl. This surprised his parents because Israelites were commanded not to marry the people of the land ([Deuteronomy 7:1-4](#); [Joshua 23:12-13](#); see also [2 Corinthians 6:14-18](#)). But Samson insisted even though his parents did not want him to marry a Philistine girl.

On his way to the wedding party, he took honey from a dead lion he had killed earlier. Samson was born a Nazirite, and Nazirites were strictly forbidden from touching a dead body ([Numbers 6:1-21](#)). But Samson did not care. He then created a riddle about the lion ([Judges 14:14](#)). He bet thirty young Philistine men that they could not solve the riddle. The Philistine men pressured his wife into revealing the answer. As a result, Samson became so angry that he killed thirty Philistine men and took their clothing to settle the bet. God used this self-serving hero to "begin the deliverance of Israel from the hand of the Philistines" ([Judges 13:5](#)).

The last important story of Samson's life tells about a woman named Delilah ([Judges 16:4-31](#)). She kept bothering Samson until he told her why he was so strong. By telling this secret, Samson broke his special promise to God, called the Nazirite vow. She cut his hair, allowing the Philistines to overpower him. They blinded him, tied him up, and forced him into hard labor.

While in captivity, Samson's hair began to grow back. During a Philistine celebration where they mocked him, he asked to be led to the two main pillars of their temple. He prayed to God for

strength to defeat the Philistines and end his own life. He then pulled the temple down, killing about 3,000 Philistines and himself. This act was not for his people or God, but to "pay back the Philistines for my two eyes" ([Judges 16:28](#)). Although it was part of God's plan, Samson's story leaves the reader wishing for a better savior.

Passages for Further Study

[Judges 13:1-16:31](#); [Hebrews 11:32](#)

Samuel

Samuel lived at the end of the time of the judges and helped lead Israel into the time of kings. He was Israel's last judge ([1 Samuel 7:6, 15-17](#)). Samuel is often seen as Israel's first prophet ([1 Samuel 3:20](#); [Acts 3:24](#); [13:20](#)). He served as a priest (see [1 Samuel 2:18](#)). He was a man of great faith ([Hebrews 11:32](#)).

Samuel was born because his mother Hannah prayed for him. Samuel's parents traveled each year from Ramah to the sanctuary at Shiloh ([1 Samuel 1:3](#)). At the sanctuary, Hannah, who could not have children, prayed for a son and promised to dedicate him to God for full-time service ([1 Samuel 1:9-11](#)). God answered her prayer, and Samuel was born ([1 Samuel 1:19-20](#)). When Samuel was old enough, Hannah took him to serve in the sanctuary with Eli, the high priest ([1 Samuel 1:24-28](#); [2:11](#)).

Eli's sons were wicked, but Samuel served the Lord. It soon became clear that God spoke more closely with Samuel than with Eli. God warned Samuel about the disaster coming to Eli's family ([1 Samuel 3:1-18](#)). This prophecy came true when the Philistines defeated Israel, killed Eli's sons, and took the ark of the covenant ([1 Samuel 4:1-22](#)). Later, under Samuel's leadership, the people repented for their idolatry (worship of false gods) and won an important battle against the Philistines ([1 Samuel 7:3-17](#)).

As Samuel grew older, it became clear he had the same weakness as Eli. Samuel's sons were evil ([1 Samuel 8:1-3](#)), and the people did not want them to lead the nation. Instead, they asked Samuel to appoint a king to lead them in battle against their enemies ([1 Samuel 8:4-5](#)). Samuel then anointed Saul as Israel's first king ([1 Samuel 9:1-10:24](#)).

The change from the time of the judges to having kings was difficult. Samuel, as a priest, prayed for

the people. As a prophet, he criticized Saul for being impatient and disobedient ([1 Samuel 13:5-14; 15:12-35](#)). When God rejected Saul as king, Samuel anointed David as God's chosen one ([1 Samuel 16:1-13](#)) and protected David from Saul ([19:18-24](#)).

Through prayer and determination, Samuel was a faithful leader ([Jeremiah 15:1; Hebrews 11:32](#)). He cared deeply for his people and bravely corrected kings and elders. He united Israel from tribal divisions into a strong nation and established a system of rule by kings. He likely wrote *The Record of Samuel the Seer* ([1 Chronicles 29:29](#)). He wrote down how a good king should rule ([1 Samuel 10:25](#)). When he died, all of Israel mourned him. He was buried in Ramah, his hometown ([1 Samuel 25:1](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 1:19-2:11; 3:1-4:1; 7:3-16:13; 19:18-24; 25:1; 28:1-25; Psalm 99:6; Jeremiah 15:1; Acts 3:24; 13:20; Hebrews 11:32](#)

Sarah

Sarah was both Abraham's wife and half-sister ([Genesis 11:29; 20:12](#)). She traveled with Abraham from Ur to Haran and then to Canaan ([Genesis 11:31; 12:5](#)). Twice, in Egypt and Gerar, Abraham asked Sarah to claim she was his sister, not his wife ([Genesis 12:10-20; 20:1-18](#)). He feared he might be killed because of her. Despite Abraham's lack of faith, God protected Sarah both times. This preserved the chosen line through which God promised to grow the Israelite nation ([Genesis 12:2; 17:19](#)).

Sarah is one of several women in the Bible who could not have children but miraculously had a son (see also [Genesis 30:22-24; 1 Samuel 1:9-20; 2 Kings 4:14-17; Luke 1:5-25](#)). After God made several promises, Sarah became pregnant and gave birth to Isaac. Sarah was ninety years old when this happened, showing God's power to do what seems impossible (compare [Genesis 17:17; 21:1-5](#)). Her name changed from Sarai to Sarah when God promised Isaac's birth ([Genesis 17:15-16](#)). Sarah is honored for her faith, even though she laughed at the prediction of Isaac's birth ([Genesis 18:10-15](#)). This happened twenty-five years after God's first promise to Abraham.

Sarah died at age 127 and was buried in the cave Abraham bought at Machpelah ([Genesis 23](#)). She is

known as the mother of the nation of Israel ([Isaiah 51:2](#)), just as Abraham is its father. She plays a key role in stories about Abraham's faith (see [Romans 4:19](#)). She symbolizes the freedom Christians have (as children of Sarah, the free woman) through faith in Christ (see [Galatians 4:21-31](#)). Peter uses her as an example of holy submission ([1 Peter 3:5-6](#)). The writer of Hebrews presents Sarah as an example of faith, for she believed in God's ability to keep his promises ([Hebrews 11:11-12](#)). Her life shows that God is faithful, even if his timing does not always match our expectations.

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 11:29-31; 12:10-20; 17:15-22; 18:9-15; 20:1-18; 21:1-13; 23:1-20; Isaiah 51:2; Romans 4:19; 9:6-9; Galatians 4:21-31; Hebrews 11:11-12; 1 Peter 3:6](#)

Satan

The book of Job mentions "the satan" as part of the heavenly court ([Job 1:6; 2:1](#)). (The heavenly court is a gathering in heaven where God meets with his angels.) In Hebrew, *satan* means an adversary or accuser in court (see [Job 1-2; Zechariah 3:1](#)). God sometimes uses angels as adversaries for righteous judgment and to oppose wrongdoers (for example, [Numbers 22:22, 32](#), where *satan* is often translated as "oppose"; see also [1 Kings 22:19-23](#)).

The Old Testament suggests the accuser has a demonic nature. But it was in the time between the Old and New Testaments that Satan became associated with the serpent in Eden (see *Wisdom of Solomon* 2:24). The New Testament calls the chief demon "Satan" ([Revelation 20:2](#)). The New Testament uses other names like:

- The devil ([Matthew 4:1-11](#))
- The tempter ([1 Thessalonians 3:5](#))
- Beelzebul, the prince of demons (see notes at [Matthew 12:24](#); [Luke 11:15](#))
- The evil one ([Matthew 13:19, 38](#); [1 John 2:13-14](#); [3:12](#); [5:18](#))
- Belial (see note at [2 Corinthians 6:15](#))
- The deceiver ([Revelation 12:9](#))
- A huge red dragon with seven heads ([Revelation 12:3, 9](#))
- Ancient serpent ([Revelation 20:2](#))
- A murderer and the father of lies ([John 8:44](#))

Satan did many evil things against God and people. He made David count his army when he should not have ([1 Chronicles 21:1](#); compare [2 Samuel 24:1](#)). Satan tried to tempt Jesus to do wrong and later helped Judas betray Jesus ([Mark 1:12-13](#); [John 13:27](#)). He wanted to test Peter's faith like he tested Job ([Luke 22:31](#)). He trapped people in sin ([Acts 26:17-18](#)). He used lies to oppose God's people ([1 Corinthians 7:5](#); [2 Corinthians 11:14](#)). In the end, God will defeat and imprison Satan, overcoming the adversary of God's people ([Revelation 12:9](#); [20:2, 10](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Numbers 22:22, 32](#); [1 Chronicles 21:1](#); [Job 1:6-2:7](#); [Zechariah 3:1-4](#); [Matthew 4:1-10](#); [12:24](#); [13:19, 38-39](#); [16:23](#); [Mark 1:13](#); [4:15](#); [Luke 4:6](#); [10:17-20](#); [11:15](#); [22:3, 31](#); [John 8:44](#); [12:31](#); [13:2, 27](#); [16:11](#); [Acts 13:9-10](#); [26:17-18](#); [Romans 16:20](#); [1 Corinthians 7:5](#); [2 Corinthians 2:10-11](#); [4:4](#); [6:15](#); [11:13-15](#); [1 Thessalonians 3:5](#); [2 Thessalonians 2:2-12](#); [Hebrews 2:14](#); [James 4:7](#); [1 Peter 5:8](#); [1 John 2:13-14](#); [3:12](#); [5:18](#); [Revelation 12:3, 9](#); [20:2, 10](#)

Saul

Saul was the first king of Israel. God and the people chose him, but he failed greatly due to his lack of confidence in himself and God. Saul was a complicated person. At times, we feel sorry for him because of his struggles. However, he often caused his own problems, bringing sadness and trouble to those close to him.

Saul was the son of a wealthy landowner. He became king without expecting or wanting to be one. The people wanted a king to lead them in battles, so they were pleased with Saul, who was taller than anyone else ([1 Samuel 10:23](#)). However, their military problems were overwhelming, and Saul lacked confidence as a military leader. Without the prophet Samuel and Saul's son Jonathan, Saul's reign might have ended in complete disaster.

Saul upset God by making quick promises without thinking during wartime ([1 Samuel 14:16-46](#)). He also performed sacrifices before battle instead of waiting for Samuel ([1 Samuel 13:7b-14](#)). He disobeyed God's command to destroy all the people and goods of the Amalekites ([1 Samuel 15:1-35](#)). Because of this, God decided to remove Saul from being king. God sent Samuel to choose David as the new king by pouring sacred oil on his head. Soon, Saul became very suspicious of David, who was his son's best friend and his most loyal servant. Saul became a cruel ruler who refused to give up control no matter what. He spent much time and effort trying to catch and kill David.

Saul was injured in a battle against the Philistines and then killed himself with his sword. His death was the result of God's judgment. Even though David had spent much time running from Saul, he honored the first king and his son Jonathan with a sincere speech ([2 Samuel 1:17-27](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 9:1-11:15](#); [13:1-31:13](#); [2 Samuel 1:1-27](#); [1 Chronicles 9:35-10:14](#)

Simon Peter

Simon Peter was the main leader among Jesus' twelve closest followers (called apostles). After Jesus' death, he became the main person to speak officially for early Christians in Jerusalem. He was the apostle mainly responsible for sharing the good news about Jesus with the Jews ([Galatians 2:7-8](#)).

The Hebrew name *Simeon* (spelled in English as "Simon") was likely his original name. *Cephas* is the transliteration of an Aramaic name that Jesus gave him, meaning "rock." In Greek, this is translated as *Petros* (English "Peter"; see [Matthew 16:17-18](#); [John 1:42](#)).

Bethsaida was Peter's hometown ([John 1:44](#)). Peter later moved to Capernaum. He was married

([1 Corinthians 9:5](#)). When Jesus visited Peter's home, he healed Peter's mother-in-law ([Matthew 8:14-15](#); [Mark 1:29-31](#); [Luke 4:38-39](#)).

Peter and his brother Andrew were fishermen. Jesus called them to be among his first disciples, along with their fishing partners, James and John ([Matthew 4:18-22](#); [Mark 1:16-20](#); see also [Luke 5:1-11](#); [John 1:35-51](#)). They were ordinary working men with little formal education ([Acts 4:13](#)).

Peter's name appears first on every list of the twelve apostles ([Matthew 10:2](#); [Mark 3:16](#); [Luke 6:14](#); [Acts 1:13](#)). Along with the brothers James and John, Peter was part of a close group of disciples who were with Jesus during special events. These included:

- the healing of Jairus's daughter ([Mark 5:37](#); [Luke 8:51](#)),
- Jesus' transfiguration when his appearance changed ([Matthew 17:1-2](#); [Mark 9:2](#); [Luke 9:28-29](#)), and
- Jesus' prayer in the garden of Gethsemane ([Matthew 26:37](#); [Mark 14:33](#)).

Peter was bold and impulsive ([Matthew 26:33](#); [Mark 14:29](#); [Luke 5:8](#); [22:33](#); [John 13:36-37](#); [21:7](#)). He was the first disciple to declare his belief in Jesus as God's chosen leader, the Messiah (or "Christ," [Matthew 16:15-16](#); [Mark 8:29](#); [Luke 9:20](#)). When Jesus talked about his upcoming death, Peter told him he was wrong. This did not match Peter's idea of the Messiah. Jesus strongly corrected Peter for this ([Matthew 16:21-23](#); [Mark 8:31-33](#)). However, Jesus said Peter would be a key person to help establish the church ([Matthew 16:18-19](#)).

Peter secretly entered the high priest's courtyard when they took Jesus there for questioning. People recognized Peter, partly because of his Galilean accent, and challenged him. He strongly denied knowing Jesus, just as Jesus had predicted, despite Peter's saying earlier that he would never do so ([Matthew 26:69-75](#); [Mark 14:66-72](#); [Luke 22:54-62](#)). Peter immediately felt deep remorse ([Matthew 26:33-35](#); [Mark 14:29-31](#); [Luke 22:31-34](#)).

After hearing about Jesus' resurrection, Peter was one of the first to run to the tomb to check if it was true ([John 20:3-7](#)). He seems to have been the first of the twelve apostles to whom the risen Jesus appeared ([Luke 24:33-34](#); [1 Corinthians 15:5](#)).

Much of Jesus' conversation in [John 21](#) was with Peter. Jesus encouraged him to "feed my lambs" ([John 21:15-17](#)).

After the Holy Spirit came on the Day of Pentecost ([Acts 2:1-13](#)), Peter became the main apostle to speak officially for the early Christians. From then on, as noted in [Acts 2:14-12:25](#), he played a key role in spreading the good news about Jesus in Judea.

- He boldly preached to the crowds ([Acts 2:14-41](#); [3:12-26](#))
- He healed people ([Acts 3:1-11](#); [5:12-16](#); [9:32-43](#))
- He spoke fearlessly to the authorities even when arrested ([Acts 4:1-20](#); [5:26-32](#))
- He miraculously escaped from prison twice ([Acts 5:18-25](#); [12:6-11](#))
- He also led in managing the quickly growing community of disciples ([Acts 5:3-11](#))

Peter was the first to share the good news about Jesus with non-Jews ([Acts 10:1-48](#); see [Matthew 16:18](#)). He played a key role in the Jerusalem council about non-Jewish converts. He argued that non-Jews should not have to follow the law of Moses. Instead, they should be accepted based on their faith in Jesus alone ([Acts 15:7-11](#)). Later, when visiting Antioch, he was inconsistent about this. Paul strongly criticized him for it ([Galatians 2:11-16](#)).

Peter brought his wife on some mission trips ([1 Corinthians 9:5](#)). We do not know many other details about Peter's later life and missionary work. He might have spent time in Corinth ([1 Corinthians 1:12](#); [3:22](#)). Early tradition says that Peter was crucified (killed by being nailed to a cross) in Rome during Nero's persecution of Christians in AD 64-65. Jesus said this would happen ([John 21:18-19](#)). The tradition that he was crucified upside-down is less certain.

Peter likely provided the information that Mark recorded in his Gospel. Mark probably learned this while helping Peter with his evangelistic work in Italy near the end of Peter's life. Tradition also says that Peter wrote 1 Peter (from Rome, referred to as "Babylon," [1 Peter 5:13](#)) and 2 Peter.

In the New Testament, Peter shows how Jesus forgives and restores those who have failed him. Jesus can still use them for his glory.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 4:18-20](#); [8:14](#); [10:2](#); [14:28-31](#); [15:15](#); [16:16-19](#); [22-23](#); [17:1-4](#); [24-27](#); [18:21](#); [19:27](#); [26:33-45](#); [58, 69-75](#); [Mark 1:16-18](#); [29-30](#); [36-37](#); [3:16](#); [5:37](#); [8:29-33](#); [9:2-6](#); [10:28](#); [11:21](#); [13:3-4](#); [14:29-42](#); [54](#); [66-72](#); [16:7-8](#); [Luke 4:38](#); [5:3-10](#); [6:14](#); [8:45](#); [51](#); [9:20](#); [28-33](#); [12:41](#); [18:28](#); [22:8](#); [31-34](#); [55-62](#); [24:12](#); [34](#); [John 1:40-42](#); [44](#); [6:8](#); [68](#); [13:6-10](#); [24](#); [36-38](#); [18:10-11](#); [15-18](#); [25-27](#); [20:2-6](#); [21:2-21](#); [Acts 1:1-12:25](#); [15:7-11](#); [Galatians 2:7-16](#); [1 Peter 1:1-5:14](#); [2 Peter 1:1-3:18](#)

Solomon

Solomon was the third king of Israel and the second son of David and Bathsheba ([2 Samuel 12:13-25](#)). He ruled for forty years, from 971 to 931 BC. When Solomon first became king he had strong faith in God. But, he ended his life worshiping idols, which led to the destruction of his kingdom.

As King David neared death, his son Adonijah tried to make himself king with support from the priest Abiathar and the general Joab ([1 Kings 1:1-53](#)). However, the kingdom was promised to Solomon ([1 Kings 1:17](#); see [2 Samuel 12:24-25](#); [1 Chronicles 28:4-7](#)). So, Bathsheba and the prophet Nathan told David about Adonijah's plans. David quickly arranged for Solomon to be officially declared king. Then David advised Solomon to follow God faithfully ([1 Kings 2:1-9](#)).

Solomon loved God and asked for his help. God offered him a gift, and Solomon chose wisdom over long life, riches, or fame. As a result, God granted Solomon all of these:

- He ruled wisely ([1 Kings 3:16-28](#)).
- He earned worldwide respect ([1 Kings 4:20-34](#)).
- He wrote the Song of Songs, most of Proverbs, and Ecclesiastes.

Rabbis (Jewish teachers) said these books reflect three stages of his life: "When a man is young he composes songs; when he grows older he makes sententious remarks; and when he becomes an old man he speaks of the vanity of things" (*Midrash Rabbah*). He also built the temple in Jerusalem and

his palace. He expanded trade and increased Israel's wealth and security. His wisdom and wealth were famous. The queen of Sheba visited Jerusalem to see him herself ([1 Kings 10:1-29](#)).

Solomon made many foreign alliances and married many foreign women, starting with the daughter of Egypt's pharaoh ([1 Kings 3:1](#)). His foreign wives led him away from God and toward idols. Later in life, Solomon, once wise, became very foolish under their influence. He worshiped false gods and treated his people badly. As a result, God used Jeroboam to take away a large part of Solomon's kingdom.

Even so, the New Testament remembers Solomon's wisdom and glory as the example by which others are judged. Jesus is the incarnation of God's wisdom (or God's wisdom in human form), which greatly exceeds Solomon's ([Matthew 12:42](#); [Luke 11:31](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 12:24-25](#); [1 Kings 1:1-11:43](#); [2 Chronicles 1:1-9:31](#); [Psalms 72:1-20](#); [127:1-5](#); [Proverbs 1:1](#); [Matthew 6:28-30](#); [12:42](#); [Luke 11:31](#); [12:27](#)

Stephen

Stephen was an early Christian whose life was an example for others to follow. Because he spoke bravely about his faith, the Jewish authorities arrested and killed him. He is known as the first Christian martyr. This means he was the first person to die for his faith in Jesus.

Stephen was one of seven men chosen to help distribute food to needy Christians in Jerusalem ([Acts 6:1-6](#)). Of the seven men chosen, Stephen was special because he was "full of faith and the Holy Spirit" ([Acts 6:5](#)). Showing God's grace and power in a special way, he performed miracles ([Acts 6:8](#)). He was brave in telling others about Jesus and was good at explaining and protecting Christian beliefs ([Acts 6:9-10](#)). Because he spoke so openly about Jesus, the Jewish leaders arrested him. They brought him before their ruling council (called the Sanhedrin) to question him ([Acts 6:9-12](#)).

Witnesses accused Stephen of speaking against the holy temple and the law of Moses ([Acts 6:13-14](#); compare [Mark 13:2](#); [John 2:19](#); [4:21](#)). Stephen defended himself before the Jewish ruling council ([Acts 7:1-53](#)). He talked about Israel's long history

of resisting God and his servants—first Moses and now the Prophet whom Moses had predicted ([Acts 7:51-53](#)). The Jewish authorities, angry at Stephen's bold claims, dragged him outside the city and stoned him to death ([Acts 7:54-60](#)). As he died, Stephen prayed for their forgiveness ([Acts 7:60](#)).

Stephen's brave testimony led to the first persecution of early Christians ([Acts 8:1-3](#)). This persecution caused the Good News to spread further as believers left Jerusalem and shared Jesus's message wherever they went ([Acts 8:4; 11:19-21](#)). After Stephen died for his faith, Christians began sharing the good news about Jesus beyond their homeland of Judea.

Stephen's life shows us that being a faithful Christian can lead to strong opposition. Speaking boldly for Jesus may be costly (see [Revelation 2:10, 13](#)), but nothing can stop the church from growing (see [Matthew 16:18; Acts 8:1-4](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 6:5-8:2; 11:19; 22:20](#)

The Amalekites

The Amalekites were the descendants of Amalek, a grandson of Esau ([Genesis 36:12; 1 Chronicles 1:36](#)). They were nomadic herdsman. Their territory in the Negev stretched from south of Beersheba to the southeast, reaching Elath and Ezion-geber. They likely raided west into the coastal plain, east into the Arabah wastelands, and possibly into Arabia.

The Amalekites were strong enemies of Israel. Israel first met the Amalekite warriors at Rephidim near Sinai when they attacked Israel ([Exodus 17:8-16](#)). Joshua and the Israelite army defeated the Amalekites in this battle. Later, the Amalekites stopped Israel's disobedient attempt to enter the promised land ([Numbers 14:39-45](#)).

Because of their hostility, Moses told Israel to destroy them ([Deuteronomy 25:17-19](#)). But the Amalekites continued to live in the Negev (see [Judges 3:12-14; 6:33; 1 Samuel 14:47-48; 15:1-35](#)). Those who survived remained enemies of Israel ([1 Samuel 27:8; 30:1-20; 2 Samuel 8:11-12; Psalm 83:1-8](#)). This remaining group was finally destroyed during King Hezekiah's reign ([1 Chronicles 4:42-43](#)). In the book of Esther, Haman, a descendant of King Agag, showed their hostility to the very end ([Esther 3](#); see [1 Samuel 15](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[1 Samuel 30:1-31](#)

The Greeks

Greek civilization was important in the ancient world. Greek culture greatly influenced the world during Jesus' birth and the writing of the New Testament.

Mycenaean Civilization (1450 to 1200 BC)

The Mycenaeans lived during the "heroic age," between 1450 and 1200 BC. This time was called the "heroic age" because it was when many famous Greek stories about heroes and great battles took place. These stories were later written down by Homer in his long poems. Their civilization was based in Mycenae, about thirty miles south of Corinth. The Mycenaeans traded widely and were very good at warfare. The Greek gods and myths known from later writings began in Mycenaean Greece. Mycenaean documents were written in Linear B, a script using syllables.

The Mycenaean civilization ended violently around 1200 BC due to Dorian Greek invaders. The following centuries are known as the "Greek Dark Ages." During this time, people stopped using Linear B script, and there are no written records.

Archaic Age, City-States (850-546 BC)

Eventually, Greek towns and villages organized into city-states that controlled large areas. During this time, Greeks began to cooperate more and shared a common identity. For example, they held the first Olympic Games in 776 BC.

As trade with nearby regions grew, the Greeks met the Phoenicians and adopted their writing system. Homer wrote the *Iliad* and *Odyssey*, which tell the stories and myths of the earlier Mycenaean civilization and their gods.

Many city-states depended on a powerful leaders called tyrants. These leaders helped keep order and peace in their cities. (The Greek word for these rulers is *tyrannos*.) Many areas wrote down their basic laws in a document called a constitution. This helped create clear rules for governing. In Athens, a small group of powerful people called the Areopagus Council ruled the city. This type of government was called an oligarchy. Later, a leader named Solon made important changes to how

Athens was governed. These changes helped Athens become a democracy, where citizens could vote and help make decisions.

Persian Wars, Classical Period (546 to 336 BC)

In 546 BC, Cyrus the Great of Persia took control of the Greek colonies in Asia Minor. Around 500 BC, Ionia tried to revolt but failed. This led Darius I to invade the Greek mainland in 492 BC. During the following wars, the Greeks were often outnumbered but used better skill and strategy to outmaneuver the Persians. In the Battle of Marathon in 490 BC, the Greeks defeated the Persians decisively. Ten years later, the Persian army under Xerxes crossed the Hellespont, and their large fleet entered Greek waters. The Persians burned Athens, but eventually, the Greeks won, and Xerxes withdrew.

After the Persian Wars ended, Athens was rebuilt and entered a period of greatness. Pericles led Athens to create a full democracy. They built large structures on the Acropolis. Athens became wealthy, and its sea power increased. This was a golden age of great achievements in art, thought, literature, and architecture.

Macedonian Empire, Hellenistic Civilization (336–146 BC)

Philip II of Macedon wanted to build an empire. He defeated Athens and Thebes in 338 BC and united Greece under the Macedonian Empire. After Philip's assassination in 336 BC, his son Alexander became the ruler. In 335 BC, Alexander destroyed Thebes, which had rebelled. He then quickly conquered Babylon and Persia (see [Daniel 8:5–8](#)). When Alexander died suddenly in 323 BC, his vast territories were divided among four generals. After some conflict, three major regions formed:

- 37. Egypt
- 38. Asia Minor, Syria, and Babylon
- 39. Macedonia and Achaia

Alexander's conquests spread Greek culture and influence across the ancient world. This clash between Greek culture and Judaism led to the Maccabean revolt in Judea in the 160s BC.

Roman Rule (168 BC to AD 330)

Rome began expanding its power into Greece in 198 BC. In 168 BC, Rome defeated the Macedonians

at the Battle of Pydna. By 148 BC, Rome had annexed Macedonia as a province. Then, in 146 BC, Rome destroyed Corinth. Greece was now firmly under Roman control and remained so until Emperor Constantine made Byzantium the capital of the Roman Empire in AD 330. Greek culture and Roman rule set the stage for the life of Jesus and the start of Christianity.

Passages for Further Study

[Daniel 8:5–8](#)

The Jewish High Council

The high council of Jewish leaders in Jerusalem had significant power in governing the Jewish people. It is traditionally called the Sanhedrin, a transliteration of the Greek word *sunedrion*, which means "council."

Jewish tradition says the Sanhedrin began when Moses chose seventy elders ([Numbers 11:16](#)). However, the earliest reference is in Josephus's *Antiquities* 12.3.3, from the time of Antiochus the Great, from 223 to 187 BC. The Sanhedrin likely started as a self-governing group of leaders under Persian rule (see [Ezra 5:5–10](#); [Nehemiah 2:16](#)). The priestly class, led by the high priest, controlled the high council. Roman rulers and the Pharisees influenced these priests to different extents. Herod the Great had a strong influence over the Sanhedrin's activities.

The Sanhedrin dealt with the legal and religious matters of Judaism. This included making judicial decisions not settled in smaller courts, known as "local sanhedrins," as well as managing criminal justice and arrests (see [Acts 9:1–2](#)). They also made official decisions on Jewish issues, although these decisions were not enforceable. The Sanhedrin could not execute criminals on its own ([John 18:31](#)), but it could do so with Roman approval.

The destruction of Jerusalem in AD 70 ended the high council's role as the leader of Judaism.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 26:57–68](#); [Mark 14:53–65](#); [15:1, 43](#); [Luke 22:66–71](#); [23:50–54](#); [John 11:47–53](#); [Acts 5:21–41](#); [6:11–8:1](#); [22:30–23:10](#); [23:26–30](#)

The Medes and Persians

The Medes (around 850–549 BC)

The early Medes did not leave written records. An inscription from Shalmaneser III of Assyria, who ruled from 858 to 824 BC, states that the Medes settled around Ecbatana, their capital, by the mid-800s BC. Ecbatana is now called Hamadan, Iran. The Medes were famous for breeding horses, so Shalmaneser raided their land to steal many fine horses. The Medes were under Assyrian control until the late 600s BC, when they became independent as Assyria weakened.

The Persians (around 700–549 BC)

Around 700 BC, Achaemenes founded a small Persian kingdom. He ruled from about 700 to 675 BC. His son, Teispes, ruled from 675 to 640 BC under the control of the Medes. The Medes were gathering forces to overthrow Assyria. However, problems for the Medes later freed Teispes from their control. Cambyses, who lived from 600 to 559 BC, was the son of Cyrus I and the grandson of Teispes. He married the daughter of the Median king, Astyages. Their son, Cyrus II, ruled Persia from 559 to 530 BC, starting in 559 BC.

The Medo-Persian Empire (549–331 BC)

Cyrus II defeated his grandfather, Astyages of Media, in 549 BC. He established Ecbatana in Media as his capital and set up his archives there (see [Ezra 6:1–5](#)). With a Persian father and a Median mother, Cyrus II represented the union of Media and Persia.

Cyrus showed kindness and generosity to defeated enemies. As a skilled military leader, he invaded Asia Minor, defeated Croesus, the king of Lydia, and controlled the Greek cities in the region. In 539 BC, he captured Babylon with almost no resistance and allowed exiled people to return home to rebuild their temples (see [Ezra 1:1–4](#)).

Cyrus's son, Cambyses II, conquered Egypt and ruled from 529 to 522 BC. However, the empire almost fell apart when he committed suicide. Darius I, the son of Hystaspes, who was the governor of Parthia, succeeded Cambyses and ruled from 521 to 486 BC. Darius was an energetic and efficient leader. He stopped internal revolts and organized the empire into twenty provinces.

Each province was under a governor, called a satrap or "protector of the kingdom." Inspectors, known as "the ears of the king," monitored the

satraps' actions. Darius moved the main capital of Persia to Persepolis, where they eventually built a large palace complex. Darius followed Zoroaster and worshiped Ahura Mazda, the main god of Zoroastrianism. Xerxes and Artaxerxes, who came after him, also followed this faith.

In the later years of Darius's rule, the Greeks defeated him at Marathon in 491 BC.

Darius's son, Khshayarsha, also known as Xerxes in Greek and Ahasuerus in Hebrew, succeeded him. During Xerxes's rule from 486 to 465 BC, the Greeks defeated the Persian fleet at Salamis in 480 BC.

People blame the end of the empire on the cowardice of Darius III, who ruled from 336 to 330 BC. Alexander the Great defeated his armies at Issus in 333 BC and finally at Gaugamela, near modern Erbil (Arbela), in 331 BC.

Persia and the Bible

The first mention of Persia in Israel's history is in [Isaiah 44:28–45:13](#). This prophecy was given to Isaiah over 150 years before Cyrus took Babylon and allowed the exiled Jews to return to Jerusalem. Other biblical references to Persia appear later in Old Testament history, such as in Ezra, Nehemiah, and Esther, and in the writings of prophets during and after the exile, like Daniel, Zephaniah, and Haggai. Scripture depicts Persia as a strict but mostly kind ruler that allowed the Jews to govern themselves and worship freely. However, the Judean community always remembered they were under foreign rule.

Passages for Further Study

[Ezra 4:5–7](#)

The Pharisees

The Pharisees were one of three major Jewish groups, along with the Sadducees and the Essenes. Unlike some other groups, the Pharisees did not try to gain political power. They began as part of a group called the *hasidim* (pious ones), who opposed mixing Greek culture and religion with Judaism in the second century BC.

The Pharisees tried to make the Old Testament law practical for Jews who wanted to obey it. They focused on both the written law of Moses (called *torah*) and oral traditions they said Moses passed down. Their goal was to protect the written law

from any violations. They were known for being devout and law-abiding.

The Pharisees shared their interpretations of the law orally from one generation to the next. This created a tradition about legal matters. They made the law relevant by creating specific guidelines for many situations. They believed that if everyone followed the law, the nation would be free of sin, and God would rule over all nations. This future goal motivated their focus on obedience. The Pharisees' traditions later became the rabbinic writings known as the *Mishnah* and the *Talmud*.

The Pharisees were a small group. But they had a lot of influence in Israel (see [Matthew 15:12-14](#); see also Josephus, *War* 2.8.14; *Antiquities* 13.10.5). They mainly influenced local synagogue communities. The Sadducees, however, were more influential in temple worship in Jerusalem and in the Sanhedrin, the Jewish high council.

Unlike the Sadducees, the Pharisees strongly believed in the resurrection of the dead (see [Acts 23:6-8](#)). After Jerusalem's destruction in AD 70, the Pharisees led and guided the people of Israel.

There was often conflict between Jesus and the Pharisees. Jesus accused them of hypocrisy (saying one thing but doing another) and prioritizing human rules over God's righteous standards. He opposed them because they led people away from God's plan for redemption. Although they were Israel's religious leaders, Jesus criticized them as hypocrites for distorting teachings and practices (see [Matthew 23](#)). The Pharisees opposed Jesus. They rejected him and his work mainly because he ignored their traditions (see, for example, [Matthew 15:1-20](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 3:7](#); [5:20](#); [9:10-14](#), [34](#); [12:1-14](#), [22-24](#), [38-40](#); [15:1-14](#); [16:1-12](#); [19:3](#); [21:45](#); [22:15](#), [34](#); [23:1-7](#), [13-31](#); [27:62-64](#); [Mark 2:23-25](#); [3:1-6](#); [7:1-13](#); [8:11-12](#); [12:13-17](#); [Luke 5:17-21](#), [29-32](#); [6:6-11](#); [7:28-30](#), [36-49](#); [11:37-54](#); [12:1-3](#); [13:31](#); [14:1-6](#); [15:1-2](#); [16:13-15](#); [17:20-21](#); [18:9-14](#); [19:38-40](#); [John 1:24-25](#); [3:1](#); [7:31-32](#), [45-52](#); [8:3-10](#), [13](#); [9:13-34](#), [40](#); [11:46-57](#); [12:17-19](#), [42](#); [18:3](#); [Acts 5:27-40](#); [15:5](#); [23:6-10](#); [26:4-5](#); [Philippians 3:5-7](#)

The Philistines

The Philistines lived on the southeast coastal plain of the Mediterranean. They were part of a larger group of sea travelers from the Aegean region, called the "Sea Peoples" by the Egyptians. Around 1200 BC, they settled on the lower coastal plain of Palestine and founded the five cities of:

40. Ashdod
41. Ashkelon
42. Ekron
43. Gaza
44. Gath

The Philistines were not simple; they were skilled in politics and technology. They were also strong warriors. Their iron technology made them nearly unbeatable enemies (see [1 Samuel 13:19-22](#)). They often fought the Israelites during the time of the judges, around 1350 to 1050 BC, and the early united monarchy, from about 1050 to 970 BC. Saul died fighting the Philistines ([1 Samuel 31:1-13](#)). However, David defeated them before he became king ([1 Samuel 18:20-30](#); [19:8](#); [23:1-5](#)) and continued to win against them during his rule ([2 Samuel 5:17-25](#); [8:1](#); [21:15-22](#)). Although the Philistines never fully disappeared while Israel existed as a nation ([2 Kings 18:8](#); [2 Chronicles 17:11](#); [21:16-17](#); [26:6-7](#); [28:18](#)), David effectively ended their threat.

In 1 Samuel, God used the Philistines to remove Eli's sinful family ([1 Samuel 4:10-22](#)). The Philistines also helped build David's military and political career ([1 Samuel 17:32-58](#); [18:20-30](#)). They distracted Saul when he was close to capturing David ([1 Samuel 23:26-28](#)). They gave David refuge from Saul ([1 Samuel 21:10-15](#); [27:1-12](#)). They stopped David from fighting his own people ([1 Samuel 29:1-11](#)). They killed Saul and his sons ([1 Samuel 31:1-13](#)). This made it possible for David to become king. However, in the end, the Philistines experienced God's judgment (see [Ezekiel 25:15-17](#); [Amos 1:6-8](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Genesis 10:13-14](#); [Judges 3:1-3](#); [Judges 13:1-16:31](#); [1 Samuel 5:1-6:18](#); [13:16-14:23](#); [21:10-15](#); [23:1-5](#), [26-28](#); [31:1-10](#); [2 Samuel 5:17-25](#); [8:1](#); [21:15-22](#); [2 Kings 18:8](#); [2 Chronicles 17:10-11](#); [21:16-17](#); [26:6-7](#); [28:18-19](#); [Isaiah 2:6](#); [Ezekiel 25:15-17](#); [Amos 1:6-8](#); [9:7](#)

The Roman Church

The exact details of how the church in Rome started are unclear. Rome had a large Jewish population, and some Jews from Rome were in Jerusalem during Pentecost when the church began ([Acts 2:10](#)). It is likely that some of these Jews became Christians and brought the message of Jesus to Rome. This led to the formation of a Christian community within the Roman synagogues.

It is doubtful that Peter started the Roman church or was in Rome when Paul wrote to the Roman Christians around AD 57. If Peter had been there, Paul would have mentioned him. Therefore, Paul wrote this letter to ensure the Roman church had guidance from an apostle. He did not write to the churches in Judea, which other apostles founded. Instead, he wrote to churches he founded, like those in Corinth and Galatia, or to those without direct apostolic guidance, like Colosse and Rome.

Eventually, non-Christian Jews in Rome likely forced Jewish Christians from the synagogues, as occurred in other places. By the time Paul wrote to the Roman church, they were meeting in separate house churches in private homes ([Romans 16:5, 10-11, 15](#)). There were no central buildings, and it is unclear if all believers in Rome gathered together.

When Claudius expelled the Jews from Rome around AD 49, Jewish Christians like Priscilla and Aquila also had to leave ([Acts 18:2](#)). Without the Jews, the Roman church likely became more Gentile. When the Jews returned, probably soon after Claudius died in AD 54, questions and possibly conflicts arose between Jewish and Gentile Christians. Paul may have written Romans to address these issues among the mixed group of Jews and Gentiles worshiping Christ in the same city.

As shown in [Romans 16](#), Paul already had many friends in the Roman church. In the spring of AD 60, about two years after writing Romans, Paul had the chance to go to Rome—a wish he had often expressed ([Acts 19:21](#); [Romans 1:13-15](#)). He stayed in Rome for two years, living in a house while being guarded by Roman soldiers and waiting for his first trial before Nero. During this time, Paul “boldly and freely... proclaimed the kingdom of God and taught about the Lord Jesus Christ” ([Acts 28:30-31](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 28:15-31](#); [Romans 1:13-15](#); [16:1-16](#)

The Sadducees

The Sadducees were an important Jewish group made up of priests and their families. They were different from the Pharisees, another Jewish group because the Pharisees were regular (“lay”) people who were not priests. They likely lived near Jerusalem and controlled the temple system ([Acts 4:1-2](#); [5:17](#)). These powerful and wealthy leaders (aristocrats) acted as mediators between Rome and Israel (see Josephus, *Antiquities* 13.10.6; *War* 2.10.5). They did not have much favor or influence with the people (Josephus, *Antiquities* 18.1.4).

The term *Sadducee* probably comes from *Zadok*, the high priest during the reigns of King David and King Solomon ([2 Samuel 8:17](#); [15:24](#); [1 Kings 1:8](#); [32-48](#)). Both words share the same Hebrew root. The earliest historical mention of the Sadducees is during the reign of John Hyrcanus, from 135 to 104 BC, a descendant of the Maccabees (Josephus, *Antiquities* 13.10.6), but they clearly existed earlier.

Their views about God often differ from those of the Pharisees ([Acts 23:8](#); see also [Acts 4:1-2](#)). The Sadducees gave primary authority to the Pentateuch. They rejected the oral tradition valued by the Pharisees. Unlike the Pharisees, the Sadducees did not believe in:

- the resurrection of the dead (see [Matthew 22:23-33](#)),
- angelic beings (see [Acts 23:8](#)), or
- the concept of final judgment.

The Pharisees, however, strongly believed in the resurrection (coming back to life after death). They even supported Paul against the Sadducees when he was on trial for disturbing the temple ([Acts 23:6-10](#)).

Despite their differences, the Pharisees and Sadducees united against Jesus. The Pharisees opposed Jesus because he did not follow their oral traditions. The Sadducees opposed him because he believed in angels, demons, final judgment, and resurrection.

When the temple was destroyed in AD 70, the Sadducees vanished. They did not leave any written records. All our knowledge about the Sadducees comes from their opponents, so we have a limited understanding of them.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 3:7; 16:1-12; 22:23-33; Mark 12:18-27; Luke 20:27-40; Acts 4:1-2; 5:17-18; 23:6-10](#)

The Son of Man

The Hebrew and Aramaic phrase “son of man” means “human being.” However, the figure in [Daniel 7:13-14](#), who is “like the Son of Man,” seems to be more than just a human being. His exact identity is not given, but his role is clear. The Most High has chosen him to rule an eternal and universal kingdom over all nations. He also represents his people, the holy people of the Most High. They will share in this son of man's kingdom over all peoples and nations (see [Daniel 7:22](#)).

The scene around this son of man shows his godly characteristics. The description “coming with the clouds of heaven” in [Daniel 7:13](#) tells us that he comes from heaven (compare [Psalm 68:4; 97:2; Nahum 1:3](#)). In the book of Exodus, the Lord God covered himself with a cloud ([Exodus 19:9](#)). God's people will rise into the clouds when Jesus returns ([1 Thessalonians 4:17](#)), just as he was taken into a cloud when he went up to heaven ([Acts 1:9](#)). This son of man receives his kingdom with humility and holiness, not by arrogantly seizing it. He is the opposite in character to the little horn ([Daniel 7:8](#)).

Jesus calls himself the Son of Man ([Matthew 24:30; 26:24; Mark 13:26; Luke 21:27; John 12:34](#); see also [Acts 7:56; Hebrews 2:6; Revelation 1:13; 14:14](#)). [Revelation 1:7](#) also connects this figure to Jesus Christ, who was pierced for our sins. God the Father gave Jesus all authority and power to rule everything and to reach people from all nations and kingdoms ([Daniel 7:14; Matthew 28:18; 19-20](#)). God called Abraham to create a great nation through his people and to bless all nations through him ([Genesis 12:1-3](#)). Jesus fulfilled this promise.

Passages for Further Study

[Daniel 7:13-14; Matthew 24:30; 26:24; Mark 13:26; Luke 21:27; John 12:34; Revelation 1:13; 14:14](#)

Thomas

Thomas was one of the twelve apostles ([Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13](#)). He is also known as “the Twin.” People remember him most for doubting that Jesus had risen from death.

We do not know how Jesus first met and called Thomas to be his disciple. The Gospel of John is the only source with personal accounts of Thomas. Thomas expressed his willingness to follow Jesus, even if it meant death ([John 11:16](#)). He openly told Jesus that he did not understand what he was saying ([John 14:5](#)). Thomas was also one of the seven disciples who went back to fishing after the resurrection, when Jesus appeared to them ([John 21:2](#)).

When Jesus first appeared to his disciples after his death, Thomas was not there. When Thomas heard the others' report, he did not believe it. He insisted he needed to see the crucifixion marks on Jesus's body and touch them himself ([John 20:19-25](#)). A week later, Jesus appeared to the disciples again and spoke directly to Thomas. He told Thomas to examine the nail and spear marks on his body and challenged him to believe, not doubt ([John 20:26-27](#)).

When Thomas saw Jesus alive again, he made one of the most important statements in the New Testament. He acknowledged Jesus as God by saying, “My Lord and my God!” ([John 20:28](#)). This moment shows most clearly in John's Gospel that Jesus is divine (God in human form).

Later traditions say Thomas worked as a missionary in the East, including Parthia (according to Eusebius), Persia (according to Jerome), and India (according to the *Acts of Thomas*). The Mar Thoma Church on India's west coast traces its origins to Thomas's early missionary work. The historical accuracy of these accounts is uncertain.

Some ancient books claim to be written by Thomas or to be about him, but these were written long after he died and are not considered reliable. These include:

- *The Acts of Thomas*
- *The Infancy Gospel of Thomas*
- *The Epistle to the Apostles*
- *The Apocalypse of Thomas*
- *The Book of Thomas the Athlete*
- *The Gospel of Thomas* (a Gnostic collection of Jesus's sayings)

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; John 11:16; John 14:5; John 20:24-29; John 21:2; Acts 1:13](#)

Timothy

Timothy traveled with Paul for much of Paul's missionary work. He was one of Paul's most loved and trusted helpers. Paul wrote two of his last letters to Timothy. At that time, Timothy was leading the church in Ephesus, near the end of Paul's life.

Timothy had a devout mother and grandmother ([2 Timothy 1:5](#)). The Christians in his hometown, Lystra, and nearby Iconium respected him highly. He joined Paul's missionary team during Paul's second journey. Paul mentions prophetic words that confirmed Timothy's selection. Timothy received a special gifting for service through the laying on of hands by the elders and Paul ([1 Timothy 1:18; 4:14; 2 Timothy 1:6](#)). To respect the Jews in the area, Paul had Timothy circumcised ([Acts 16:1-3](#)). Paul did this so that Timothy would be accepted by the Jewish people they wanted to teach about Jesus.

Over the next fifteen years, Paul sent Timothy on special missions to various churches ([Acts 19:22; 1 Corinthians 4:17; 16:10-11; Philippians 2:19-23; 1 Thessalonians 3:1-6; 1 Timothy 1:3](#); see also [Acts 17:14-15; 18:5](#)). Paul included Timothy's name as coauthor in several of his letters ([2 Corinthians 1:1; Philippians 1:1; Colossians 1:1; 1 Thessalonians 1:1; 2 Thessalonians 1:1; Philemon 1:1](#)). Paul clearly had a close relationship with Timothy and respected him greatly (see [Romans 16:21; 1 Corinthians 4:17; 1 Thessalonians 3:2; 1 Timothy 1:2; 6:11; 2 Timothy 1:2](#)). As Paul neared the end of his life and awaited his sentence in prison, he strongly desired to see Timothy ([2 Timothy 1:3-4](#)). Among all Paul's coworkers, Timothy is especially praised for his selfless concern for Jesus and his people ([Philippians 2:20-22](#)).

Paul's second letter to Timothy (2 Timothy) was written shortly before Paul was killed. In this letter, he encouraged Timothy to be bold and fearless in sharing the good news about Jesus. He urged Timothy to be willing to suffer for Jesus ([2 Timothy 1:8; 2:1-3; 4:1-2, 5](#)). This was a strong message for someone who might have been naturally timid (see [2 Timothy 1:6-7](#)). Timothy himself seems to have become a prisoner later on ([Hebrews 13:23](#)).

Timothy was a great example of serving Jesus in humble and unnoticed ways. He devoted himself selflessly and focused on the work of Jesus and his people wherever help was needed. He reminds

believers to become strong and effective witnesses for Jesus.

Passages for Further Study

[Acts 16:1-3; 17:14-15; 18:5; 19:22; 20:4; Romans 16:21; 1 Corinthians 4:17; 16:10-11; 2 Corinthians 1:1, 19; Philippians 1:1; 2:19-23; Colossians 1:1; 1 Thessalonians 1:1; 3:2-6; 2 Thessalonians 1:1; 1-2 Timothy; Philemon 1:1; Hebrews 13:23](#)

Titus

Titus was a non-Jewish person (gentile) who became a follower of Jesus. He served as one of Paul's trusted helpers. Paul wrote one of his last letters to Titus while Titus was helping to strengthen the church in Crete. Titus shows us how the good news about Jesus changed the lives of non-Jewish people. Many of them, like Titus, believed so strongly in this message that they left their homes to help Paul share the good news about Jesus with others.

We do not know anything about Titus's background or conversion. His name is not mentioned in Acts. We first hear of him as a non-Jewish believer who went with Paul and Barnabas to Jerusalem ([Galatians 2:1](#)). Importantly, Paul emphasized that Titus was not forced to be circumcised ([Galatians 2:3](#)).

Later, as a trusted member of Paul's team, Titus went on special assignments. Paul sent him to Corinth to handle a difficult situation, likely carrying the demanding letter mentioned in [2 Corinthians 2:4, 9; 7:8-9](#). This task needed someone who could be both gentle and strong as a leader. Titus seemed to have a stronger personality than Timothy (see [1 Corinthians 16:10-11; 2 Corinthians 7:13-15; 2 Timothy 1:6-7](#)).

Titus returned to Paul with good news ([2 Corinthians 7:6-7, 13-15](#)). After that, Paul sent him back to Corinth with the letter we call *2 Corinthians*. This letter encouraged the believers to finish their fundraising for the poor believers in Jerusalem. Titus eagerly accepted this task because he loved the Christians in Corinth ([2 Corinthians 7:15; 8:6, 16-17](#)). Paul described him as a person of integrity and similar to Paul himself ([2 Corinthians 8:23; 12:18](#)).

A few years later, after Paul's first trial in Rome and his release, he left Titus on the island of Crete to strengthen the church. While Titus was there, Paul

wrote a letter to him. In the letter, Paul gave advice on choosing church leaders and encouraged Titus to teach and show godly behavior. Paul then asked Titus to meet him at Nicopolis (in Achaia), where Paul planned to spend the winter ([Titus 3:12](#)). Later, shortly before Paul was executed in Rome, he wrote that Titus had gone to Dalmatia (along the Adriatic coast, northwest of modern-day Greece), likely for ministry work there ([2 Timothy 4:10](#)).

The church historian Eusebius mentions an early tradition that Titus settled on Crete and served as bishop there until he was very old (Eusebius, *Church History* 3.4.6).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Corinthians 2:13](#); [7:6](#), [13-14](#); [8:6](#), [16-17](#), [23](#); [12:18](#); [Galatians 2:1](#), [3](#); [2 Timothy 4:10](#); [Titus 1:4](#); [2:1](#)

Uzziah

Uzziah was the son of Amaziah and Jecoliah. He was king of Judah for 52 years, from 792 to 740 BC (see [2 Kings 14:21-22](#); [15:1-2](#); [2 Chronicles 26:1-3](#)). He began as co-ruler with his father at age sixteen for about 25 years. After his father was assassinated, Uzziah became the only ruler. He was a capable, energetic, and well-organized king who pleased the Lord for most of his reign.

During most of Uzziah's reign, Jeroboam II ruled the northern kingdom of Israel from 793 to 753 BC. Both kings were successful and brought a long period of prosperity to Israel and Judah. Uzziah successfully fought the Philistines and built many fortifications in Jerusalem and throughout Judah. He "sought the LORD" ([2 Chronicles 26:5](#)), and as long as he did, the Lord blessed him in all his efforts, and he prospered.

Several prophets were active during Uzziah's reign. Amos and Hosea prophesied during his life ([Hosea 1:1](#); [Amos 1:1](#)), though most of their messages were for the northern kingdom. The prophet Isaiah received his call the year Uzziah died ([Isaiah 1:1](#); [6:1](#)).

Uzziah became proud of his many successes, which led to his downfall ([2 Chronicles 26:16](#)). He acted like a priest, entered the holy area of the temple, and burned incense. The priests tried to stop him from sinning against the Lord, but he angrily ignored their warnings. Because of his disobedience, God gave Uzziah leprosy, and he had

to live the rest of his life in isolation. Uzziah was buried with his ancestors, but at a distance because of his leprosy ([2 Chronicles 26:23](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Kings 14:21-22](#); [15:1-7](#); [2 Chronicles 26:1-23](#); [Isaiah 1:1](#); [6:1](#); [Hosea 1:1](#); [Amos 1:1](#); [Zechariah 14:5](#)

Women Named Mary

The Gospels mention four other Marys besides the mother of Jesus:

45. *Mary Magdalene*, likely from Magdala in Galilee, was freed from demon possession by Jesus ([Mark 16:9](#)). She became a loyal follower and supported Jesus and his disciples financially ([Luke 8:1-3](#); see also [Matthew 27:55-56](#); [Mark 15:40-41](#)). She witnessed Jesus's death on the cross and his burial ([Matthew 27:55-61](#); [Mark 15:40-47](#); [John 19:25](#); compare [Luke 23:49](#), [55-56](#)). She went to the tomb early on Sunday morning with burial spices. She was among the first to hear that Jesus had risen from the dead ([Matthew 28:1-8](#); [Mark 16:1-8](#); [Luke 24:1-11](#), [22-24](#)). She was also the first to see the risen Jesus ([Matthew 28:9-10](#); [Mark 16:9-11](#); [John 20:1-2](#), [11-18](#)).
46. *Mary, the mother of James the younger* (not the apostle) and Joseph, was among the women present at Jesus's death on the cross and his burial ([Matthew 27:55-61](#); [Mark 15:40-47](#); see also [Luke 23:49](#), [55](#)). Like Mary Magdalene, she was among the first to hear that Jesus had risen from the dead ([Matthew 28:1-8](#); [Mark 16:1-8](#); [Luke 24:1-11](#)). She was also one of the first to see the risen Jesus ([Matthew 28:9-10](#)).

47. *Mary of Bethany* was Martha and Lazarus's sister. Jesus loved their family very much ([John 11:5](#)). Jesus praised Mary for wanting to learn from him ([Luke 10:38-42](#)). Soon after Jesus raised her brother from the dead ([John 11:32-45](#)), Mary anointed Jesus's feet with very expensive perfume. Jesus defended her when others said it was wasteful ([John 12:1-11](#); compare [Matthew 26:6-13](#); [Mark 14:3-9](#)).
48. *Mary, the wife of Clopas*, was among the women watching when Jesus died on the cross ([John 19:25](#)). The New Testament does not mention her husband, Clopas, elsewhere.

Passages for Further Study

[Matthew 27:55-61](#); [28:1](#); [Mark 15:40-47](#); [16:1-11](#); [Luke 8:2-3](#); [10:38-42](#); [24:1-10](#); [John 11:1-6](#), [17-24](#); [12:3-8](#); [19:25](#); [20:1-2](#), [11-18](#); [Acts 12:12](#)

Xerxes I

Xerxes I ruled the Persian Empire from 486 to 465 BC. He was the son and successor of Darius I (Hystaspes). Xerxes inherited a large empire from his father and his maternal grandfather, Cyrus II. However, he struggled to govern Persia well because of his cruelty and instability.

Early in Xerxes' reign, Egypt and Babylon rebelled against Persian rule. Xerxes stopped the rebellions and ensured tax revenues continued, but his harsh treatment of people started building his reputation for tyranny.

In the third year of his reign, Xerxes gathered his leaders to plan an invasion of Greece. (The book of Esther starts with a banquet likely related to this event.) In 480 BC, the famous but doomed attempt to conquer Greece began. Xerxes' harshness is shown in two stories recorded by Herodotus from this campaign. When Xerxes and his armies reached the Hellespont (the waterway connecting the Black Sea with the Mediterranean), his engineers built a bridge for crossing, but a storm destroyed it. Xerxes reacted by beheading the engineers and whipping the water before constructing a stronger bridge.

Later, after burning Athens, his fleet lost at Salamis. Xerxes executed the admiral of the Phoenician fleet, leading the Phoenicians and Egyptians to abandon him. Only the Persian fleet remained, and it was defeated by the Greeks in 479 BC. Xerxes had to retreat. Afterward, he focused on domestic matters, such as large building projects at Susa and Persepolis, and the events described in Esther.

Xerxes worried about assassins trying to kill him. According to [Esther 2:21-23](#), Mordecai stopped an assassination plot, which led to Xerxes publicly honoring him. After the Greeks defeated Xerxes again at the Battle of the Eurymedon in 466 BC, he lost territory. Another assassination plot by his court officials succeeded, and his reign ended shamefully in 465 BC.

Passages for Further Study

[Ezra 4:6](#); [Esther 1:1-22](#)

Zadok

Zadok was a key figure in the history of Israel's priesthood. He first appears in the story of 2 Samuel ([2 Samuel 8:17](#)). Some scholars think he might not have been born into a priestly family. However, the Bible states he was a descendant of Aaron ([1 Chronicles 6:1-15](#), [50-53](#)). Zadok's family line traces back to Eleazar, Aaron's son ([1 Chronicles 6:4-8](#); [24:3](#); [Ezra 7:2-5](#)). Zadok served with Abiathar, a descendant of Eli. Both were priests of Israel under King David ([2 Samuel 8:17](#); [20:25](#)).

When Absalom rebelled against King David, both Zadok and Abiathar proved their loyalty by bringing the Ark to him, ready to join him in exile ([2 Samuel 15:24-29](#)). However, David sent them back to Jerusalem to act as his spies.

Later, David's son Adonijah tried to take David's throne with Joab and Abiathar's help. Zadok wisely chose not to support him ([1 Kings 1:5-10](#)). Abiathar was banished ([1 Kings 2:26-27](#)), fulfilling the prophecy that Eli's family would lose the priesthood ([1 Samuel 2:27-36](#)). In this prophecy, God said, "I will raise up for Myself a faithful priest. He will do whatever is in My heart and mind. And I will build for him an enduring house, and he will walk before My anointed one for all time" ([1 Samuel 2:35](#)).

Zadok fulfilled the prophecy and became the only high priest under Solomon ([1 Kings 2:35](#)). Zadok's

descendants served as Israel's priests during the monarchy and beyond. Azariah, the chief priest during Hezekiah's reign, was from Zadok's line ([2 Chronicles 31:10](#)). During the exile to Babylon, Ezekiel's vision of the new temple mentions Zadok's priestly line ([Ezekiel 40:46](#); [43:19](#); [44:15](#); [48:11](#)). In the early 100s BC, when the Jews were under Seleucid rule, the high priesthood became a political position and was taken from Zadok's descendants. Because of Ezekiel's prophecies, Jewish groups, like those who created the Dead Sea Scrolls, continued to hope for the return of Zadok's line to the high priesthood. The New Testament states that Jesus Christ now holds the office of the high priest ([Hebrews 9:11](#); [10:12-25](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[2 Samuel 8:17](#); [15:23-37](#); [1 Kings 1:5-53](#); [2:35](#); [1 Chronicles 6:1-15](#), [50-53](#); [Ezra 7:2](#); [Ezekiel 40:46](#); [43:19](#); [44:15](#); [48:11](#)

Zerubbabel

Zerubbabel was a Jew born in Babylon. He moved to Judea in 538 BC as the governor of Jerusalem under Persian rule. Cyrus, the king of Persia, allowed Jews who were captured and exiled from Judah to return home. Zerubbabel led one of the first groups of these returning exiles.

Zerubbabel arrived in Judea to rebuild the temple, starting with the altar. Sacrifices could resume once the Holy Place was ready. However, local opposition halted construction. The Judeans lost focus until Haggai and Zechariah's preaching motivated them to restart. Zerubbabel played a key role in leading and organizing the rebuilding, which took about six years, from 520 to 515 BC.

Many people expected great things from Zerubbabel because he was from King David's family ([1 Chronicles 3:1-19](#)). Zechariah and Haggai describe Zerubbabel in messianic terms as the one chosen by God to restore Israel ([Haggai 2:21-23](#); [Zechariah 4:6-7](#)). However, Zerubbabel soon disappears from the biblical story without explanation. This early governor of Judea was not the Messiah. Instead, Jesus Christ, one of Zerubbabel's descendants, would take on that glorious role ([Matthew 1:12](#)).

Passages for Further Study

[Ezra 2:1-6:22](#); [Nehemiah 7:7](#); [Haggai 1:12-2:23](#); [Zechariah 4:1-14](#); [Matthew 1:12](#)